

Protagoras

ΠΡΟΤΑΓΟΡΑΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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309a

Co: Where are you coming from, Socrates? Or is it quite obvious that you have been pursuing the youthful glory of Alcibiades?¹ And yet, when I saw him just the other day, he seemed already like a fine man to me. Yes, a man he is, Socrates, since between ourselves, his beard is starting to grow.

ΕΤ. πόθεν, ὦ Σώκρατες, φαίνει; ἢ δῆλα δὴ ὅτι ἀπὸ κυνηγεσίου τοῦ περὶ τὴν Ἀλκιβιάδου ὥραν; καὶ μὴν μοι καὶ πρῶην ἰδόντι καλὸς μὲν ἐφαίνετο ἀνὴρ ἔτι, ἀνὴρ μέντοι, ὦ Σώκρατες, ὥς γ' ἐν αὐτοῖς ἡμῖν εἰρησθαι, καὶ πώγωνος ἤδη ὑποπιμπλάμενος. ΣΩ. εἴτα τί τοῦτο; οὐ σὺ μέντοι Ὀμήρου ἐπαινέτης εἶ,

309b

S: What of it? You are an admirer of Homer, aren't you? And he says that a youth is at his most gracious when the beard is starting to grow,² the stage Alcibiades is at now.

309b

Co: Well, what's going on these days? Is it him you are coming from? How is the young man disposed towards you?

309b

S: Nicely, in my opinion anyway, especially today, for he said a great deal to support and assist me. And yes indeed, I have just been with him. Yet I want to tell you something unusual, for although Alcibiades was present, I paid no attention to him, and indeed on occasion I forgot he was even there.

ὃς ἔφη χαριεστάτην ἤβην εἶναι τοῦ πρῶτον ὑπηνήτου, ἣν νῦν Ἀλκιβιάδης ἔχει; ΕΤ. τί οὖν τὰ νῦν; ἢ παρ' ἐκείνου φαίνει; καὶ πῶς πρὸς σε ὁ νεανίας διάκειται; ΣΩ. εἶ, ἔμοιγε ἔδοξεν, οὐχ ἥκιστα δὲ καὶ τῇ νῦν ἡμέρᾳ καὶ γὰρ πολλὰ ὑπὲρ ἐμοῦ εἶπε βοηθῶν ἐμοί, καὶ οὖν καὶ ἄρτι ἀπ' ἐκείνου ἔρχομαι. ἄτοπον μέντοι τί σοι ἐθέλω εἰπεῖν· παρόντος γὰρ ἐκείνου, οὔτε προσεῖχον τὸν νοῦν, ἐπελανθανόμην τε αὐτοῦ θαμά.

309c

Co: What could have happened to the two of you to bring this about? For surely you have not met someone else more beautiful, not in this city anyway?

309c

S: Yes, much more so.

309c

Co: What are you saying? Is he a citizen or a foreigner?

309c

S: A foreigner.

309c

Co: Where is he from?

309c

S: Abdera.³

309c

Co: And did you think this foreigner such a beauty that he appeared more beautiful to you than the son of Clinias?

309c

S: But how, blessed man, could the wisest avoid appearing more beautiful?

309c

Co: What is this, Socrates? Have you been in the company of some wise man just now?

ET. καὶ τί ἂν γεγονὸς εἴη περὶ σὲ κάκεῖνον τοσοῦτον πρᾶγμα; οὐ γὰρ δήπου τινὶ καλλίονι ἐνέτυχες ἄλλω ἔν γε τῇδε τῇ πόλει. ΣΩ. καὶ πολὺ γε. ET. τί φῆς; ἀστῶ ἢ ξένω; ΣΩ. ξένω. ET. ποδαπῶ; ΣΩ. Ἀβδηρίτῃ. ET. καὶ οὕτω καλὸς τις ὁ ξένος ἔδοξέν σοι εἶναι, ὥστε τοῦ Κλεινίου ὑέος καλλίων σοι φανῆναι; ΣΩ. πῶς δ' οὐ μέλλει, ὦ μακάριε, τὸ σοφώτατον κάλλιον φαίνεσθαι; ET. ἀλλ' ἢ σοφῶ τινι ἡμῖν, ὦ Σώκρατες, ἐντυχὼν πάρει;

309d

S: Yes, the wisest of them all nowadays, presumably, provided you think the wisest of them all is Protagoras.⁴

309d

Co: What are you saying? Is Protagoras in town?

309d

S: Yes, he has been here for two days already.

309d

Co: So have you just come from being with the man?

ΣΩ. σοφωτάτω μὲν οὖν δήπου τῶν γε νῦν, εἴ σοι δοκεῖ σοφώτατος εἶναι Πρωταγόρας, ΕΤ. ὦ τί λέγεις; Πρωταγόρας ἐπιδεδήμηκεν; ΣΩ. τρίτην γε ἡδὴ ἡμέραν. ΕΤ. καὶ ἄρτι ἄρα ἐκείνῳ συγγεγονῶς ἦκεις;

310a

S: I have indeed, and I said and heard a great deal.

310a

Co: Well, why don't you recount the meeting to us, if there is no reason not to do so? Sit down here. This slave will give you his seat.

310a

S: Yes, of course. I would be grateful if you would listen to me.

310a

Co: And we would also be grateful to you, if you would speak.

310a

S: Then, the gratitude will be mutual. Anyway, listen.

ΣΩ. πάνυ γε, πολλὰ καὶ εἰπὼν καὶ ἀκούσας. ΕΤ. τί οὖν οὐ διηγήσω ἡμῖν τὴν συνουσίαν, εἰ μή σέ τι κωλύει, καθεζόμενος ἐνταυθί, ἐξαναστήσας τὸν παῖδα τουτονί; ΣΩ. πάνυ μὲν οὖν· καὶ χάριν γε εἶσομαι, ἐὰν ἀκούητε. ΕΤ. καὶ μὴν καὶ ἡμεῖς σοί, ἐὰν λέγῃς. ΣΩ. διπλῇ ἂν εἴῃ ἡ χάρις. ἀλλ' οὖν ἀκούετε. τῆς γὰρ παρελθούσης νυκτὸς ταυτησί, ἔτι βαθέος ὄρθρου, Ἴπποκράτης, ὁ Ἀπολλοδώρου υἱὸς Φάσωνος δὲ ἀδελφός, τὴν

310b

Last night, just before daybreak, Hippocrates, the son of Apollodorus and brother of Phason,⁵ banged on my door very forcibly with his stick, and when someone opened it for him he rushed straight in, shouting in a loud voice, “Socrates, are you awake or asleep?”

310b

I recognised his voice and said, “Hippocrates, this man! I hope you are not bearing some bad news.”

310b

“Not at all,” he said. “The news is good.”

310b

“It would be nice if you would tell me what it is,” I said, “and the reason you have called at this hour.”

310b

He stood beside me and said, “Protagoras has arrived.”

310b

“The day before yesterday,” I said. “Have you just found this out?”

310b

“Yes, by the gods,” he said, “last evening in fact.”

θύραν τῇ βακτηρίᾳ πάνυ σφόδρα ἔκρουε, καὶ ἐπειδὴ αὐτῷ ἀνέωξέ τις, εὐθὺς εἴσω ἦει ἐπειγόμενος, καὶ τῇ φωνῇ μέγα λέγων, ὦ Σώκρατες, ἔφη, ἐγρήγορας ἢ καθεύδεις; καὶ ἐγὼ τὴν φωνὴν γνοὺς αὐτοῦ, Ἴπποκράτης, ἔφην, οὗτος· μή τι νεώτερον ἀγγέλλεις; οὐδέν γ', ἢ δ' ὅς, εἰ μὴ ἀγαθὰ γε. εὖ ἂν λέγοις, ἦν δ' ἐγὼ ἔστι δὲ τί, καὶ τοῦ ἔνεκα τηνικάδε ἀφίκου; Πρωταγόρας, ἔφη, ἦκει, στὰς παρ' ἐμοί. πρῶην, ἔφην ἐγὼ· σὺ δὲ ἄρτι πέπυσαι; νῆ τοὺς θεοῦς, ἔφη, ἐσπέρας γε.

310c

And at the same time he felt around the top of the couch, sat down at my feet and said, “Yes. Last evening I got back very late from Oenoe, for my slave, Satyrus, had run away. And indeed I intended to tell you that I would be going after him, but something else made me forget to do so.

καὶ ἅμα ἐπιψηλαφήσας τοῦ σκίμποδος ἐκαθέζετο παρὰ τοὺς πόδας μου, καὶ εἶπεν· ἐσπέρας δῆτα, μάλα γε ὁπὲ ἀφικόμενος ἐξ Οἰνός. ὁ γάρ τοι παῖς με ὁ Σάτυρος ἀπέδρα· καὶ δῆτα μέλλων σοι φράζειν ὅτι διωξοίμην αὐτόν, ὑπὸ τινος ἄλλου ἐπελαθόμην. ἐπειδὴ δὲ ἦλθον καὶ δεδειπνηκότες ἡμεν καὶ ἐμέλλομεν ἀναπαύεσθαι, τότε μοι ἀδελφὸς λέγει ὅτι ἦκει Πρωταγόρας, καὶ ἔτι μὲν ἐνεχέρησα εὐθὺς παρὰ σὲ ἵεναι, ἔπειτά μοι λίαν πόρρω ἔδοξε τῶν νυκτῶν εἶναι· ἐπειδὴ

310d

It was when I was back home and we had eaten supper and were about to get some rest that my brother told me that Protagoras had arrived. I was even prepared to come to you right away, but then I thought it was much too late at night. Yet as soon as the sleep had relieved me of the fatigue, I got up immediately and made my way here.”

310d

Being aware of his impetuosity and excitability, I asked, “Well, what has that to do with you? Protagoras has not done you some injustice, has he?”

310d

He laughed and said, “By the gods, he has, Socrates. He is the only wise man, and he will not make me wise.”

310d

“Oh yes, by Zeus,” I said. “If you pay good money to him, and persuade him, he will make you wise too.”

δὲ τάχιστα με ἐκ τοῦ κόπου ὁ ὕπνος ἀνῆκεν, εὐθὺς ἀναστὰς οὕτω δεῦρο ἐπορευόμεν. καὶ ἐγὼ γινώσκων αὐτοῦ τὴν ἀνδρείαν καὶ τὴν πτοίησιν, τί οὖν σοι, ἦν δ' ἐγώ, τοῦτο; μῶν τί σε ἀδικεῖ Πρωταγόρας; καὶ ὃς γελάσας, νῆ τοὺς θεοὺς, ἔφη, ὦ Σώκρατες, ὅτι γε μόνος ἐστὶ σοφός, ἐμὲ δὲ οὐ ποιεῖ. ἀλλὰ ναὶ μὰ Δία, ἔφην ἐγώ, ἂν αὐτῷ διδῶς ἀργύριον καὶ πείθῃς ἐκεῖνον, ποιήσει καὶ σὲ σοφόν. εἰ γάρ, ἦ δ' ὅς, ὦ Ζεῦ καὶ θεοί, ἐν

310e

“By Zeus and the gods,” he replied, “would that it all came down to this, since in that case I would begrudge him nothing belonging to myself or even my friends. Yes, this is the very reason I came to you, to get you to discuss this with him on my behalf. For as well as being too young, I have never even seen Protagoras before, or heard him at all either, since I was still a child when he visited the city before. Anyway, Socrates, everyone praises the man and proclaims him the wisest of speakers. So why don’t we make our way to him now so that we may be sure of finding him indoors? I hear that he is staying with Callias,⁶ the son of Hipponicus, so let us go.”

τούτῳ εἴη ὥς οὔτ' ἂν τῶν ἐμῶν ἐπιλίποισι οὐδὲν οὔτε τῶν φίλων· ἀλλ' αὐτὰ ταῦτα καὶ νῦν ἤκω παρὰ σέ, ἵνα ὑπὲρ ἐμοῦ διαλεχθῇς αὐτῷ. ἐγὼ γὰρ ἅμα μὲν καὶ νεώτερός εἰμι, ἅμα δὲ οὐδὲ ἐώρακα Πρωταγόραν πώποτε οὐδ' ἀκήκοα οὐδέν· ἔτι γὰρ παῖς ἦ ὅτε τὸ πρότερον ἐπεδήμησε. ΣΩ. ἀλλὰ γάρ, ὦ Σώκратες, πάντες τὸν ἄνδρα ἐπαινοῦσιν καὶ φασιν σοφώτατον εἶναι λέγειν· ἀλλὰ τί οὐ βαδίζομεν παρ' αὐτόν, ἵνα

311a

And I said, “Let us not go there yet, my good man, for it is still early. Instead, let us get up and go out into the courtyard here, walk about, and pass the time until it becomes light. Then we may go. In fact, Protagoras spends most of his time indoors, so do not worry, that is quite likely where we shall find him.”

ἔνδον καταλάβωμεν; καταλύει δ', ὥς ἐγὼ ἤκουσα, παρὰ Καλλία τῷ Ἱππονίκου· ἀλλ' ἴωμεν. καὶ ἐγὼ εἶπον· μήπω, ἀγαθέ, ἐκεῖσε ἴωμεν—πρῶ γὰρ ἐστίν—ἀλλὰ δεῦρο ἐξαναστῶμεν εἰς τὴν αὐλήν, καὶ περιόντες αὐτοῦ διατρίψωμεν ἕως ἂν φῶς γένηται· εἴτα ἴωμεν. καὶ γὰρ τὰ πολλὰ Πρωταγόρας ἔνδον διατρίβει, ὥστε, θάρρει, καταληψόμεθα αὐτόν, ὥς τὸ εἶκος, ἔνδον. μετὰ ταῦτα ἀναστάντες εἰς τὴν αὐλήν περιήμεν· καὶ ἐγὼ

311b

After that we went out into the courtyard and walked about. And to test the resolve of Hippocrates, I probed him by asking questions.

ἀποπειρώμενος τοῦ Ἱπποκράτους τῆς ῥώμης διεσκόπουν αὐτόν καὶ ἡρώτων, εἰπέ μοι, ἔφην ἐγὼ, ὦ Ἱππόκратες, παρὰ Πρωταγόραν νῦν ἐπιχειρεῖς ἰέναι, ἀργύριον τελῶν ἐκείνῳ μισθὸν ὑπὲρ σεαυτοῦ, ὥς παρὰ τίνα ἀφιζόμενος καὶ τίς γεννησόμενος; ὥσπερ ἂν εἰ ἐπενόεις παρὰ τὸν σαυτοῦ ὁμώνυμον ἐλθὼν Ἱπποκράτη τὸν Κῶν, τὸν τῶν Ἀσκληπιαδῶν, ἀργύριον τελεῖν ὑπὲρ σαυτοῦ μισθὸν ἐκείνῳ, εἴ τίς σε ἤρετο· εἰπέ μοι, μέλλεις τελεῖν, ὦ Ἱππόκратες, Ἱπποκράτει

311c

“Tell me, Hippocrates,” I asked. “At the moment you are trying to gain access to Protagoras, and you will pay money to the man as a fee, on

your own behalf. What sort of person will you be visiting, and what sort of person will you become as a result? For instance, if you intended to visit your own namesake, the Asklepiad, Hippocrates of Cos, and pay money to him on your own behalf as a fee, and someone asked you, ‘Tell me, Hippocrates, you are about to pay a fee to this Hippocrates, to someone who is what?’ How would you reply?”

311c

“I would say that I am paying a fee to someone who is a physician,” he replied.

311c

“In order to become what?”

311c

“A physician,” he replied.

311c

“And if you were going to visit Polycleitus of Argos or Pheidias of Athens and pay a fee to these men on your own behalf, and someone asked you, ‘You propose to pay this money to Polycleitus and Pheidias, to people who are what?’, how would you reply?”

311c

“To people who are sculptors, that is what I would say.”

311c

“So that you yourself may become what?”

311c

“A sculptor, of course.”

μισθὸν ὡς τίνι ὄντι; τί ἂν ἀπεκρίνω;—εἶπον ἄν, ἔφη, ὅτι ὡς ἱατρῷ.—ὡς τίς γενησόμενος;—ὡς ἱατρός, ἔφη.—εἰ δὲ παρὰ Πολύκλειτον τὸν Ἀργεῖον ἢ Φειδίαν τὸν Ἀθηναῖον ἐπενόεις ἀφικόμενος μισθὸν ὑπὲρ σαυτοῦ τελεῖν ἐκείνοις, εἴ τίς σε ἤρετο· τελεῖν τοῦτο τὸ ἀργύριον ὡς τίνι ὄντι ἐν ᾧ ἔχεις Πολυκλείτῳ τε καὶ Φειδίᾳ; τί ἂν ἀπεκρίνω;—εἶπον ἂν ὡς ἀγαλματοποιοῖς.—ὡς τίς δὲ γενησόμενος αὐτός;—δῆλον ὅτι ἀγαλματοποιός.—εἶεν, ἦν δ’ ἐγώ·

311d

“So be it,” I said. “But in the present case, where you and I are visiting Protagoras, we shall be prepared to pay money to him on your behalf, provided our own funds are sufficient to persuade him. If not, we shall spend even our friends’ money as well. If someone observing our extreme seriousness on these matters were to ask, ‘Tell me, Socrates and Hippocrates, you intend to pay money to Protagoras, to someone who is what?’, how would we reply to him? What other name do we hear people using in relation to Protagoras, in the same way that ‘sculptor’ is used in relation to Pheidias, and ‘poet’ in relation to Homer? What title of this sort do we hear in relation to Protagoras?”

παρὰ δὲ δὴ Πρωταγόραν νῦν ἀφικόμενοι ἐγὼ τε καὶ σὺ ἀργύριον ἐκείνῳ μισθὸν ἔτοιμοι ἐσόμεθα τελεῖν ὑπὲρ σοῦ, ἂν μὲν ἐξικνηται τὰ ἡμέτερα χρήματα καὶ τούτοις πείθωμεν αὐτόν, εἰ δὲ μή, καὶ τὰ τῶν φίλων προσαναλίσκοντες. εἰ οὖν τις ἡμᾶς περὶ ταῦτα οὕτω σφόδρα σπουδάζοντας ἔροιτο· εἶπέ μοι, ὦ Σώκρατες τε καὶ Ἰππόκρατες, ὥς τίνι ὄντι τῷ Πρωταγόρᾳ ἐν ᾧ ἔχετε χρήματα τελεῖν; τί ἂν αὐτῷ

311e

“Well now, Socrates, what they say anyway is that the man is a sophist,” he replied.

311e

“So we are going to pay money to him as a sophist?”

311e

“Certainly.”

ἀποκρινάμεθα; τί ὄνομα ἄλλο γε λεγόμενον περὶ Πρωταγόρου ἀκούομεν; ὥσπερ περὶ Φειδίου ἀγαλματοποιὸν καὶ περὶ Ὀμήρου ποιητήν, τί τοιοῦτον περὶ Πρωταγόρου ἀκούομεν;—σοφιστήν δὴ τοι ὀνομάζουσί γε, ὦ Σώκρατες, τὸν ἄνδρα εἶναι, ἔφη.—ὥς σοφιστῇ ἄρα ἐρχόμεθα τελοῦντες τὰ χρήματα;—μάλιστα.— ΣΩ. εἰ οὖν καὶ τοῦτό τις σε προσέροιτο·

312a

“Now, suppose someone were to ask you this additional question, ‘If you yourself were to go to Protagoras, what would you intend to become?’”

312a

And he replied, blushing, for the day was breaking by now and I could see him clearly. “If this is anything like the previous instances, it is obvious I intend to become a sophist.”

312a

“By the gods,” I said, “wouldn’t you be ashamed to present yourself before the Greeks as a sophist?”

312a

“Yes, by Zeus, Socrates, if I really must say what I am thinking.”

αὐτὸς δὲ δὴ ὡς τίς γενησόμενος ἔρχη παρὰ τὸν Πρωταγόραν;—καὶ ὃς εἶπεν ἐρυθρίασας—ἤδη γὰρ ὑπέφαινέν τι ἡμέρας, ὥστε καταφανῆ αὐτὸν γενέσθαι—εἰ μὲν τι τοῖς ἔμπροσθεν ἔοικεν, δῆλον ὅτι σοφιστῆς γενησόμενος.—σὺ δέ, ἦν δ’ ἐγώ, πρὸς θεῶν, οὐκ ἂν αἰσχύνοιο εἰς τοὺς Ἕλληνας σαυτὸν σοφιστὴν παρέχων;—νῆ τὸν Δία, ὦ Σώκρατες, εἶπερ γε ἃ διανοοῦμαι χρὴ λέγειν.—ἀλλ’ ἄρα, ὦ Ἱππόκρατες, μὴ οὐ τοιαύτην ὑπολαμβάνεις σου τὴν παρὰ Πρωταγόρου μάθησιν

312b

“Well, Hippocrates, perhaps this turns out not to be the kind of instruction you are expecting from Protagoras. Were you expecting the kind of instruction you get from a teacher of writing, or of the harp, or from a trainer? For it was not with a view to becoming a practitioner that you developed proficiency in these subjects, but to acquire an education suited to an independent free man.”

312b

“Very much so,” he replied, “and I think this is more the kind of instruction I expect from Protagoras.”

312b

“Well, do you know what you are about to do now, or has this escaped your notice?” said I.

312b

“In what respect?”

ἔσεσθαι, ἀλλ' οἷαπερ ἡ παρὰ τοῦ γραμματιστοῦ ἐγένετο καὶ κιθαριστοῦ καὶ παιδοτρίβου; τούτων γὰρ σὺ ἐκάστην οὐκ ἐπὶ τέχνῃ ἔμαθες, ὡς δημιουργὸς ἐσόμενος, ἀλλ' ἐπὶ παιδείᾳ, ὡς τὸν ἰδιώτην καὶ τὸν ἐλεύθερον πρέπει.—πάνυ μὲν οὖν μοι δοκεῖ, ἔφη, τοιαύτη μᾶλλον εἶναι ἢ παρὰ Πρωταγόρου μάθησις. οἶσθα οὖν ὃ μέλλεις νῦν πράττειν, ἢ σε λανθάνει; ἦν δ' ἐγώ.—τοῦ πέρι;—ὅτι μέλλεις τὴν ψυχὴν τὴν σαυτοῦ παρασχεῖν

312c

“The fact is you are about to submit your own soul to the care of a man whom you admit to be a sophist. Yet I would be surprised if you knew what precisely a sophist is. What is more, if you are unaware of this, you do not know to whom you are handing over your soul, whether the arrangement be a good one or bad one.”

312c

“I think that I know well,” he said.

312c

“Then tell me what you think a sophist is.”

312c

“I think,” said he, “just as the name implies, that this is someone knowledgeable in matters of wisdom.”

θεραπεῦσαι ἀνδρί, ὡς φῆς, σοφιστῇ· ὅτι δέ ποτε ὁ σοφιστής ἐστιν, θαυμάζοιμ' ἂν εἰ οἶσθα. καίτοι εἰ τοῦτ' ἀγνοεῖς, οὐδὲ ὅτῳ παραδίδως τὴν ψυχὴν οἶσθα, οὔτ' εἰ ἀγαθῷ οὔτ' εἰ κακῷ πράγματι.—οἶμαί γ', ἔφη, εἰδέναι.—λέγε δὴ, τί ἡγῇ εἶναι τὸν σοφιστήν;—ἐγὼ μὲν, ἦ δ' ὅς, ὥσπερ τοῦνομα λέγει, τοῦτον εἶναι τὸν τῶν σοφῶν ἐπιστήμονα.—οὐκοῦν, ἦν δ' ἐγώ, τοῦτο μὲν ἔξεστι λέγειν καὶ περὶ ζωγράφων καὶ περὶ τεκτόνων, ὅτι οὗτοί εἰσιν οἱ τῶν σοφῶν ἐπιστήμονες· ἀλλ'

312d

“Isn't it also possible”, I asked, “to say this about painters and builders, that these are the ones who are knowledgeable in matters of wisdom? And if someone were to ask us, ‘Of what wise matters are painters knowledgeable?’, I presume we would say that they know about the

production of images, and reply similarly about the other examples. But if someone were to ask us, specifically, ‘Of what wise matters is a sophist knowledgeable?’, how would we reply to him? What sort of processes is he master of?”

312d

“What else could we say he is, Socrates, except a master of turning someone into a formidable speaker?”

εἴ τις ἔροιτο ἡμᾶς, τῶν τί σοφῶν εἰσιν οἱ ζωγράφοι ἐπιστήμονες, εἵπομεν ἄν που αὐτῷ ὅτι τῶν πρὸς τὴν ἀπεργασίαν τὴν τῶν εἰκόνων, καὶ τᾶλλα οὕτως. εἰ δέ τις ἐκεῖνο ἔροιτο, ὁ δὲ σοφιστὴς τῶν τί σοφῶν ἐστιν; τί ἂν ἀποκρινοίμεθα αὐτῷ; ποίας ἐργασίας ἐπιστάτης;—τί ἂν εἵπομεν αὐτὸν εἶναι, ὃ Σώκρατες, ἢ ἐπιστάτην τοῦ ποιῆσαι δεινὸν λέγειν;—ἴσως ἄν, ἣν δ’ ἐγώ, ἀληθῆ λέγοιμεν, οὐ μέντοι ἱκανῶς γε· ἐρωτήσεως γὰρ ἔτι ἡ ἀπόκρισις ἡμῖν δεῖται, περὶ οὗτου ὁ σοφιστὴς δεινὸν ποιεῖ λέγειν· ὥσπερ ὁ κιθαριστὴς

312e

“We may perhaps be speaking the truth”, I remarked, “without actually saying enough, for our response invites further questioning as to the subject in which the sophist makes someone a formidable speaker. For example, the harp player obviously makes a person formidable in the subject about which he is knowledgeable, about harp-playing. Is this so?”

312e

“Yes.”

312e

“So be it. About what subject does the sophist make someone formidable in speaking?”

312e

“About the subject in which he himself is knowledgeable, of course.”

312e

“Quite likely. What then is the subject about which the sophist is knowledgeable, and makes his pupil knowledgeable?”

312e

“By Zeus,” he exclaimed, “I cannot really tell you!”

δεινὸν δῆπου ποιεῖ λέγειν περὶ οὐπὲρ καὶ ἐπιστήμονα, περὶ κιθαρίσεως· ἧ γάρ;—ναί.—εἶεν· ὁ δὲ δὴ σοφιστὴς περὶ τίνος δεινὸν ποιεῖ λέγειν;—δῆλον ὅτι περὶ οὐπὲρ καὶ ἐπίστασθαι;—εἰκὸς γε. τί δὴ ἐστὶν τοῦτο περὶ οὗ αὐτός τε ἐπιστήμων ἐστὶν ὁ σοφιστὴς καὶ τὸν μαθητὴν ποιεῖ;—μὰ Δί', ἔφη, οὐκέτι ἔχω σοι λέγειν. ΣΩ.

313a

I then proceeded to ask, “Do you know the sort of danger to which you are going to expose your soul? If you had occasion to entrust your body to someone, running the risk that it might be improved or made worse, you would think a lot about whether you should entrust it to that person or not. You would call upon the advice of your friends and family, and deliberate for many days.

καὶ ἐγὼ εἶπον μετὰ τοῦτο· τί οὖν; οἶσθα εἰς οἷόν τινα κίνδυνον ἔρχη ὑποθήσων τὴν ψυχὴν; ἢ εἰ μὲν τὸ σῶμα ἐπιτρέπειν σε ἔδει τῷ διακινδυνεύοντα ἢ χρηστὸν αὐτὸ γενέσθαι ἢ πονηρόν, πολλὰ ἂν περιεσκέψω εἴτ' ἐπιτρέπτεον εἴτε οὐ, καὶ εἰς συμβουλήν τοὺς τε φίλους ἂν παρεκάλεις καὶ τοὺς οἰκείους σκοπούμενος ἡμέρας συχνάς· ὃ δὲ περὶ πλείονος τοῦ σώματος ἡγῇ, τὴν ψυχὴν, καὶ ἐν ᾧ πάντ' ἐστὶν τὰ σὰ ἢ εὖ ἢ κακῶς πράττειν, χρηστοῦ ἢ πονηροῦ αὐτοῦ γενομένου, περὶ δὲ τούτου οὔτε τῷ πατρὶ οὔτε τῷ ἀδελφῷ

313b

Yet, when it comes to your soul – which you value more highly than your body, and on which the good or bad unfolding of all your affairs depends, according as it is improved or made worse – when it comes to this, you have consulted neither your father nor your brother nor any of us, your companions, at all, as to whether or not you should entrust your own soul to this foreigner who has just arrived in town. No, you heard about him yesterday, as you say. You arrive here at daybreak, and without initiating any discussion or consultation as to whether you should entrust yourself to him or not, you are ready to spend your own money and your friends' money, since you have already decided that

come what may, you must be an associate of Protagoras, whom on your own admission you have never either known or spoken to before. You call him a sophist.

ἐπεκοινώσω οὔτε ἡμῶν τῶν ἐταίρων οὐδενί, εἴτ' ἐπιτρεπτέον εἴτε καὶ οὐ τῷ ἀφικομένῳ τούτῳ ξένῳ τὴν σὴν ψυχὴν, ἀλλ' ἐσπέρας ἀκούσας, ὡς φῆς, ὄρθριος ἦκων περὶ μὲν τούτου οὐδένα λόγον οὐδὲ συμβουλήν ποιῇ, εἴτε χρὴ ἐπιτρέπειν σαυτὸν αὐτῷ εἴτε μή, ἕτοιμος δ' εἶ ἀναλίσκειν τὰ τε σαυτοῦ καὶ τὰ τῶν φίλων χρήματα, ὡς ἤδη διεγνωκὼς ὅτι πάντως συνεστέον Πρωταγόρᾳ, ὃν οὔτε γινώσκεις, ὡς φῆς, οὔτε

313c

You obviously do not even know what a sophist is, and yet, you are about to entrust yourself to him.”

313c

He heard this and said, “Quite likely, Socrates, based on what you are saying.”

313c

“Well now, Hippocrates, could the sophist be a sort of merchant or retailer of the provisions by which the soul is nourished? For that is how he appears to me anyway.”

313c

“What is the soul nourished by, Socrates?”

διείλεξαι οὐδεπώποτε, σοφιστὴν δ' ὀνομάζεις, τὸν δὲ σοφιστὴν ὅτι ποτ' ἔστιν φαίνῃ ἀγνοῶν, ὃ μέλλεις σαυτὸν ἐπιτρέπειν;—καὶ ὃς ἀκούσας, ἔοικεν, ἔφη, ὦ Σώκρατες, ἐξ ὧν σὺ λέγεις.—ἄρ' οὖν, ὦ Ἰππόκρατες, ὁ σοφιστὴς τυγχάνει ὧν ἔμπορός τις ἢ κάπηλος τῶν ἀγωγίμων, ἀφ' ὧν ψυχὴ τρέφεται; φαίνεται γὰρ ἔμοιγε τοιοῦτός τις.—τρέφεται δέ, ὦ Σώκρατες, ψυχὴ τίनि;—μαθήμασιν δήπου, ἣν δ' ἐγώ. καὶ ὅπως γε μή, ὦ ἐταίρε, ὁ σοφιστὴς ἐπαινῶν ἃ πωλεῖ ἐξαπατήσῃ ἡμᾶς, ὥσπερ οἱ περὶ τὴν τοῦ σώματος τροφήν, ὁ

313d

“By what it learns, I presume,” said I. “But the sophist deceives us by praising whatever he sells, just as merchants and retailers do when

they deal in nutriment for the body. For these people, although they praise everything they sell, presumably do not know themselves which of the wares they deal in are beneficial or harmful to the body, nor do the people who buy from them, unless they happen to be trainers or physicians.

ἐμπορός τε καὶ κάπηλος. καὶ γὰρ οὗτοί που ὧν ἄγουσιν ἀγωγίμων οὔτε αὐτοὶ ἴσασιν ὅτι χρηστὸν ἢ πονηρὸν περὶ τὸ σῶμα, ἐπαινοῦσιν δὲ πάντα πωλοῦντες, οὔτε οἱ ὠνούμενοι παρ' αὐτῶν, ἐὰν μὴ τις τύχη γυμναστικός ἢ ἱατρὸς ὧν. οὕτω δὲ καὶ οἱ τὰ μαθήματα περιάγοντες κατὰ τὰς πόλεις καὶ πωλοῦντες καὶ καπηλεύοντες τῷ αἰεὶ ἐπιθυμοῦντι ἐπαινοῦσιν μὲν πάντα ἃ πωλοῦσιν, τάχα δ' ἂν τινες, ὧ ἄριστε, καὶ τούτων ἀγνοοῖεν ὧν πωλοῦσιν ὅτι χρηστὸν ἢ πονηρὸν

313e

“The same applies to those who parade their learning around the cities, acting as salesmen and retailers to any eager customer. They too praise everything they sell. Yet in all probability some of these, my good man, are ignorant as to whether the wares they are selling are beneficial or harmful to the soul. And the same applies to the people who buy from them, unless one of them is, perchance, for his part, a skilled physician of the soul.

πρὸς τὴν ψυχὴν· ὥς δ' αὐτως καὶ οἱ ὠνούμενοι παρ' αὐτῶν, ἐὰν μὴ τις τύχη περὶ τὴν ψυχὴν αὖ ἱατρικὸς ὧν. εἰ μὲν οὖν σὺ τυγχάνεις ἐπιστήμων τούτων τί χρηστὸν καὶ πονηρὸν, ἀσφαλές σοι ὠνεῖσθαι μαθήματα καὶ παρὰ Πρωταγόρου καὶ παρ' ἄλλου ὅτουοῦν· εἰ δὲ μὴ, ὄρα, ὧ μακάριε,

314a

“Now, if you are knowledgeable as to which of these wares are beneficial or harmful, you may purchase learning, in safety, from Protagoras or anyone else at all. Otherwise beware, blessed man, lest you take chances and imperil your most precious possessions, for there is surely an even greater danger in the purchase of learning than in the purchase of food. Indeed, it is possible for food and drink purchased

from a retailer or merchant to be taken away in separate vessels before admitting them into the body by drinking them or eating them. Once you have got them home, it is possible to take advice by calling upon someone who knows what we should eat and drink and what we should not, and how much and at what time. Consequently there is no great danger involved in their purchase.

μη περὶ τοῖς φιλάτοις κυβεύης τε καὶ κινδυνεύης. ΣΩ. καὶ γὰρ δὴ καὶ πολὺ μείζων κίνδυνος ἐν τῇ τῶν μαθημάτων ὦνῃ ἢ ἐν τῇ τῶν σιτίων. σιτία μὲν γὰρ καὶ ποτὰ πριάμενον παρὰ τοῦ καπήλου καὶ ἐμπορίου ἔξεστιν ἐν ἄλλοις ἀγγείοις ἀποφέρειν, καὶ πρὶν δέξασθαι αὐτὰ εἰς τὸ σῶμα πίνοντα ἢ φαγόντα, καταθέμενον οἴκαδε ἔξεστιν συμβουλευσάσθαι, παρακαλέσαντα τὸν ἐπαίοντα, ὅτι τε ἔδεστέον ἢ ποτέον καὶ ὅτι μή, καὶ ὁπόσον καὶ ὁπότε ὥστε ἐν τῇ ὦνῃ οὐ μέγας ὁ

314b

“Learning, by contrast, cannot be borne away in a separate vessel. No, once the fee has been proffered, it is necessary to take that learning into the soul itself, and once you have learned something, you must go your way, having been either harmed or benefited. Well, we should consider these issues in the company of our elders, for we are too young to deal with such an extensive topic.

κίνδυνος. μαθήματα δὲ οὐκ ἔστιν ἐν ἄλλῳ ἀγγείῳ ἀπενεγκεῖν, ἀλλ’ ἀνάγκη καταθέντα τὴν τιμὴν τὸ μάθημα ἐν αὐτῇ τῇ ψυχῇ λαβόντα καὶ μαθόντα ἀπιέναι ἢ βεβλαμμένον ἢ ὠφελημένον. ταῦτα οὖν σκοπώμεθα καὶ μετὰ τῶν πρεσβυτέρων ἡμῶν· ἡμεῖς γὰρ ἔτι νέοι ὥστε τοσοῦτον πρᾶγμα διελέσθαι. νῦν μέντοι, ὥσπερ ὠρμήσαμεν, ἴωμεν καὶ ἀκούσωμεν τοῦ ἀνδρός, ἔπειτα ἀκούσαντες καὶ ἄλλοις ἀνακοινώσωμεθα καὶ γὰρ οὐ μόνος Πρωταγόρας αὐτόθι ἐστίν,

314c

“Now, however, in accordance with our plan, we should go and listen to the man, and once we have heard him we should also consult other people too. In fact, Protagoras is not the only one there. Hippias of Elis⁷

is also there. So too, I believe, is Prodicus of Ceos,⁸ and a host of others, all wise.”

ἀλλὰ καὶ Ἰππίας ὁ Ἡλεῖος—οἶμαι δὲ καὶ πρόδικον τὸν Κεῖον—καὶ ἄλλοι πολλοὶ καὶ σοφοί. δόξαν ἡμῖν ταῦτα ἐπορευόμεθα· ἐπειδὴ δὲ ἐν τῷ προθύρῳ ἐγενόμεθα, ἐπιστάντες περὶ τινος λόγου διελεγόμεθα, ὃς ἡμῖν κατὰ τὴν ὁδὸν ἐνέπεσεν· ἴν’ οὖν μὴ ἀτελὴς γένοιτο, ἀλλὰ διαπερανάμενοι οὕτως ἐσίοιμεν, στάντες ἐν τῷ προθύρῳ διελεγόμεθα ἕως συνωμολογήσασιν ἀλλήλοις. δοκεῖ οὖν μοι, ὁ θυρωρός, εὐνοῦχός τις, κατήκουεν ἡμῶν, κινδυνεύει δὲ

314d

Once we had decided this, we went on our way. But when we got to the porch, we stood there discussing a particular argument that had occurred to us on the road so that it would not be left unfinished and we could bring the issue to a conclusion before going inside. So we stood in the porch and discussed it until we had come to agreement with one another. Well, I think the doorman, a eunuch, overheard us, but due to the profusion of sophists he was probably annoyed with the visitors to the house, since when we knocked on the door, he opened it, saw us and said, “Ah, some more sophists. Himself is busy.” At the same time, he slammed the door shut with both hands as hard as he possibly could. So we knocked again and he responded, with the door still closed, saying, “Gentlemen, did you not hear me saying that he is busy?”

διὰ τὸ πλῆθος τῶν σοφιστῶν ἄχθεσθαι τοῖς φοιτῶσιν εἰς τὴν οἰκίαν· ἐπειδὴ γοῦν ἐκρούσαμεν τὴν θύραν, ἀνοίξας καὶ ἰδὼν ἡμᾶς, ἔα, ἔφη, σοφισταὶ τινες· οὐ σχολὴ αὐτῷ· καὶ ἅμα ἀμφοῖν τοῖν χεροῖν τὴν θύραν πάνυ προθύμως ὥς οἷός τ’ ἦν ἐπήραξεν. καὶ ἡμεῖς πάλιν ἐκρούομεν, καὶ ὃς ἐγκεκλημένης τῆς θύρας ἀποκρινόμενος εἶπεν, ὦ ἄνθρωποι, ἔφη, οὐκ ἀκηκόατε ὅτι οὐ σχολὴ αὐτῷ; ἀλλ’ ὠγαθέ, ἔφην ἐγώ, οὔτε παρὰ Καλλίαν ἤκομεν οὔτε σοφισταὶ ἐσμεν. ἀλλὰ θάρρει·

314e

“But, my good man,” I replied, “we are not visiting Callias, nor are we sophists, so do not worry. In fact, we have come because we want to see Protagoras, so please announce us.” So the man eventually opened the door to us with some reluctance.

Πρωταγόραν γάρ τοι δεόμενοι ἰδεῖν ἤλθομεν· εἰσάγγειλον οὔν. μόγις οὔν ποτε ἡμῖν ἄνθρωπος ἀνέωξεν τὴν θύραν. ΣΩ. ἐπειδὴ δὲ εἰσῆλθομεν, κατελάβομεν Πρωταγόραν ἐν τῷ προστώῳ περιπατοῦντα, ἑξῆς δ' αὐτῷ συμπεριεπάτουν ἐκ μὲν τοῦ ἐπὶ θάτερα Καλλίας ὁ Ἴππονίκου καὶ ὁ ἀδελφὸς αὐτοῦ

315a

And when we went in we found Protagoras walking about in the portico. Walking in line with him on one side was Callias, the son of Hipponicus, and his brother Paralus, the son of Pericles, who has the same mother, also Charmides, the son of Glaucon. On the other side was Xanthippus, the other son of Pericles, Phillipides, the son of Philomelus, and Antimoerus from Mende,⁹ the most highly regarded of Protagoras' pupils, one who is developing his proficiency with a view to becoming a sophist. Those who followed behind these men and listened in on the conversation seemed for the most part to be foreigners whom Protagoras had drawn from the various cities he travelled through, charming them with his voice, just like Orpheus, while they followed along, enchanted by the sound.¹⁰ There were also some of our fellow-countrymen in the chorus. When I beheld this chorus, I was especially delighted at the beautiful care they exercised never to impede Protagoras by getting in front of him. So when he turned about along with his cohort, those eavesdroppers divided in two nicely, and in due order, on either side, turned in a circle and always positioned themselves perfectly behind him once more.

ὁ ὁμομήτριος, Πάραλος ὁ Περικλέους, καὶ Χαρμίδης ὁ Γλαύκωνος, ἐκ δὲ τοῦ ἐπὶ θάτερα ὁ ἕτερος τῶν Περικλέους Ξάνθιππος, καὶ Φιλίππιδης ὁ Φιλομήλου καὶ Ἀντίμοιρος ὁ Μενδαῖος, ὅσπερ εὐδοκιμεῖ μάλιστα τῶν Πρωταγόρου μαθητῶν καὶ ἐπὶ τέχνῃ μαθάνει, ὡς σοφιστὴς ἐσόμενος.

τούτων δὲ οἱ ὀπισθεν ἠκολούθουν ἐπακούοντες τῶν λεγομένων τὸ μὲν πολὺ ξένοι ἐφαίνοντο—οὓς ἄγει ἐξ ἐκάστων τῶν πόλεων ὁ Πρωταγόρας, δι' ὧν διεξέρχεται, κηλῶν τῇ φωνῇ ὥσπερ Ὀρφεύς, οἱ δὲ κατὰ τὴν φωνὴν ἔπονται κεκληγμένοι— ἦσαν δέ τινες καὶ τῶν ἐπιχωρίων ἐν τῷ χορῷ. τοῦτον τὸν χορὸν μάλιστα ἔγωγε ἰδὼν ἦσθην, ὥς καλῶς ἠύλαβοντο μηδέποτε ἐμποδὼν ἐν τῷ πρόσθεν εἶναι Πρωταγόρου, ἀλλ' ἐπειδὴ αὐτὸς ἀναστρέφοι καὶ οἱ μετ' ἐκείνου, εὖ πως καὶ ἐν κόσμῳ περιεσχίζοντο οὗτοι οἱ ἐπήκοοι ἔνθεν καὶ ἔνθεν, καὶ ἐν κύκλῳ περιιόντες αἰεὶ εἰς τὸ ὀπισθεν καθίσταντο κάλλιστα. τὸν δὲ μετ' εἰσενόησα, ἔφη Ὀμηρος, Ἰππίαν τὸν

315c

'The next person I beheld', in Homer's phrase,¹¹ was Hippias of Elis, seated upon a raised chair in the opposite portico. Seated about him on benches were Eryximachus, the son of Acumenus, Phaedrus of Myrrhinus, Andron,¹² the son of Androtion, and among the foreigners were fellow citizens of Hippias, and a few others. They appeared to be questioning Hippias on astronomical issues concerning nature and the heavenly bodies, while he, seated on his raised chair, analysed each of their questions and dealt with them in detail.

Ἥλειον, καθήμενον ἐν τῷ κατ' ἀντικρὺ προστώῳ ἐν θρόνῳ· περὶ αὐτὸν δ' ἐκάθηντο ἐπὶ βάθρων Ἐρυξίμαχος τε ὁ Ἀκουμενοῦ καὶ Φαῖδρος ὁ Μυρρινούσιος καὶ Ἄνδρων ὁ Ἀνδροτίωνος καὶ τῶν ξένων πολῖταί τε αὐτοῦ καὶ ἄλλοι τινές. ἐφαίνοντο δὲ περὶ φύσεώς τε καὶ τῶν μετεώρων ἀστρονομικὰ ἄττα διερωτᾶν τὸν Ἰππίαν, ὁ δ' ἐν θρόνῳ καθήμενος ἐκάστοις αὐτῶν διέκρινεν καὶ διεξήκει τὰ ἐρωτώμενα. καὶ μὲν δὴ καὶ Τάνταλόν γε εἰσεῖδον—ἐπεδήμει

315d

And then 'I beheld Tantalus',¹³ for as it happens, Prodicus of Ceos is also in town. He was in a small room which Hipponicus had previously used for storage, but Callias had even emptied this out and turned it into a guest chamber because of the huge number of lodgers. Now, Prodicus was still lying down, covered in fleeces and blankets. There seemed to be a lot of them. Sitting beside him on one of the adjacent couches was

Pausanias from Cerames, and with Pausanias there was a young man, still a youth, whom I thought noble and good by nature, and certainly very handsome. I think I heard that his name was Agathon, and I would not be surprised if he happens to be the young favourite of Pausanias. This youth was there, as were the two Adimantuses, one the son of Cepis, the other of Leucolophides,¹⁴ and there seemed to be some others there too. From outside I was unable to understand what they were discussing, despite my earnest desire to listen to Prodicus, for he seems to me to be an extremely wise and divine man. But because of his deep voice, there was a booming sound in the room which made everything he said unclear.

γὰρ ἄρα καὶ Πρόδικος ὁ Κεῖτος—ἦν δὲ ἐν οἰκῆματί τι, ᾧ πρὸ τοῦ μὲν ὡς ταμιεῖω ἐχρήτο Ἰππόνικος, νῦν δὲ ὑπὸ τοῦ πλήθους τῶν καταλόντων ὁ Καλλίας καὶ τοῦτο ἐκκενώσας ξένοις κατάλυσιν πεποίηκεν. ὁ μὲν οὖν Πρόδικος ἔτι κατέκειτο, ἐγκεκαλυμμένος ἐν κωδίοις τισὶν καὶ στρώμασιν καὶ μάλα πολλοῖς, ὡς ἐφαίνετο· παρεκάθηντο δὲ αὐτῷ ἐπὶ ταῖς πλησίον κλίμαις Πausανίας τε ὁ ἐκ Κεραμέων καὶ μετὰ Πausανίου νέον τι ἔτι μειράκιον, ὡς μὲν ἐγῶμαι καλὸν τε καὶ ἀγαθὸν τὴν φύσιν, τὴν δ' οὖν ιδέαν πάνυ καλός. ἔδοξα ἀκοῦσαι ὄνομα αὐτῷ εἶναι Ἀγάθωνα, καὶ οὐκ ἂν θαυμάζοιμι εἰ παιδικὰ Πausανίου τυγχάνει ὦν. ΣΩ. τοῦτό τ' ἦν τὸ μειράκιον, καὶ τῷ Ἀδειμάντῳ ἀμφοτέρῳ, ὃ τε Κήπιδος καὶ ὁ Λευκολοφίδου, καὶ ἄλλοι τινὲς ἐφαίνοντο· περὶ δὲ ὧν διελέγοντο οὐκ ἐδυνάμην ἔγωγε μαθεῖν ἔξωθεν, καίπερ λιπαρῶς ἔχων ἀκούειν τοῦ Προδίκου—πάσσοφος γάρ μοι δοκεῖ ἀνὴρ εἶναι καὶ θεῖος—ἀλλὰ διὰ τὴν βαρύτητα τῆς φωνῆς βόμβος τις ἐν τῷ οἰκῆματι γιγνόμενος ἀσαφῆ ἔποιε τὰ λεγόμενα. καὶ ἡμεῖς μὲν ἄρτι εἰσεληλύθεμεν, κατόπιν δὲ ἡμῶν ἐπεισῆλθον Ἀλκιβιάδης τε ὁ καλός, ὡς φῆς σὺ καὶ ἐγὼ πείθομαι, καὶ Κριτίας ὁ Καλλαίσχρου. ἡμεῖς οὖν ὡς εἰσῆλθομεν, ἔτι σμίκρ' ἄττα διατρίψαντες καὶ ταῦτα διαθεασάμενοι προσῆμεν πρὸς τὸν Πρωταγόραν,

316b

We had only just arrived when right behind us came Alcibiades, the beautiful, as you call him, and I agree with you. Critias, the son of

Callaeschrus, came in too.¹⁵ Now, once we had entered, we spent some time on a few minor issues, and when these had been dealt with we went up to Protagoras, and I said, “Protagoras, myself and Hippocrates here have come to meet you.”

316b

“Do you wish to converse alone or in the presence of the others?” he asked.

316b

“It makes no difference to us,” I replied. “When you have heard the reason for our visit, you can decide for yourself.”

316b

“Well, then,” he said, “what is the purpose of your visit?”

καὶ ἐγὼ εἶπον· ὦ Πρωταγόρα, πρὸς σέ τοι ἤλθομεν ἐγὼ τε καὶ Ἴπποκράτης οὗτος, πότερον, ἔφη, μόνῳ βουλούμενοι διαλεχθῆναι ἢ καὶ μετὰ τῶν ἄλλων; ἡμῖν μὲν, ἦν δ' ἐγώ, οὐδὲν διαφέρει· ἀκούσας δὲ οὐ ἔνεκα ἤλθομεν, αὐτὸς σκέψαι. τί οὖν δή ἐστίν, ἔφη, οὐ ἔνεκα ἦκετε; Ἴπποκράτης ὅδε ἐστὶν μὲν τῶν ἐπιχωρίων, Ἀπολλοδώρου υἱός, οἰκίας μεγάλης τε καὶ εὐδαίμονος, αὐτὸς δὲ τὴν φύσιν δοκεῖ ἐνάμιλλος εἶναι τοῖς ἡλικιώταις. ἐπιθυμεῖν δέ μοι

316c

“Hippocrates here is one of our fellow countrymen. He is the son of Apollodorus, and he belongs to a great, prosperous family, while he himself seems by nature to be a match for any one of his peers. I think he wishes to attain a high reputation in the city, and he believes he will best attain this if he consorts with you. So please consider at this stage whether you think we should discuss these issues privately on our own or in the company of others.”

δοκεῖ ἐλλόγιμος γενέσθαι ἐν τῇ πόλει, τοῦτο δὲ οἶεται οἱ μάλιστ' ἂν γενέσθαι, εἰ σοὶ συγγένοιτο· ταῦτ' οὖν ἤδη σὺ σκόπει, πότερον περὶ αὐτῶν μόνος οἶε δεῖν διαλέγεσθαι πρὸς μόνους, ἢ μετ' ἄλλων. ὀρθῶς, ἔφη, προμηθεῖ, ὦ Σώκρατες, ὑπὲρ ἐμοῦ. ξένον γὰρ ἄνδρα καὶ ἰόντα εἰς πόλεις μεγάλας, καὶ ἐν ταύταις πείθοντα τῶν νέων τοὺς βελτίστους

ἀπολείποντας τὰς τῶν ἄλλων συνουσίας, καὶ οἰκείων καὶ ὀθνείων, καὶ πρεσβυτέρων καὶ νεωτέρων, ἑαυτῷ συνεῖναι ὡς βελτίους ἐσομένους διὰ

316d

“Socrates,” he replied, “you are right to be cautious on my behalf. Indeed, a foreigner who arrives in great cities, persuading the best of their young folk to depart from the company of others, of family members or acquaintances, older or younger, in order to consort with himself so that they may be improved by his company, needs to proceed carefully in so doing. For these activities generate no small measure of resentment, hostility and intrigue.

τὴν ἑαυτοῦ συνουσίαν, χρή εὐλαβεῖσθαι τὸν ταῦτα πράττοντα· οὐ γὰρ σμικροὶ περὶ αὐτὰ φθόνοι τε γίνονται καὶ ἄλλαι δυσμένειαι τε καὶ ἐπιβουλαί. ἐγὼ δὲ τὴν σοφιστικὴν τέχνην φημὶ μὲν εἶναι παλαιάν, τοὺς δὲ μεταχειριζομένους αὐτὴν τῶν παλαιῶν ἀνδρῶν, φοβουμένους τὸ ἐπαχθὲς αὐτῆς, πρόσχημα ποιεῖσθαι καὶ προκαλύπτεσθαι, τοὺς μὲν ποιήσιν, οἷον Ὅμηρόν τε καὶ Ἡσίοδον καὶ Σιμωνίδαην, τοὺς δὲ αὖ τελετάς τε καὶ χρησμοδίας, τοὺς ἀμφί τε Ὀρφέα καὶ Μουσαῖον· ἐνίους δὲ τινὰς ἥσθηται καὶ γυμναστικὴν, οἷον Ἴκκος τε ὁ Ταραντῖνος καὶ ὁ νῦν ἔτι ὢν οὐδενὸς ἥττων σοφιστῆς

316e

“Now, I say that the skill of sophistry is of ancient date, yet those men of old who turned a hand to it, fearing the offence it might cause, disguised their skill. Some like Homer, Hesiod and Simonides concealed it as poetry; others, the associates of Orpheus and Musaeus, as rites or oracular sayings. And I have on occasion even observed people concealing it as gymnastics – Iccus of Tarentum, for instance, and the present-day sophist, as good as any, Herodicus of Selymbria, formerly of Megara. Your own Agathocles, although he is a great sophist, adopted the disguise of a musician, as did Pythocles of Ceos and many others. All these men, as I have been saying, made use of these various skills as a screen because they were afraid of the resentment. Now, I do not agree with the approach of all these people, since I believe that

they do not achieve their desired objective. For the men who exercise power in the various cities, the very people they are trying to deceive, are quite aware of this subterfuge, while the masses hardly notice anything but simply repeat the pronouncements of the men in power. Now, trying to get away with something when you are unable to get away with it, and being exposed in the attempt, is sheer folly on the part of the person who tries to do so, and, of necessity, provokes even greater hostility in people, for they believe that such a person, in addition to his other failings, is also a rogue. So I have adopted an approach that is the complete opposite of theirs. I admit to being a sophist and an educator of humanity, and I regard this precaution, whereby I admit it rather than deny it, as better than the other one. And I have devised other safeguards as well as this so that, with God as my witness, nothing terrible has happened to me due to my admission of being a sophist, even though I have by now been many years in the profession. Yes, indeed, I have a long life behind me and I am old enough to be the father of anyone here, so, if you wish to pursue these issues, I would be very pleased to conduct the discussion in front of everyone in the house.”

Ἡρόδικος ὁ Σηλυμβριανός, τὸ δὲ ἀρχαῖον Μεγαρεὺς μουσικὴν δὲ Ἀγαθοκλῆς τε ὁ ὑμέτερος πρόσχημα ἐποίησατο, μέγας ὢν σοφιστής, καὶ Πυθοκλείδης ὁ Κεῖος καὶ ἄλλοι πολλοί. οὗτοι πάντες, ὥσπερ λέγω, φοβηθέντες τὸν φθόνον ταῖς τέχναις ταύταις παραπετάσασιν ἐχρήσαντο. ΣΩ. ἐγὼ δὲ τούτοις ἅπασιν κατὰ τοῦτο εἶναι οὐ συμφέρομαι· ἡγοῦμαι γὰρ αὐτοὺς οὐ τι διαπράξασθαι ὃ ἐβουλήθησαν—οὐ γὰρ λαθεῖν τῶν ἀνθρώπων τοὺς δυναμένους ἐν ταῖς πόλεσι πράττειν, ὥνπερ ἔνεκα ταῦτ’ ἐστὶν τὰ προσήματα· ἐπεὶ οἳ γε πολλοὶ ὡς ἔπος εἰπεῖν οὐδὲν αἰσθάνονται, ἀλλ’ ἅττ’ ἂν οὗτοι διαγγέλλωσι, ταῦτα ὑμνοῦσιν—τὸ οὖν ἀποδιδράσκοντα μὴ δύνασθαι ἀποδρᾶναι, ἀλλὰ καταφανῆ εἶναι, πολλὴ μωρία καὶ τοῦ ἐπιχειρήματος, καὶ πολὺ δυσμενεστέρους παρέχεσθαι ἀνάγκη τοὺς ἀνθρώπους· ἡγοῦνται γὰρ τὸν τοιοῦτον πρὸς τοῖς ἄλλοις καὶ πανοῦργον εἶναι. ἐγὼ οὖν τούτων τὴν ἐναντίαν ἅπασαν ὁδὸν ἐλήλυθα, καὶ ὁμολογῶ τε σοφιστὴς εἶναι καὶ παιδεύειν ἀνθρώπους, καὶ

εὐλάβειαν ταύτην οἶμαι βελτίω ἐκείνης εἶναι, τὸ ὁμολογεῖν μᾶλλον ἢ ἔξαρνον εἶναι· καὶ ἄλλας πρὸς ταύτην ἔσκεμμαι, ὥστε, σὺν θεῷ εἰπεῖν, μηδὲν δεινὸν πάσχειν διὰ τὸ ὁμολογεῖν σοφιστὴς εἶναι. καίτοι πολλά γε ἔτη ἤδη εἰμὶ ἐν τῇ τέχνῃ· καὶ γὰρ καὶ τὰ σύμπαντα πολλά μοί ἐστιν—οὐδενὸς οὗτου οὐ πάντων ἂν ὑμῶν καθ’ ἡλικίαν πατήρ εἴην—ὥστε πολὺ μοι ἥδιστόν ἐστιν, εἴ τι βούλεσθε, περὶ τούτων ἀπάντων ἐναντίον τῶν ἔνδον ὄντων τὸν λόγον ποιεῖσθαι. καὶ ἐγώ—ὑπώπτευσα γὰρ βούλεσθαι αὐτὸν τῷ τε προδίκῳ καὶ τῷ Ἰππία ἐνδείξασθαι καὶ καλλωπίσασθαι ὅτι ἐρασταὶ

317d

I suspected that he wished to put on a show before Prodicus and Hippias, and take pride in the fact that we were admirers of his who had come to join him. So I said, “Why don’t we invite Prodicus and Hippias and the people with them to listen in to our discussion?”

317d

“Yes, certainly,” replied Protagoras.

317d

“Well,” said Callias, “would you like us to arrange a meeting place, so that you may sit down and conduct your discussion?”

αὐτοῦ ἀφιγμένοι εἴμεν—τί οὖν, ἔφην ἐγώ, οὐ καὶ πρόδικον καὶ Ἰππίαν ἐκαλέσαμεν καὶ τοὺς μετ’ αὐτῶν, ἵνα ἐπακούσωσιν ἡμῶν; πάνυ μὲν οὖν, ἔφη ὁ Πρωταγόρας. βούλεσθε οὖν, ὁ Καλλίας ἔφη, συνέδριον κατασκευάσωμεν, ἵνα καθεζόμενοι διαλέγησθε; ἐδόκει χρῆναι ἄσμενοι δὲ πάντες ἡμεῖς, ὥς ἀκουσόμενοι ἀνδρῶν σοφῶν, καὶ αὐτοὶ τε ἀντιλαβόμενοι τῶν βάθρων καὶ τῶν κλινῶν κατεσκευάζομεν παρὰ τῷ Ἰππία—ἐκεῖ γὰρ προϋπῆρχε τὰ βάθρα—ἐν δὲ τούτῳ Καλλίας τε καὶ Ἀλκιβιάδης

317e

That seemed the thing to do, and we were all pleased at the prospect of listening to wise men, so we too picked up the benches and couches ourselves and arranged them beside Hippias, since the benches were to hand already. Meanwhile, Callias and Alcibiades arrived, bringing

Prodicus, whom they had roused from the couch, and Prodicus' associates too.

317e

Once we had all sat down together, Protagoras said, “Well, Socrates, now that these people are also present, would you please elaborate upon what you mentioned to me earlier on this young man’s behalf?”

ἡκέτην ἄγοντε τὸν πρόδικον, ἀναστήσαντες ἐκ τῆς κλίνης, καὶ τοὺς μετὰ τοῦ Προδίκου. ἐπεὶ δὲ πάντες συνεκαθεζόμεθα, ὁ Πρωταγόρας, νῦν δὴ ἄν, ἔφη, λέγοις, ὦ Σώκратες, ἐπειδὴ καὶ οἶδε πάρεισιν, περὶ ὧν ὀλίγον πρότερον μνεΐαν ἐποιῶ πρὸς ἐμὲ ὑπὲρ τοῦ νεανίσκου. ΣΩ.

318a

So I replied, “Protagoras, I will begin as I did earlier with the reason for my visit. Yes, it so happens that Hippocrates here wants to be an associate of yours, and he says that he would like to find out what benefit will accrue to him if he associates with you. That is as much as we have to say.”

318a

So Protagoras responded by saying, “Well, young man, if you associate with me, this is what you will obtain. On the very first day you spend time with me you will go home a better man, and the same thing will happen the following day. And every day thereafter you will continually develop for the better.”

καὶ ἐγὼ εἶπον ὅτι ἡ αὐτὴ μοι ἀρχὴ ἐστίν, ὦ Πρωταγόρα, ἥπερ ἄρτι, περὶ ὧν ἀφικόμην. Ἰπποκράτης γὰρ ὅδε τυγχάνει ἐν ἐπιθυμίᾳ ὧν τῆς σῆς συνουσίας· ὅτι οὖν αὐτῷ ἀποβήσεται, ἔάν σοι συνῇ, ἡδέως ἂν φησι πυθέσθαι. τοσοῦτος ὁ γε ἡμέτερος λόγος. ὑπολαβὼν οὖν ὁ Πρωταγόρας εἶπεν· ὦ νεανίσκε, ἔσται τοίνυν σοι, ἔάν ἐμοὶ συνῇς, ἢ ἂν ἡμέρα ἐμοὶ συγγένῃ, ἀπιέναι οἴκαδε βελτίονι γεγονότι, καὶ ἐν τῇ ὑστεραίᾳ ταῦτα ταῦτα· καὶ ἐκάστης ἡμέρας ἀεὶ ἐπὶ τὸ βέλτιον ἐπιδιδόναι.

318b

And having heard this, I said, “Protagoras, what you claim is nothing surprising. No, it is quite likely, since even you, as old as you are and as

wise as you are, would become better if someone were to teach you what you did not already know. But suppose the situation were different.

καὶ ἐγὼ ἀκούσας εἶπον· ὦ Πρωταγόρα, τοῦτο μὲν οὐδὲν θαυμαστὸν λέγεις, ἀλλὰ εἰκός, ἐπεὶ καὶ σύ, καίπερ τηλικούτος ὢν καὶ οὕτως σοφός, εἴ τις σε διδάξειεν ὃ μὴ τυγχάνοις ἐπιστάμενος, βελτίων ἂν γένοιο. ἀλλὰ μὴ οὕτως, ἀλλ' ὥσπερ ἂν εἰ αὐτίκα μάλα μεταβαλὼν τὴν ἐπιθυμίαν Ἰπποκράτης ὅδε ἐπιθυμήσειεν τῆς συνουσίας τούτου τοῦ νεανίσκου τοῦ νῦν νεωστὶ ἐπιδημοῦντος, Ζευξίππου τοῦ Ἡρακλεώτου, καὶ ἀφικόμενος παρ' αὐτόν, ὥσπερ παρὰ σέ

318c

Suppose Hippocrates here were to change his desire suddenly and develop a desire to associate with that young man who has only recently arrived in town, Zeuxippus of Heraclea. Suppose he met him and heard from Zeuxippus the same words he has just heard from you now, that every day he is with him he will be better and will develop, and if he were to ask him, 'What are you saying I shall be better at, and in what respect shall I develop?', Zeuxippus' reply to him would be, 'At painting.' And if he had spent time with Orthagoras, the Theban, and heard from him the same responses he has heard from you, and he were to ask that man in what respect he would become better every day by spending time with him, he would reply, 'At flute-playing.'¹⁶ So, please respond to the young man in this way, and to me when I put a question on his behalf. Hippocrates here, on associating with Protagoras will, on the very first day he spends time with him, depart a better man, and every day thereafter he will develop in this manner. But in what direction, Protagoras, and in relation to what?"

νῦν, ἀκούσειεν αὐτοῦ ταῦτα ταῦτα ἅπερ σοῦ, ὅτι ἐκάστης ἡμέρας συνὼν αὐτῷ βελτίων ἔσται καὶ ἐπιδώσει, εἰ αὐτόν ἐπανέροιτο· τί δὴ φῆς βελτίω ἔσεσθαι καὶ εἰς τί ἐπιδώσειν; εἶποι ἂν αὐτῷ ὁ Ζευξίππος ὅτι πρὸς γραφικὴν· καὶ εἰ Ὀρθαγόρα τῷ Θηβαίῳ συγγενόμενος, ἀκούσας ἐκείνου ταῦτα ταῦτα ἅπερ σοῦ, ἐπανέροιτο αὐτόν εἰς ὅτι βελτίων καθ'

ἡμέραν ἔσται συγγιγνόμενος ἐκείνῳ, εἴποι ἂν ὅτι εἰς αὐλήσιν· οὕτω δὴ καὶ σὺ εἰπὲ τῷ νεανίσκῳ καὶ ἐμοὶ ὑπὲρ

318d

When Protagoras had heard this he said, “You are putting your question very well, Socrates, and I enjoy responding to people who put their questions well. You see, if Hippocrates comes to join me, he will not suffer what he would have suffered by spending time with any other sophist.

τούτου ἐρωτῶντι, Ἴπποκράτης ὅδε Πρωταγόρα συγγενόμενος, ἧ ἂν αὐτῷ ἡμέρα συγγένηται, βελτίων ἄπεισι γενόμενος καὶ τῶν ἄλλων ἡμερῶν ἐκάστης οὕτως ἐπιδώσει εἰς τί, ὃ Πρωταγόρα, καὶ περὶ τοῦ; καὶ ὁ Πρωταγόρας ἐμοῦ ταῦτα ἀκούσας, σὺ τε καλῶς ἐρωτᾷς, ἔφη, ὃ Σώκρατες, καὶ ἐγὼ τοῖς καλῶς ἐρωτῶσι χαίρω ἀποκρινόμενος. Ἴπποκράτης γὰρ παρ’ ἐμὲ ἀφικόμενος οὐ πείσεται ἄπερ ἂν ἔπαθεν ἄλλῳ τῷ συγγενόμενος τῶν σοφιστῶν. οἱ μὲν γὰρ ἄλλοι λωβῶνται τοὺς νέους·

318e

In fact, the others mistreat the young people. For no sooner do they get away from the various skills than these sophists draw them back in once more, against their will, immersing them in the skills by teaching them calculation, astronomy, geometry and music.” And as he said this, he glanced at Hippias. “Yet, once he comes to me, he will learn nothing else except what he came to learn, and the subject matter is sound-judgement in relation to private affairs and in relation to civic affairs, how he may best manage his own household and how his words and deeds may be extremely influential over the business of the city.”

τὰς γὰρ τέχνας αὐτοὺς πεφευγότας ἄκοντας πάλιν αὖ ἄγοντες ἐμβάλλουσιν εἰς τέχνας, λογισμούς τε καὶ ἀστρονομίαν καὶ γεωμετρίαν καὶ μουσικὴν διδάσκοντες—καὶ ἅμα εἰς τὸν Ἰππίαν ἀπέβλεψεν—παρὰ δ’ ἐμὲ ἀφικόμενος μαθήσεται οὐ περὶ ἄλλου τοῦ ἢ περὶ οὗ ἦκει. τὸ δὲ μάθημά ἐστιν εὐβουλία περὶ τῶν οἰκείων, ὅπως ἂν ἄριστα τὴν αὐτοῦ οἰκίαν διοικοῖ,

319a

“So, am I following what you are saying?” I asked. “You seem to me to be describing political skill, and promising to produce men who are good citizens.”

319a

“That, Socrates, is precisely the profession I profess,” he said.

319a

“In that case,” I said, “you have acquired a great system, if indeed you have acquired it.

καὶ περὶ τῶν τῆς πόλεως, ὅπως τὰ τῆς πόλεως δυνατώτατος ἂν εἴη καὶ πράττειν καὶ λέγειν. ΣΩ. ἄρα, ἔφην ἐγώ, ἔπομαί σου τῷ λόγῳ; δοκεῖς γάρ μοι λέγειν τὴν πολιτικὴν τέχνην καὶ ὑπὸσχνεῖσθαι ποιεῖν ἄνδρας ἀγαθοὺς πολίτας. αὐτὸ μὲν οὖν τοῦτο ἐστίν, ἔφη, ὃ Σώκρατες, τὸ ἐπάγγελμα ὃ ἐπαγγέλλομαι. ἦ καλόν, ἦν δ' ἐγώ, τέχνημα ἄρα κέκτησαι, εἵπερ κέκτησαι· οὐ γάρ τι ἄλλο πρὸς γε σὲ εἰρήσεται ἢ ἅπερ νοῶ. ἐγὼ γὰρ τοῦτο, ὦ Πρωταγόρα, οὐκ ὥμην διδακτὸν

319b

For I should not say anything else to a man like you, except what I am really thinking. Indeed, I do not believe that this can be taught, Protagoras, yet, when you say that it can, I do not know how to doubt you. But it is only right that I explain the reason I believe that it cannot be taught or procured by people from other people. Indeed I agree, as do the other Greeks, that the Athenians are wise.

εἶναι, σοὶ δὲ λέγοντι οὐκ ἔχω ὅπως ἂν ἀπιστῶ. ὅθεν δὲ αὐτὸ ἡγοῦμαι οὐ διδακτὸν εἶναι μηδ' ὑπ' ἀνθρώπων παρασκευαστὸν ἀνθρώποις, δίκαιός εἰμι εἰπεῖν. ἐγὼ γὰρ Ἀθηναίους, ὥσπερ καὶ οἱ ἄλλοι Ἕλληνες, φημὶ σοφοὺς εἶναι. ὁρῶ οὖν, ὅταν συλλεγώμεν εἰς τὴν ἐκκλησίαν, ἐπειδὴν μὲν περὶ οἰκοδομίας τι δέη πράξαι τὴν πόλιν, τοὺς οἰκοδόμους μεταπεμπομένους συμβούλους περὶ τῶν οἰκοδομημάτων, ὅταν δὲ περὶ ναυπηγίας, τοὺς ναυπηγούς, καὶ τᾶλλα πάντα οὕτως,

319c

Now, I observe that whenever we gather together in the Assembly, and the city needs to engage in some activity related to construction works, they send for the builders to advise on what they are going to construct. When the issue is shipbuilding, they send for the shipwrights, and the same goes for all other subjects which they regard as capable of being learned and taught. Yet if anyone else attempts to advise them, someone whom they believe to be no practitioner, even if he is extremely beautiful and wealthy and of noble lineage, they accept him none the more for that. No, they ridicule him and cause a commotion until either he himself gives up on his attempt to speak because he has been shouted down, or the attendants drag him away or carry him out at the behest of the officials. So, on issues where they believe that a skill is involved, this is how they proceed.

ὅσα ἡγοῦνται μαθητά τε καὶ διδασκὰ εἶναι· ἐὰν δέ τις ἄλλος ἐπιχειρῇ αὐτοῖς συμβουλεύειν ὃν ἐκεῖνοι μὴ οἶονται δημιουργὸν εἶναι, κἂν πάνυ καλὸς ᾖ καὶ πλούσιος καὶ τῶν γενναίων, οὐδέν τι μᾶλλον ἀποδέχονται, ἀλλὰ καταγελῶσι καὶ θορυβοῦσιν, ἕως ἄν ἡ αὐτὸς ἀποστῇ ὁ ἐπιχειρῶν λέγειν καταθορυβηθείς, ἢ οἱ τοξόται αὐτὸν ἀφελκύσωσιν ἢ ἐξάρωνται κελεύόντων τῶν πρυτάνεων. περὶ μὲν οὖν ὧν οἶονται ἐν τέχνῃ εἶναι, οὕτω διαπράττονται· ἐπειδὴν δέ τι περὶ τῶν τῆς

319d

“However, once they need to decide on the administration of the city, it is all the same to them if the person who stands up to advise them about these issues is a carpenter, a blacksmith, a cobbler, a merchant, a ship owner, rich or poor, of noble lineage or none. It makes no difference.

319d

No one rebukes these speakers for this, as they did in the previous case, for trying to give advice without having learned about the matter from anyone, or without even having a teacher. For the Athenians obviously do not believe that this subject can be taught.

πόλεως διοικήσεως δέη βουλεύσασθαι, συμβουλεύει αὐτοῖς ἀνιστάμενος περὶ τούτων ὁμοίως μὲν τέκτων, ὁμοίως δὲ χαλκεὺς σκυτοτόμος, ἔμπορος ναύκληρος, πλούσιος πένης, γενναῖος ἀγεννής, καὶ τούτοις οὐδεὶς τοῦτο ἐπιπλήττει ὥσπερ τοῖς πρότερον, ὅτι οὐδαμῶθεν μαθὼν, οὐδὲ ὄντος διδασκάλου οὐδενὸς αὐτῷ, ἔπειτα συμβουλεύειν ἐπιχειρεῖ· δῆλον γὰρ ὅτι οὐχ ἡγοῦνται διδακτὸν εἶναι. μὴ τοῖνυν ὅτι τὸ κοινὸν τῆς

319e

“What is more, this conclusion applies not only in the communal aspect of the city, but also in private. For the wisest and most excellent of our citizens are unable to pass on this excellence, which they possess, to anyone else. Indeed Pericles, the father of these two young men here, educated them well and truly in the subjects for which he found teachers, yet when it comes to matters on which he himself is wise, he neither instructs them himself nor hands them over to anyone else.

πόλεως οὕτως ἔχει, ἀλλὰ ἰδίᾳ ἡμῖν οἱ σοφώτατοι καὶ ἄριστοι τῶν πολιτῶν ταύτην τὴν ἀρετὴν ἣν ἔχουσιν οὐχ οἷοί τε ἄλλοις παραδίδόναι· ΣΩ. ἐπεὶ Περικλῆς, ὁ τούτων τῶν νεανίσκων πατήρ, τούτους ἃ μὲν διδασκάλων εἶχετο καλῶς καὶ εὖ ἐπαίδευσεν,

320a

Rather they go about, grazing like sacred cattle, perhaps somehow stumbling upon excellence of their own accord. Or take Clinias if you like, the younger brother of Alcibiades here. The very same man, Pericles, acting as his guardian, was somehow afraid lest he be corrupted by Alcibiades, so he separated the two brothers, and placed Clinias with the family of Ariphron¹⁷ to be educated.

ἃ δὲ αὐτὸς σοφός ἐστιν οὔτε αὐτὸς παιδεύει οὔτε τῷ ἄλλῳ παραδίδωσιν, ἀλλ' αὐτοὶ περιόντες νέμονται ὥσπερ ἄφετοι, ἐάν που αὐτόματοι περιτύχωσιν τῇ ἀρετῇ. εἰ δὲ βούλει, Κλεινίαν, τὸν Ἀλκιβιάδου τουτουῖ νεώτερον ἀδελφόν, ἐπιτροπεύων ὁ αὐτὸς οὗτος ἀνὴρ Περικλῆς, δεδιὼς περὶ αὐτοῦ μὴ διαφθαρεῖ δὴ ὑπὸ Ἀλκιβιάδου,

ἀποσπάσας ἀπὸ τούτου, καταθέμενος ἐν Ἀρίφρονος ἐπαίδευε· καὶ πρὶν ἕξ μῆνας γεγονέναι,

320b

But before six months had elapsed he gave him back, at a loss as to what he should do with him.

ἀπέδωκε τούτῳ οὐκ ἔχων ὅτι χρήσαιτο αὐτῷ. καὶ ἄλλους σοι παμπόλλους ἔχω λέγειν, οἱ αὐτοὶ ἀγαθοὶ ὄντες οὐδένα πώποτε βελτίῳ ἐποίησαν οὔτε τῶν οἰκείων οὔτε τῶν ἀλλοτρίων. ἐγὼ οὖν, ὦ Πρωταγόρα, εἰς ταῦτα ἀποβλέπων οὐχ ἡγοῦμαι διδασκτὸν εἶναι ἀρετήν· ἐπειδὴ δέ σου ἀκούω ταῦτα λέγοντος, κάμπτομαι καὶ οἶμαί τί σε λέγειν διὰ τὸ ἡγεῖσθαί σε πολλῶν μὲν ἔμπειρον γεγονέναι, πολλὰ δὲ μεμαθηκέναι, τὰ δὲ αὐτὸν ἐξηυρηκέναι. εἰ οὖν ἔχεις ἐναργέστερον ἡμῖν ἐπιδειῖξαι ὥς

320c

And I can recount a whole range of other examples of those who are themselves good but have never yet made someone else good, either a member of their own family or someone from outside it. So, Protagoras, when I look at all this, I come to the view that excellence cannot be taught. Yet when I hear these assertions of yours, I waver, and I think you are talking sense, because I regard you as a highly experienced, very learned person who has made discoveries of his own. Therefore, if you can prove to us more clearly that excellence is teachable, do not begrudge us a response.

320c

Prove it.”

320c

“Well, Socrates,” he said, “I shan’t begrudge you. But as an older man addressing his juniors, should I make my point by telling you a story or by working through an argument?” Now, most of the gathering replied that he should proceed in whatever manner he wished. “Well,” said he, “I think it would be more pleasing to tell you a story.”

διδασκόν ἐστιν ἡ ἀρετή, μὴ φθονήσης ἀλλ' ἐπίδειξον. ἀλλ', ὦ Σώκρατες, ἔφη, οὐ φθονήσω· ἀλλὰ πότερον ὑμῖν, ὡς πρεσβύτερος νεωτέροις, μῦθον λέγων ἐπιδείξω ἢ λόγῳ διεξιθῶν; πολλοὶ οὖν αὐτῷ ὑπέλαβον τῶν παρακαθημένων ὁποτέρως βούλοιο οὕτως διεξιέναι. δοκεῖ τοίνυν μοι, ἔφη, χαριέστερον εἶναι μῦθον ὑμῖν λέγειν. ἦν γάρ ποτε χρόνος ὅτε θεοὶ μὲν ἦσαν, θνητὰ δὲ γένη

320d

“Now, there was once a time when, although there were gods, there were no mortal creatures of any kind. And when the moment of destiny came for the birth of the mortal creatures, the gods formed them within the earth, from earth and fire which they mixed together, and from whatever mixes with earth and fire. Once they were ready to bring the creatures forth into the light, they directed Prometheus and Epimetheus¹⁸ to equip them and assign powers to each, as appropriate. Epimetheus asked Prometheus if he himself could do the allocating. ‘Once I have done the allocating, you shall do the inspecting,’ he said, and having persuaded his brother of this, he made the allocations. To some he assigned strength without adding speed; others, who were weaker, he equipped with speed. Some of them he armed, and he devised an alternative means of preservation for those who were given an unarmed nature. To those whom he kept small, he allotted winged flight or an underground dwelling place, while those whom he caused to grow large he preserved

οὐκ ἦν. ἐπειδὴ δὲ καὶ τούτοις χρόνος ἦλθεν εἰμαρμένος γενέσεως, τυποῦσιν αὐτὰ θεοὶ γῆς ἔνδον ἐκ γῆς καὶ πυρὸς μείζαντες καὶ τῶν ὅσα πυρὶ καὶ γῇ κεράννυται. ἐπειδὴ δ' ἄγειν αὐτὰ πρὸς φῶς ἔμελλον, προσέταξαν Προμηθεῖ καὶ Ἐπιμηθεῖ κοσμήσαι τε καὶ νεῖμαι δυνάμεις ἐκάστοις ὡς πρέπει. Προμηθεῖα δὲ παραιτεῖται Ἐπιμηθεὺς αὐτὸς νεῖμαι, νείμαντος δέ μου, ἔφη, ἐπίσκεψαι καὶ οὕτω πείσας νέμει. νέμων δὲ τοῖς μὲν ἰσχὺν ἄνευ τάχους προσῆπτεν, τοὺς δ' ἀσθενεστέρους τάχει ἐκόσμει· τοὺς δὲ ὥπλιζε, τοῖς δ' ἄοπλον διδοὺς φύσιν ἄλλην τιν' αὐτοῖς ἐμηχανᾶτο δύνάμιν εἰς σωτηρίαν. ΣΩ. ἃ μὲν γὰρ αὐτῶν σμικρότητι

ἤμπισχεν, πτηνὸν φυγὴν ἢ κατάγειον οἴκησιν ἔνεμεν· ἃ δὲ ἠῖξε
μεγέθει, τῷδε

321a

through their own largeness. He also distributed the other faculties, balancing them equally in this way. As he was making these arrangements, he took care that no kind of creature should become extinct. When he had provided them with sufficient means of avoiding mutual annihilation, he devised a protection against the seasons sent from Zeus by wrapping them in thick hair and hard skin, adequate defences against the cold, that could also protect them from heat, so that, as they retired to their lair, these same defences would serve for each as their own self-grown bedding.

αὐτῷ αὐτὰ ἔσφζεν· καὶ τᾶλλα οὕτως ἐπανισῶν ἔνεμεν. ταῦτα δὲ
ἐμηχανᾶτο εὐλάβειαν ἔχων μή τι γένος αἰστωθείη· ἐπειδὴ δὲ αὐτοῖς
ἀλληλοφθοριῶν διαφυγὰς ἐπήρκεσε, πρὸς τὰς ἐκ Διὸς ὥρας εὐμάρειαν
ἐμηχανᾶτο ἀμφιεννὺς αὐτὰ πυκναῖς τε θριξίν καὶ στερεοῖς δέρμασιν,
ἱκανοῖς μὲν ἀμῦναι χειμῶνα, δυνατοῖς δὲ καὶ καύματα, καὶ εἰς εὐνὰς
ιοῦσιν ὅπως ὑπάρχοι τὰ αὐτὰ ταῦτα στρωμνὴ οἰκεία τε καὶ αὐτοφυῆς
ἐκάστω· καὶ

321b

Some he shod with hooves, others with hard, bloodless skin. Then he devised various kinds of food for the various species, the pasture of the earth for some, fruit from trees, or roots for others, and to some he gave other creatures as food for them to eat. These he graced with very few offspring, but he made the creatures that were eaten by them highly productive as a means of preserving the species. Now, since Epimetheus was not wise, he carelessly lavished all the powers upon the irrational creatures. So he was left with the human race still unprovided for, and he was at a loss as to what he should do. In his perplexity, Prometheus arrived to inspect the distribution, and he saw that although the other creatures were suitably provided for in all respects, the human race was naked, unshod, had no bedding and was unarmed. But by now the day of destiny was at hand, on which human

beings too had to come forth from the earth into the light. Prometheus, gripped by perplexity as to what sort of protection he might find for the humans, stole the wisdom that resides in skill from Hephaestus and Athena, along with fire, for it is impossible for anyone to attain the skill or for it to be useful without fire, and so it is that he bestows this gift upon humanity.

ὑποδῶν τὰ μὲν ὀπλαῖς, τὰ δὲ θριξίν καὶ δέρμασιν στερεοῖς καὶ ἀναίμοις. τούντεϋθεν τροφὰς ἄλλοις ἄλλας ἐξεπóριζεν, τοῖς μὲν ἐκ γῆς βοτάνην, ἄλλοις δὲ δένδρων καρπούς, τοῖς δὲ ῥίζας· ἔστι δ' οἷς ἔδωκεν εἶναι τροφήν ζώων ἄλλων βοράν· καὶ τοῖς μὲν ὀλιγογονίαν προσῆψε, τοῖς δ' ἀναλίσκομένοις ὑπὸ τούτων πολυγονίαν, σωτηρίαν τῷ γένει πορίζων. ἅτε δὴ οὖν οὐ πάνυ τι σοφὸς ὢν ὁ Ἐπιμηθεὺς ἔλαθεν αὐτὸν καταναλώσας τὰς δυνάμεις εἰς τὰ ἄλογα· λοιπὸν δὴ ἀκόσμητον ἔτι αὐτῷ ἦν τὸ ἀνθρώπων γένος, καὶ ἠπόρει ὅτι χρήσαιτο. ἀποροῦντι δὲ αὐτῷ ἔρχεται Προμηθεὺς ἐπισκεψόμενος τὴν νομὴν, καὶ ὁρᾷ τὰ μὲν ἄλλα ζῶα ἐμμελῶς πάντων ἔχοντα, τὸν δὲ ἄνθρωπον γυμνόν τε καὶ ἀνυπόδητον καὶ ἄστρωτον καὶ ἄοπλον· ἦδη δὲ καὶ ἡ εἰμαρμένη ἡμέρα παρῆν, ἐν ἣ ἔδει καὶ ἄνθρωπον ἐξιέναι ἐκ γῆς εἰς φῶς. ἀπορία οὖν σχόμενος ὁ Προμηθεὺς ἦντινα σωτηρίαν τῷ ἀνθρώπῳ εὔροι, κλέπτει Ἥφαίστου καὶ Ἀθηνᾶς τὴν ἔντεχνον σοφίαν σὺν πυρί—ἀμύχανον γὰρ ἦν ἄνευ πυρὸς αὐτὴν κτητὴν τῷ ἢ χρησίμην γενέσθαι—καὶ οὕτω δὴ δωρεῖται ἀνθρώπῳ. τὴν μὲν οὖν περὶ τὸν βίον σοφίαν ἄνθρωπος ταύτη ἔσχεν, τὴν δὲ πολιτικὴν οὐκ εἶχεν· ἦν γὰρ παρὰ τῷ Δίῳ. τῷ δὲ Προμηθεὶ εἰς μὲν τὴν ἀκρόπολιν τὴν τοῦ Διὸς οἴκησιν οὐκέτι ἐνεχώρει εἰσελθεῖν—πρὸς δὲ καὶ αἱ Διὸς φυλακαὶ φοβεραὶ ἦσαν—εἰς δὲ τὸ τῆς Ἀθηνᾶς καὶ Ἥφαίστου οἶκημα τὸ κοινόν, ἐν ᾧ

321e

“Now, that is how humanity came to possess the wisdom for everyday life, yet they did not possess wisdom in civic affairs, for that belonged to Zeus. There was no time for Prometheus to enter the high pinnacle that is the abode of Zeus, and the guardsmen of Zeus were too fearsome anyway. But he entered unnoticed into the shared workshop of Athena and Hephaestus wherein they practised their skill, stole the skill that

works through fire, the one that belongs to Hephaestus, and the other skill that belongs to Athena, and bestowed them upon humanity. And as a consequence of this, the life of man is well provided for, and yet it is said that because of Epimetheus, Prometheus was prosecuted afterwards for theft.

ἐφιλοτεχνείτην, λαθὼν εἰσέρχεται, καὶ κλέψας τὴν τε ἔμπυρον τέχνην τὴν τοῦ Ἥφαίστου καὶ τὴν ἄλλην τὴν τῆς Ἀθηνᾶς δίδωσιν ἀνθρώπῳ, καὶ ἐκ τούτου εὐπορία μὲν ἀνθρώπῳ τοῦ βίου γίγνεται, Προμηθεῖα δὲ δι' Ἐπιμηθεῖα ὕστερον, ἥπερ λέγεται, κλοπῆς δίκη μετῆλθεν. ΣΩ. ἐπειδὴ δὲ ὁ ἄνθρωπος θείας μετέσχε μοίρας, πρῶτον μὲν διὰ τὴν τοῦ θεοῦ συγγένειαν ζώων μόνον θεοὺς ἐνόμισεν, καὶ ἐπεχείρει βωμοὺς τε ἰδρῦεσθαι καὶ ἀγάλματα θεῶν· ἔπειτα φωνὴν καὶ ὀνόματα ταχὺ διηρθρώσατο τῇ τέχνῃ, καὶ οἰκῆσεις καὶ ἐσθῆτας καὶ ὑποδέσεις καὶ στρωμνὰς καὶ τὰς ἐκ γῆς τροφὰς ἤϋρετο. οὕτω δὲ παρεσκευασμένοι κατ' ἀρχὰς

322b

“Since humanity had shared in a divine portion, firstly, due to their kinship with the god, they were the only living creatures who acknowledged the gods, and they set about constructing altars and statues of gods. Then, by means of this skill, they quickly produced articulate sounds and names, and invented houses, clothing, shoes, bedding, and the production of food from the earth. Once they had been provided for in this way, the humans did not live communally at first, and there were no cities. So they were being ravaged by the wild beasts, because they were weaker than the beasts in every respect. And although their skilled craftsmanship was enough to secure them a source of food, it fell short when it came to warfare against the wild animals, for they did not yet possess skill in civic affairs of which warfare is a part. So they sought to come together and preserve themselves by building cities.

ἄνθρωποι ὥκουν σποράδην, πόλεις δὲ οὐκ ἦσαν· ἀπώλλυντο οὖν ὑπὸ τῶν θηρίων διὰ τὸ πανταχῇ αὐτῶν ἀσθενέστεροι εἶναι, καὶ ἡ

δημιουργική τέχνη αὐτοῖς πρὸς μὲν τροφήν ἱκανὴ βοηθὸς ἦν, πρὸς δὲ τὸν τῶν θηρίων πόλεμον ἐνδεής —πολιτικὴν γὰρ τέχνην οὐπω εἶχον, ἥς μέρος πολεμική— ἐζήτουν δὴ ἀθροίζεσθαι καὶ σώζεσθαι κτίζοντες πόλεις· ὅτ’ οὖν ἀθροισθεῖεν, ἡδίκουν ἀλλήλους ἅτε οὐκ ἔχοντες τὴν πολιτικὴν τέχνην, ὥστε πάλιν σκεδαννύμενοι διεφθείροντο.

322c

“Now, when they came together, they acted unjustly towards one another as they lacked skill in civic affairs. So they were dispersed once again, and subject to destruction. Then Zeus, fearing that our race might perish completely, sent Hermes, bearing respect and justice to humanity, so that there would be order in the cities and conjoining bonds of friendship. So Hermes asked Zeus in what manner he should bestow justice and respect upon humanity. ‘Should I allocate these in the same way that the skills were allocated? They were distributed so that one person possessing medical skill was enough to treat numerous laymen, and the same applied to the other skilled persons. So should I also distribute justice and respect among the humans in this way or should I allocate it to them all?’ ‘To them all,’ replied Zeus, ‘and let them all have a share in it, for cities will not come into existence if only a few people share in this skill, as happens with other skills. And set down a law from me whereby anyone unable to share in justice and respect is to die as a pestilence of the city.’

Ζεὺς οὖν δείσας περὶ τῷ γένει ἡμῶν μὴ ἀπόλοιτο πᾶν, Ἑρμῆν πέμπει ἄγοντα εἰς ἀνθρώπους αἰδῶ τε καὶ δίκην, ἵν’ εἶεν πόλεων κόσμοι τε καὶ δεσμοὶ φιλίας συναγωγοί. ἐρωτᾷ οὖν Ἑρμῆς Δία τίνα οὖν τρόπον δοίῃ δίκην καὶ αἰδῶ ἀνθρώποις· πότερον ὥς αἱ τέχναι νενέμηνται, οὕτω καὶ ταύτας νείμω; νενέμηνται δὲ ὥδε· εἷς ἔχων ἰατρικὴν πολλοῖς ἱκανὸς ἰδιώταις, καὶ οἱ ἄλλοι δημιουργοί· καὶ δίκην δὲ καὶ αἰδῶ οὕτω θῶ ἐν τοῖς ἀνθρώποις, ἢ ἐπὶ πάντας νείμω; ἐπὶ πάντας, ἔφη ὁ Ζεὺς, καὶ πάντες μετεχόντων· οὐ γὰρ ἂν γένοιντο πόλεις, εἰ ὀλίγοι αὐτῶν μετέχοιεν ὥσπερ ἄλλων τεχνῶν· καὶ νόμον γε θὲς παρ’ ἐμοῦ τὸν μὴ δυνάμενον αἰδοῦς καὶ δίκης μετέχειν κτείνειν ὥς νόσον πόλεως. οὕτω δὴ, ὦ Σώκρατες, καὶ διὰ ταῦτα οἱ τε ἄλλοι καὶ Ἀθηναῖοι, ὅταν μὲν περὶ ἀρετῆς

τεκτονικῆς ἢ λόγος ἢ ἄλλης τινὸς δημιουργικῆς, ὀλίγοις οἴονται μετεῖναι συμβουλῆς, καὶ ἐάν

322e

“Accordingly, for these reasons, Socrates, everyone, Athenians included, believes that few advisers should be involved whenever the deliberation relates to excellence in building, or some other skilled work. And if anyone outside of that few offers advice, they do not put up with it, as you have said, quite reasonably in my view. Yet when it comes to advice on excellence in civic affairs, where it is necessary to proceed entirely on the basis of justice and sound-mindedness, they quite reasonably accept contributions from all men because it is appropriate for everyone to share in this excellence; otherwise there would be no cities at all. That is the explanation for this, Socrates.

τις ἐκτὸς ὧν τῶν ὀλίγων συμβουλευῆ, οὐκ ἀνέχονται, ὥς σὺ φής—εἰκότως, ὥς ἐγὼ φημι— ΣΩ. ὅταν δὲ εἰς συμβουλὴν πολιτικῆς

323a

“In case you think you are being deceived, please accept this additional proof that the whole world really does believe that all men have a share of justice, and also civic excellence in general.

ἀρετῆς ἴωσιν, ἣν δεῖ διὰ δικαιοσύνης πᾶσαν ἰέναι καὶ σωφροσύνης, εἰκότως ἅπαντος ἀνδρὸς ἀνέχονται, ὥς παντὶ προσήκον ταύτης γε μετέχειν τῆς ἀρετῆς ἢ μὴ εἶναι πόλεις. αὕτη, ὦ Σώκρατες, τούτου αἰτία. ἵνα δὲ μὴ οἷᾳ ἀπαταῖσθαι ὥς τῷ ὄντι ἡγοῦνται πάντες ἄνθρωποι πάντα ἄνδρα μετέχειν δικαιοσύνης τε καὶ τῆς ἄλλης πολιτικῆς ἀρετῆς, τόδε αὖ λαβὲ τεκμήριον. ἐν γὰρ ταῖς ἄλλαις ἀρεταῖς, ὥσπερ σὺ λέγεις, ἐάν τις φῇ ἀγαθὸς αὐλητῆς εἶναι, ἢ ἄλλην ἡντινοῦν τέχνην ἣν μὴ ἐστίν, ἢ καταγελῶσιν

323b

In the case of the other excellences, as you say yourself, if someone claims to be a good flute player or to be good at any other skill which he is not good at, they laugh at him or get angry with him, and his relatives come and rebuke him for being insane. Yet, in the case of

justice and excellence in civic affairs generally, if a person whom they know to be unjust should himself declare the truth about himself in front of everyone, they regard this as madness in such circumstances, even though in the previous case, flute-playing, they regarded speaking the truth as sound-mindedness. Indeed, they say that everyone should claim to be just, regardless of whether they are or are not, and anyone who is not pretending to be just is insane, because it is necessary for everyone to share in it in some way or other if they are to live with their fellow men. So they quite reasonably accept all men as advisers on this particular excellence because they believe that everyone has a share in it. That is all I have to say on that issue.

ἢ χαλεπαίνουνσιν, καὶ οἱ οἰκεῖοι προσιόντες νουθετοῦσιν ὡς μαινόμενον· ἐν δὲ δικαιοσύνη καὶ ἐν τῇ ἄλλῃ πολιτικῇ ἀρετῇ, ἐάν τινα καὶ εἰδῶσιν ὅτι ἄδικός ἐστιν, ἐὰν οὗτος αὐτὸς καθ' αὐτοῦ τάληθῇ λέγει ἐναντίον πολλῶν, ὃ ἐκεῖ σωφροσύνην ἡγοῦντο εἶναι, τάληθῇ λέγειν, ἐνταῦθα μανίαν, καὶ φασιν πάντας δεῖν φάναι εἶναι δικαίους, ἐάντε ᾧσιν ἐάντε μή, ἢ μαίνεσθαι τὸν μὴ προσποιούμενον δικαιοσύνην· ὡς ἀναγκαῖον

323c

“Next I shall try to show you that they do not think that it is present naturally or of its own accord. Rather, it is capable of being taught, and those who acquire it acquire it through diligence.

οὐδένα ὄντιν' οὐχὶ ἀμῶς γέ πως μετέχειν αὐτῆς, ἢ μὴ εἶναι ἐν ἀνθρώποις. ὅτι μὲν οὖν πάντ' ἄνδρα εἰκότως ἀποδέχονται περὶ ταύτης τῆς ἀρετῆς σύμβουλον διὰ τὸ ἡγεῖσθαι παντὶ μετεῖναι αὐτῆς, ταῦτα λέγω· ὅτι δὲ αὐτὴν οὐ φύσει ἡγοῦνται εἶναι οὐδ' ἀπὸ τοῦ αὐτομάτου, ἀλλὰ διδακτόν τε καὶ ἐξ ἐπιμελείας παραγίγνεσθαι ᾧ ἂν παραγίγηται, τοῦτό σοι μετὰ τοῦτο πειράσομαι ἀποδείξαι. ὅσα γὰρ ἡγοῦνται ἀλλήλους κακὰ ἔχειν ἄνθρωποι

323d

For people who believe that any of their fellow men have bad qualities, due to nature or chance, do not get angry with them or instruct them

or punish them, so that they will not be as they are.

φύσει ἢ τύχῃ, οὐδεὶς θυμοῦται οὐδὲ νουθετεῖ οὐδὲ διδάσκει οὐδὲ κολάζει τοὺς ταῦτα ἔχοντας, ἵνα μὴ τοιοῦτοι ὦσιν, ἀλλ' ἐλεοῦσιν· οἷον τοὺς αἰσχροὺς ἢ μικροὺς ἢ ἀσθενεῖς τίς οὕτως ἀνόητος ὥστε τι τούτων ἐπιχειρεῖν ποιεῖν; ταῦτα μὲν γὰρ οἶμαι ἴσασιν ὅτι φύσει τε καὶ τύχῃ τοῖς ἀνθρώποις γίγνεται, τὰ καλὰ καὶ τὰναντία τούτοις· ὅσα δὲ ἐξ ἐπιμελείας καὶ ἀσκήσεως καὶ διδαχῆς οἴονται γίγνεσθαι ἀγαθὰ ἀνθρώποις,

323e

Rather, they pity them. Who would be so stupid as to try to inflict any of this upon people who are ugly or small or weak? Indeed, they know, I believe, that these advantages and their opposites come to people by nature and by chance. Whereas if anyone does not possess those good qualities – which, in their view, come to people through diligence, practice and instruction – but has the opposite qualities instead, the bad ones, surely these are the people who become the target of anger, punishment and admonishment. Injustice is one of these bad qualities, so is impiety, and, in short, everything that is in opposition to civic excellence. Hence, everyone gets angry with every offender, and they admonish them, obviously because this excellence is capable of being acquired by diligence and study. Indeed, Socrates, if you would like to consider what precisely punishment can do to those who act unjustly, this will teach you that people believe that excellence can be acquired.

ἐάν τις ταῦτα μὴ ἔχῃ, ἀλλὰ τὰναντία τούτων κακά, ἐπὶ τούτοις που οἷ τε θυμοὶ γίνονται καὶ αἱ κολάσεις καὶ αἱ νουθετήσεις. ΣΩ. ὣν ἐστὶν ἓν καὶ ἡ ἀδικία καὶ ἡ ἀσέβεια καὶ συλλήβδην πᾶν τὸ ἐναντίον τῆς πολιτικῆς ἀρετῆς· ἔνθα δὴ πᾶς παντὶ θυμοῦται καὶ νουθετεῖ, δῆλον ὅτι ὡς ἐξ ἐπιμελείας καὶ μαθήσεως κτητῆς οὕσης. εἰ γὰρ ἐθέλεις ἐννοῆσαι τὸ κολάζειν, ὦ Σώκρατες, τοὺς ἀδικοῦντας τί ποτε δύναται, αὐτό σε διδάξει ὅτι οἷ γε ἄνθρωποι ἡγοῦνται παρασκευαστὸν εἶναι ἀρετήν. οὐδεὶς γὰρ κολάζει τοὺς ἀδικοῦντας πρὸς τούτῳ τὸν νοῦν ἔχων καὶ τούτου ἕνεκα, ὅτι ἠδίκησεν, ὅστις

324b

For no one punishes those who act unjustly because they acted unjustly with this alone in mind and only on account of this behaviour unless he is inflicting punishment irrationally, as if he were a wild animal. But someone who undertakes the infliction of punishment on the basis of reason does not seek vengeance for the past injustice, for that would not undo what had been done. Rather, it is inflicted for the sake of the future, so that the wrongdoer himself will not act unjustly again.

μη ὥσπερ θηρίον ἀλογίστως τιμωρεῖται· ὁ δὲ μετὰ λόγου ἐπιχειρῶν κολάζειν οὐ τοῦ παρεληλυθότος ἔνεκα ἀδικήματος τιμωρεῖται—οὐ γὰρ ἂν τό γε πραχθὲν ἀγέννητον θεῖη—ἀλλὰ τοῦ μέλλοντος χάριν, ἵνα μὴ αὖθις ἀδικήσῃ μήτε αὐτὸς οὗτος μήτε ἄλλος ὁ τοῦτον ἰδὼν κολασθέντα. καὶ τοιαύτην διάνοιαν ἔχων διανοεῖται παιδευτὴν εἶναι ἀρετὴν· ἀποτροπῆς γοῦν ἔνεκα κολάζει. ταύτην οὖν τὴν δόξαν πάντες ἔχουσιν ὅσοιπερ

324c

Nor will anyone who sees this fellow punished. And someone who thinks like this is of the view that excellence can be instilled by education, since he inflicts punishment as a deterrent. Now, this view is held by all those who inflict punishment in private or in public. People in general, and your fellow Athenians in particular, seek vengeance and punish those who in their view act unjustly.

324c

So, based on this argument, the Athenians are included among those who believe that excellence can be procured and is capable of being taught.

τιμωροῦνται καὶ ἰδίᾳ καὶ δημοσίᾳ. τιμωροῦνται δὲ καὶ κολάζονται οἱ τε ἄλλοι ἄνθρωποι οὓς ἂν οἶωνται ἀδικεῖν, καὶ οὐχ ἥκιστα Ἀθηναῖοι οἱ σοὶ πολῖται· ὥστε κατὰ τοῦτον τὸν λόγον καὶ Ἀθηναῖοί εἰσι τῶν ἡγουμένων παρασκευαστὸν εἶναι καὶ διδασκτὸν ἀρετὴν. ὥς μὲν οὖν εἰκότως ἀποδέχονται οἱ σοὶ πολῖται καὶ χαλκῆως καὶ σκυτοτόμου συμβουλευόντος τὰ πολιτικά, καὶ ὅτι διδασκτὸν καὶ παρασκευαστὸν ἡγοῦνται ἀρετὴν, ἀποδέδεικται σοι, ὦ Σώκρατες, ἱκανῶς, ὥς γέ μοι

324d

“Well, Socrates, it seems, to me anyway, that you have been given adequate proof that it is reasonable for your fellow citizens to accept the blacksmith and the cobbler as advisers on civic affairs, and that they believe that excellence can be imparted and is capable of being taught.

φαίνεται. ἔτι δὴ λοιπὴ ἀπορία ἐστίν, ἣν ἀπορεῖς περὶ τῶν ἀνδρῶν τῶν ἀγαθῶν, τί δὴποτε οἱ ἄνδρες οἱ ἀγαθοὶ τὰ μὲν ἄλλα τοὺς αὐτῶν υἱεῖς διδάσκουσιν ἃ διδασκάλων ἔχεται καὶ σοφοὺς ποιοῦσιν, ἣν δὲ αὐτοὶ ἀρετὴν ἀγαθοὶ οὐδενὸς βελτίους ποιοῦσιν. τούτου δὴ πέρι, ὦ Σώκρατες, οὐκέτι μῦθόν σοι ἔρῳ ἀλλὰ λόγον. ὥδε γὰρ ἐννόησον· πότερον ἔστιν τι ἐν ἧ οὐκ ἔστιν οὗ ἀναγκαῖον πάντας τοὺς πολίτας μετέχειν,

324e

“Now, there is still one puzzle left, the issue you raised about the good men. Why, exactly, is it that good men instruct their own sons in the broad range of subjects for which teachers can be found, and make them wise therein, yet when it comes to the excellence in which they themselves are good, they make their sons no better than anyone else? Now, on this issue, Socrates, I shall no longer recount a story to you, but an argument. Well, think about this. Is there or is there not one thing in which all the citizens must share if there is to be a city? Indeed, the resolution of the difficulty you raise lies in this question and nowhere else. For if there is one, and this one is not the skill of the builder, the blacksmith or the potter, but justice, sound-mindedness and holiness, and what I collectively refer to as one thing, the excellence of man, if this is what everyone should share in, and if all men should act in consort with this if they wish to learn or enact anything else, and if anyone, child, man or woman, who has no share in this should be instructed and punished until they have become better because of the punishment, and if anyone who does not heed the punishment and instruction should be cast out of the city or put to death because he is incurable, if this is how matters stand, and yet in spite of its nature good men teach their sons everything else with the

exception of this, behold how strangely good men are behaving. For we have shown that they believe that this can be taught privately and publicly. Yet, in spite of the fact that this can be taught and cultivated, do they really teach those other subjects to their sons – the ones that do not carry the death penalty should the boys lack the knowledge thereof – while, on the other hand, failing to teach or lavish the utmost care on that subject which does carry the penalty of death or exile for their sons, if they neither learn this nor cultivate excellence, and not just death, but confiscation of their property, and, in short, the total overthrow of their family? No, Socrates, we must believe that they teach and admonish them all through their lives, beginning when they are small children.

εἴπερ μέλλει πόλις εἶναι; ἐν τούτῳ γὰρ αὕτη λύεται ἡ ἀπορία ἣν σὺ ἀπορεῖς ἢ ἄλλοθι οὐδαμοῦ. ΣΩ. εἰ μὲν γὰρ ἔστιν, καὶ τοῦτό ἐστιν τὸ ἐν οὐ τεκτονικὴ οὐδὲ χαλκεία οὐδὲ κεραμεία ἀλλὰ δικαιοσύνη καὶ σωφροσύνη καὶ τὸ ὅσιον εἶναι, καὶ συλλήβδην ἐν αὐτὸ προσαγορεύω εἶναι ἀνδρὸς ἀρετὴν—εἰ τοῦτ' ἐστὶν οὗ δεῖ πάντας μετέχειν καὶ μετὰ τούτου πάντ' ἄνδρα, ἐάν τι καὶ ἄλλο βούληται μαθάνειν ἢ πράττειν, οὕτω πράττειν, ἄνευ δὲ τούτου μή, ἢ τὸν μὴ μετέχοντα καὶ διδάσκειν καὶ κολάζειν καὶ παῖδα καὶ ἄνδρα καὶ γυναῖκα, ἕωςπερ ἂν κολαζόμενος βελτίων γένηται, ὃς δ' ἂν μὴ ὑπακούῃ κολαζόμενος καὶ διδασκόμενος, ὥς ἀνίατον ὄντα τοῦτον ἐκβάλλειν ἐκ τῶν πόλεων ἢ ἀποκτείνειν—εἰ οὕτω μὲν ἔχει, οὕτω δ' αὐτοῦ πεφυκός τις οἱ ἀγαθοὶ ἄνδρες εἰ τὰ μὲν ἄλλα διδάσκονται τοὺς υἱεῖς, τοῦτο δὲ μή, σκέψαι ὥς θαυμασίως γίνονται οἱ ἀγαθοί. ὅτι μὲν γὰρ διδασκτὸν αὐτὸ ἡγούνται καὶ ἰδίᾳ καὶ δημοσίᾳ, ἀπεδείξαμεν· διδασκτοῦ δὲ ὄντος καὶ θεραπευτοῦ τὰ μὲν ἄλλα ἄρα τοὺς υἱεῖς διδάσκονται, ἐφ' οἷς οὐκ ἔστι θάνατος ἢ ζημία ἐὰν μὴ ἐπίστωνται, ἐφ' ᾧ δὲ ἢ τε ζημία θάνατος αὐτῶν τοῖς παισὶ καὶ φυγαὶ μὴ μαθοῦσι μηδὲ θεραπευθεῖσιν εἰς ἀρετὴν, καὶ πρὸς τῷ θανάτῳ χρημάτων τε δημεύσεις καὶ ὥς ἔπος εἰπεῖν συλλήβδην τῶν οἰκῶν ἀνατροπαί, ταῦτα δ' ἄρα οὐ διδάσκονται οὐδ' ἐπιμελοῦνται πᾶσαν ἐπιμέλειαν; οἷσθαί γε χρή, ὦ Σώκρατες. ἐκ παίδων σμικρῶν ἀρξάμενοι, μέχρι οὔπερ ἂν ζῶσι, καὶ διδάσκουσι καὶ νοουθετοῦσιν.

ἐπειδὴν θάττον συνιῇ τις τὰ λεγόμενα, καὶ τροφὸς καὶ μήτηρ καὶ παιδαγωγὸς καὶ αὐτὸς

325d

“As soon as someone can understand what is being said, his nurse, mother, trainer and even his father exert themselves so that the child may excel, teaching him with every word and deed, and pointing out that this is just, that unjust; this is noble, that base; this is sacred, that profane; do this, but do not do that. If he obeys willingly, all is well, but otherwise they correct him with threats and blows as though he were a twisted and bent piece of wood. Afterwards they send him to various teachers, directing them to attend much more to the proper conduct of the children than to writing and lyre-playing. The teachers attend to these matters, and once the children have learned writing and are beginning to understand the written word just as well as the spoken word, they provide them with the works of good poets to read in the classroom, and compel them to learn these by heart. These contain many words of warning and numerous narratives, praises and eulogies of the good men of old, so that the child may be inspired to imitate them, and may yearn to become a man of this sort. The lyre teachers, doing the same sort of thing, pay attention to sound-mindedness and how the young people may refrain from doing wrong. What is more, once they have learned to play the harp, they teach them the works of some other good poets, lyric poets, which they arrange to the tunes of the harp, and they compel the rhythms and harmonies to take up their abode in the souls of children so that they may be gentler, and be effective in word and deed by becoming more graceful and harmonious, for the whole life of man stands in need of grace and harmony.

ὁ πατήρ περὶ τούτου διαμάχονται, ὅπως ὡς βέλτιστος ἔσται ὁ παῖς, παρ’ ἑκάστον καὶ ἔργον καὶ λόγον διδάσκοντες καὶ ἐνδεικνύμενοι ὅτι τὸ μὲν δίκαιον, τὸ δὲ ἄδικον, καὶ τόδε μὲν καλόν, τόδε δὲ αἰσχρόν, καὶ τόδε μὲν ὄσιον, τόδε δὲ ἀνόσιον, καὶ τὰ μὲν ποιεῖ, τὰ δὲ μὴ ποιεῖ. καὶ ἐὰν μὲν ἐκὼν πείθεται· εἰ δὲ μή, ὥσπερ ξύλον διαστρεφόμενον καὶ

καμπτόμενον εὐθύνουσιν ἀπειλαῖς καὶ πληγαῖς. μετὰ δὲ ταῦτα εἰς διδασκάλων πέμποντες πολὺ μᾶλλον ἐντέλλονται ἐπιμελεῖσθαι εὐκοσμίας τῶν παίδων ἢ γραμμάτων τε καὶ κιθαρίσεως· ΣΩ. οἱ δὲ διδάσκαλοι τούτων τε ἐπιμελοῦνται, καὶ ἐπειδὴν αὐτὰ γράμματα μάθωσιν καὶ μέλλωσιν συνήσειν τὰ γεγραμμένα ὥσπερ τότε τὴν φωνήν, παρατιθέασιν αὐτοῖς ἐπὶ τῶν βάθρων ἀναγινώσκειν ποιητῶν ἀγαθῶν ποιήματα καὶ ἐκμανθάνειν ἀναγκάζουσιν, ἐν οἷς πολλὰ μὲν νουθετήσεις ἔνεισιν πολλὰ δὲ διέξοδοι καὶ ἔπαινοι καὶ ἐγκώμια παλαιῶν ἀνδρῶν ἀγαθῶν, ἵνα ὁ παῖς ζηλῶν μιμῆται καὶ ὀρέγεται τοιοῦτος γενέσθαι. οἱ τ' αὖ κιθαρισταί, ἕτερα τοιαῦτα, σωφροσύνης τε ἐπιμελοῦνται καὶ ὅπως ἂν οἱ νέοι μὴδὲν κακουργῶσιν· πρὸς δὲ τούτοις, ἐπειδὴν κιθαρίζειν μάθωσιν, ἄλλων αὖ ποιητῶν ἀγαθῶν ποιήματα διδάσκουσι μελοποιῶν, εἰς τὰ κιθαρίσματα ἐντείνοντες, καὶ τοὺς ῥυθμούς τε καὶ τὰς ἁρμονίας ἀναγκάζουσιν οἰκιοῦσθαι ταῖς ψυχαῖς τῶν παίδων, ἵνα ἡμερώτεροί τε ᾖσιν, καὶ εὐρυθμότεροι καὶ εὐαρμοστότεροι γιγνόμενοι χρήσιμοι ᾖσιν εἰς τὸ λέγειν τε καὶ πράττειν· πᾶς γὰρ ὁ βίος τοῦ ἀνθρώπου εὐρυθμίας τε καὶ εὐαρμοστίας δεῖται. ἔτι τοίνυν πρὸς τούτοις εἰς παιδοτρίβου πέμπουσιν, ἵνα τὰ σώματα βελτίω ἔχοντες ὑπηρετῶσι τῇ διανοίᾳ χρηστῇ

326c

And, in addition even to this, they send them to trainers so that their bodies may be in better shape to act as the servant of the mind, which is now so effective, and they may not be compelled to turn cowards, either in war or any other situations, due to the poor condition of their bodies. Those who are in the best position to do all this do it best, and it is the wealthy who are best able to do so, and their sons attend teachers, beginning at the earliest possible age, and giving it up at the latest possible age. Once they are quit of their teachers, the city, for its part, compels them to learn the laws and to live in accord therewith, in accord with that pattern, so that they do not behave in a random manner of their own volition. Rather, they act as writing teachers do with children who are not yet skilled at writing. They write letters in outline with their stylus, and then give the tablet, thus inscribed, to

the child, and make him write with the lines as a guide. So too does the city write its laws, which are inventions of good lawgivers of times past. It compels people to rule and be ruled in accordance with these, and punishes anyone who departs from them. And the name of this punishment, both among yourselves here and everywhere else, is correction, for justice provides correction. Now, when so much attention is paid to excellence, privately and publicly, are you really surprised, Socrates, and puzzled as to whether excellence can be taught? But there is no cause for surprise. No, there would be much more cause for surprise if it could not be taught.

οὕση, καὶ μὴ ἀναγκάζονται ἀποδειλιάν διὰ τὴν πονηρίαν τῶν σωμάτων καὶ ἐν τοῖς πολέμοις καὶ ἐν ταῖς ἄλλαις πράξεσιν. καὶ ταῦτα ποιοῦσιν οἱ μάλιστα δυνάμενοι μάλιστα—μάλιστα δὲ δύνανται οἱ πλουσιώτατοι—καὶ οἱ τούτων ὑεῖς, πρωαίτατα εἰς διδασκάλων τῆς ἡλικίας ἀρξάμενοι φοιτᾶν, ὀψιαίτατα ἀπαλλάττονται. ἐπειδὴν δὲ ἐκ διδασκάλων ἀπαλλαγῶσιν, ἡ πόλις αὖ τοὺς τε νόμους ἀναγκάζει μανθάνειν καὶ κατὰ τούτους ζῆν κατὰ παράδειγμα, ἵνα μὴ αὐτοὶ ἐφ’ αὐτῶν εἰκῇ πράττωσιν, ἀλλ’ ἀτεχνῶς ὥσπερ οἱ γραμματισταὶ τοῖς μήπω δεινοῖς γράφειν τῶν παίδων ὑπογράψαντες γραμμὰς τῇ γραφίδι οὕτω τὸ γραμματεῖον διδόασιν καὶ ἀναγκάζουσι γράφειν κατὰ τὴν ὑφήγησιν τῶν γραμμῶν, ὥς δὲ καὶ ἡ πόλις νόμους ὑπογράψασα, ἀγαθῶν καὶ παλαιῶν νομοθετῶν εὐρήματα, κατὰ τούτους ἀναγκάζει καὶ ἄρχειν καὶ ἄρχεσθαι, ὃς δ’ ἂν ἐκτὸς βαίνειν τούτων, κολάζει καὶ ὄνομα τῇ κολάσει ταύτῃ καὶ παρ’ ὑμῖν καὶ ἄλλοθι πολλαχοῦ, ὥς εὐθυνούσης τῆς δίκης, εὐθύναι. τοσαύτης οὖν τῆς ἐπιμελείας οὕσης περὶ ἀρετῆς ἰδίᾳ καὶ δημοσίᾳ, θαυμάζεις, ὦ Σώκρατες, καὶ ἀπορεῖς εἰ διδακτόν ἐστιν ἀρετὴ; ἀλλ’ οὐ χρὴ θαυμάζειν, ἀλλὰ πολὺ μᾶλλον εἰ μὴ διδακτόν. ΣΩ. διὰ τί οὖν τῶν ἀγαθῶν πατέρων πολλοὶ ὑεῖς φαῦλοι γίνονται; τοῦτο αὖ μάθε· οὐδὲν γὰρ θαυμαστόν, εἴπερ ἀληθὴ ἐγὼ ἐν τοῖς ἔμπροσθεν ἔλεγον, ὅτι τούτου τοῦ πράγματος,

327a

“So why do so many sons of good fathers turn out mediocre? You need to understand this too. Indeed, it is nothing surprising if, in fact, I was

speaking the truth earlier when I said that when it comes to the matter of excellence, no one should distance himself from this if there is to be a city. Indeed, if what I am saying is actually the case, as it most certainly is, then select any other activity or subject whatsoever and reflect upon it. Suppose it were impossible that there be a city unless we were all flute players, each according to his ability, and everyone taught this to everyone else in public and in private, and rebuked anyone who did not play well, and did not hold back in doing so. It would be just like the present situation, where no one holds back or conceals his expertise on matters of justice and law, as one would in other areas of expertise. For the justice and excellence we exercise towards one another presumably benefits us all, and, as a consequence, everyone is eager to tell everyone else what is right and just, and give them instruction.

τῆς ἀρετῆς, εἰ μέλλει πόλις εἶναι, οὐδένα δεῖ ἰδιωτεύειν. εἰ γὰρ δὴ ὁ λέγω οὕτως ἔχει—ἔχει δὲ μάλιστα πάντων οὕτως—ἐνθυμήθητι ἄλλο τῶν ἐπιτηδευμάτων ὅτιοῦν καὶ μαθημάτων προελόμενος. εἰ μὴ οἶόν τ' ἦν πόλιν εἶναι εἰ μὴ πάντες αὐληταὶ ἦμεν ὁποῖός τις ἐδύνατο ἕκαστος, καὶ τοῦτο καὶ ἰδίᾳ καὶ δημοσίᾳ πᾶς πάντα καὶ ἐδίδασκε καὶ ἐπέπληττε τὸν μὴ καλῶς αὐλοῦντα, καὶ μὴ ἐφθόνει τούτου, ὥσπερ νῦν τῶν δικαίων καὶ τῶν νομίμων οὐδεὶς φθονεῖ οὐδ' ἀποκρύπτεται ὥσπερ τῶν ἄλλων τεχνημάτων—λυσιτελεῖ γὰρ οἶμαι ἡμῖν ἢ ἀλλήλων δικαιοσύνη καὶ ἀρετὴ διὰ ταῦτα πᾶς παντὶ προθύμως λέγει καὶ διδάσκει καὶ τὰ δίκαια καὶ τὰ νόμιμα—εἰ οὖν οὕτω καὶ ἐν αὐλήσει πᾶσαν προθυμίαν καὶ ἀφθονίαν εἶχομεν ἀλλήλους διδάσκειν, οἷετις ἂν τι, ἔφη, μᾶλλον, ὦ Σώκρατες, τῶν ἀγαθῶν αὐλητῶν ἀγαθοὺς αὐλητὰς τοὺς υἱεῖς γίγνεσθαι ἢ τῶν φαύλων; οἶμαι μὲν οὐ, ἀλλὰ ὅτου ἔτυχεν ὁ υἱὸς εὐφυέστατος γενόμενος εἰς αὐλησιν, οὗτος

327c

Now, if we were also to have the same total eagerness and lack of restraint in teaching flute-playing to one another, do you think, Socrates,” he said, “that the sons of any of the good flute players would prove to be better flute players than the sons of ordinary players? I

think not. No, if anyone had a son with a natural ability in flute-playing, the boy would grow in reputation, and if he had no natural ability he would never be famous. The son of a good flute player may often turn out to be inferior, and the son of an ordinary one to be good. In any case, they would all be competent flute players compared to unlearned folk who know nothing about flute-playing. You should also think about the present case in the same way. Among those educated by laws and by their fellow men, even the person who seems completely unjust is a just man, a practitioner in the matter of justice, if he is judged by the standard of men devoid of education, with no law courts, no laws and no compulsion of any kind to make them pay attention to excellence, wild folk just like those presented at the Lenaean festival by the playwright Pherecrates last year.¹⁹ Certainly, if you fell in with people of that sort, just like those haters of humanity in the chorus of that play, you would be grateful to meet up with Eurypatus and Phrynondas,²⁰ and you would wail longingly for the wickedness of the people here.

ἂν ἐλλόγιμος ἠδύζηθη, ὅτου δὲ ἀφυής, ἀκλεής· καὶ πολλάκις μὲν ἀγαθοῦ αὐλητοῦ φαῦλος ἂν ἀπέβη, πολλάκις δ' ἂν φαύλου ἀγαθός· ἀλλ' οὖν αὐληταί γ' ἂν πάντες ἦσαν ἱκανοὶ ὡς πρὸς τοὺς ἰδιώτας καὶ μηδὲν αὐλήσεως ἐπαίοντας. οὕτως οἴου καὶ νῦν, ὅστις σοι ἀδικώτατος φαίνεται ἄνθρωπος τῶν ἐν νόμοις καὶ ἀνθρώποις τετραμμένων, δίκαιον αὐτὸν εἶναι καὶ δημιουργὸν τούτου τοῦ πράγματος, εἰ δέοι αὐτὸν κρίνεσθαι πρὸς ἀνθρώπους οἷς μήτε παιδεία ἐστὶν μήτε δικαστήρια μήτε νόμοι μηδὲ ἀνάγκη μηδεμία διὰ παντὸς ἀναγκάζουσα ἀρετῆς ἐπιμελεῖσθαι, ἀλλ' εἶεν ἄγριοί τινες οἰοίπερ οὓς πέρυσιν Φερεκράτης ὁ ποιητὴς ἐδίδασκεν ἐπὶ Ληναίῳ. ἡ σφόδρα ἐν τοῖς τοιούτοις ἀνθρώποις γενόμενος, ὥσπερ οἱ ἐν ἐκείνῳ τῷ χορῷ μισάνθρωποι, ἀγαπήσας ἂν εἰ ἐντύχοις Εὐρυβάτῳ καὶ Φρυνώνδῃ, καὶ ἀνολοφύραι· ἂν ποθῶν τὴν τῶν ἐνθάδε ἀνθρώπων πονηρίαν. νῦν δὲ τρυφᾷς, ὦ Σώκρατες, διότι πάντες διδάσκαλοί εἰσιν ἀρετῆς καθ' ὅσον δύνανται ἕκαστος, καὶ οὐδεὶς σοι φαίνεται· ΣΩ. εἴθ', ὥσπερ ἂν εἰ ζητοῖς τίς διδάσκαλος

328a

“And now you are putting on airs, Socrates, because everyone is a teacher of excellence, each to the extent of his ability, yet it seems to you that there are none. It is as if you were to ask who the teacher of the Greek language is. There is not one to be found. And in my view, if you were to ask who would teach the sons of our craftsmen the very skill which they have obviously learned from their own father – insofar as the father and his associates who had the same skill were able to do so – if you ask who in turn would teach these boys, I do not think it an easy matter to produce a teacher, Socrates, even though it is extremely easy to do so for others who are devoid of experience. And the same argument applies to excellence, and to everything else. But if there

τοῦ ἐλληνίζειν, οὐδ’ ἂν εἷς φανείη, οὐδέ γ’ ἂν οἶμαι εἰ ζητοῖς τίς ἂν ἡμῖν διδάξειεν τοὺς τῶν χειροτεχνῶν υἱεῖς αὐτὴν ταύτην τὴν τέχνην ἣν δὴ παρὰ τοῦ πατρὸς μεμαθήκασιν, καθ’ ὅσον οἷός τ’ ἦν ὁ πατήρ καὶ οἱ τοῦ πατρὸς φίλοι ὄντες ὁμοτέχνοι, τούτους ἔτι τίς ἂν διδάξειεν, οὐ ῥάδιον οἶμαι εἶναι, ὧ Σώκρατες, τούτων διδάσκαλον φανῆναι, τῶν δὲ ἀπείρων παντάπασι ῥάδιον, οὕτω δὲ ἀρετῆς καὶ τῶν ἄλλων πάντων· ἀλλὰ καὶ εἰ ὀλίγον ἔστιν τις ὅστις διαφέρει

328b

is anyone who surpasses us, even a little, in our advance towards excellence, we should be grateful.

ἡμῶν προβιάσαι εἰς ἀρετὴν, ἀγαπητόν. ὧν δὴ ἐγὼ οἶμαι εἷς εἶναι, καὶ διαφερόντως ἂν τῶν ἄλλων ἀνθρώπων ὀνησαί τινα πρὸς τὸ καλὸν καὶ ἀγαθὸν γενέσθαι, καὶ ἀξίως τοῦ μισθοῦ ὃν πράττομαι καὶ ἔτι πλείονος, ὥστε καὶ αὐτῷ δοκεῖν τῷ μαθόντι. διὰ ταῦτα καὶ τὸν τρόπον τῆς πράξεως τοῦ μισθοῦ τοιοῦτον πεποίημαι· ἐπειδὴν γάρ τις παρ’ ἐμοῦ μάθῃ, ἐὰν μὲν βουλήται, ἀποδέδωκεν ὃ ἐγὼ πράττομαι ἀργύριον·

328c

And I think I am one of those people, and that I, more so than anyone else, can benefit a person in becoming noble and good. And I am well worth the fee I charge, and even more, so much so that the student

himself also agrees. Accordingly, I have devised the following system for paying the fee. Once someone has received instruction from me, he hands over the money I charge if he wishes. Otherwise, he goes to a temple, takes an oath as to how much he claims the teaching is worth, and deposits that amount.

ἐὰν δὲ μή, ἔλθων εἰς ἱερόν, ὁμόσας ὅσου ἂν φῇ ἄξια εἶναι τὰ μαθήματα, τοσοῦτον κατέθηκε. τοιοῦτόν σοι, ἔφη, ὦ Σώκρατες, ἐγὼ καὶ μῦθον καὶ λόγον εἴρηκα, ὡς διδασκτὸν ἀρετὴ καὶ Ἀθηναῖοι οὕτως ἡγοῦνται, καὶ ὅτι οὐδὲν θαυμαστὸν τῶν ἀγαθῶν πατέρων φαύλους ὑεῖς γίγνεσθαι καὶ τῶν φαύλων ἀγαθούς, ἐπεὶ καὶ οἱ Πολυκλείτου ὑεῖς, Παράλου καὶ Ξανθίππου τοῦδε ἡλικιωταί, οὐδὲν πρὸς τὸν πατέρα εἰσίν, καὶ ἄλλοι ἄλλων δημιουργῶν. τῶνδε δὲ

328d

“Socrates,” he said, “I have presented you with a story and an argument like this to show that excellence can be taught, and that the Athenians believe this to be the case, and that it is no surprise that ordinary sons are born to good fathers, and good sons to ordinary fathers, since even the sons of Polykleitus, who are the same age as Paralus and Xanthippus here, are nothing in comparison with their father, and the same goes for the sons of other craftsmen. But these two boys do not deserve such denunciation just yet. Indeed, there is still hope for them because they are young.”

οὐπω ἄξιον τοῦτο κατηγορεῖν· ἔτι γὰρ ἐν αὐτοῖς εἰσιν ἐλπίδες· νέοι γάρ. Πρωταγόρας μὲν τοσαῦτα καὶ τοιαῦτα ἐπιδειξάμενος ἀπεπαύσατο τοῦ λόγου. καὶ ἐγὼ ἐπὶ μὲν πολὺν χρόνον κεκληλημένος ἔτι πρὸς αὐτὸν ἔβλεπον ὡς ἐροῦντά τι, ἐπιθυμῶν ἀκούειν· ἐπεὶ δὲ δὴ ἡσθόμην ὅτι τῷ ὄντι πεπαυμένος εἴη, μόγις πως ἐμαυτὸν ὥσπερ εἰ συναγείρας εἶπον, βλέψας πρὸς τὸν Ἱπποκράτη· ὦ παῖ Ἀπολλοδώρου, ὡς χάριν σοι ἔχω ὅτι προὔτρεψάς με ὥδε ἀφικέσθαι πολλοῦ γὰρ ποιοῦμαι

328e

Having expounded for so long in this manner, Protagoras brought his speech to a close. I had been beguiled, and for a long time I kept looking

at him as though he was still going to say something, so keen was I to hear him. However, once I realised that he really had finished, I somehow gradually gathered myself together, as it were, glanced towards Hippocrates and said, “Son of Apollodorus, I am grateful to you for encouraging me to come here, for I think it very important that I have heard what I have heard from Protagoras. Indeed, in former times I did not believe that good people become good by the diligence of their fellow men, but now I am convinced, except for one minor difficulty which Protagoras will, of course, explain away quite easily, since he has already explained so much else.

ἀκηκοέναι ἃ ἀκήκοα Πρωταγόρου. ἐγὼ γὰρ ἐν μὲν τῷ ἔμπροσθεν χρόνῳ ἡγούμην οὐκ εἶναι ἀνθρωπίνην ἐπιμέλειαν ἢ ἀγαθοὶ οἱ ἀγαθοὶ γίνονται· νῦν δὲ πέπεισμαι. πλὴν σμικρὸν τί μοι ἐμποδῶν, ὃ δῆλον ὅτι Πρωταγόρας ῥαδίως ἐπεκιδιᾷξει, ἐπειδὴ καὶ τὰ πολλὰ ταῦτα ἐξεδίδασκεν. ΣΩ. καὶ γὰρ εἰ μὲν τις περὶ αὐτῶν τούτων συγγένοιτο ὁττωῦν τῶν

329a

“If someone were to frequent any of our public speakers on these very issues, he would probably hear speeches of this sort, either from Pericles or any of the other accomplished speakers.

δημηγόρων, τάχ’ ἂν καὶ τοιούτους λόγους ἀκούσειεν ἢ Περικλέους ἢ ἄλλου τινὸς τῶν ἱκανῶν εἰπεῖν· εἰ δὲ ἐπανερόιτο τινά τι, ὥσπερ βιβλία οὐδὲν ἔχουσιν οὔτε ἀποκρίνασθαι οὔτε αὐτοὶ ἐρέσθαι, ἀλλ’ ἐάν τις καὶ σμικρὸν ἐπερωτήσῃ τι τῶν ῥηθέντων, ὥσπερ τὰ χαλκία πληγέντα μακρὸν ἤχεϊ καὶ ἀποτείνει ἐὰν μὴ ἐπιλάβηται τις, καὶ οἱ ῥήτορες οὕτω, σμικρὰ

329b

But if anyone puts a question to them, they behave like a book. They are not able to answer the question or ask one themselves. Rather, if someone asks even a trivial question about anything they have said, our rhetoricians protract and draw out their oration in answer to the simplest question, like clanging brass that resounds for quite some

time, drawing out its note until someone puts a hand on it. Now, Protagoras here is well able to deliver a good long speech. That is obvious now.

329b

Yet he is also competent at answering briefly when he is questioned, and at waiting, and accepting the answer when he asks a question himself, endowments possessed by very few.

ἐρωτηθέντες δόλιχον κατατείνουσι τοῦ λόγου. Πρωταγόρας δὲ ὅδε ἱκανὸς μὲν μακροὺς λόγους καὶ καλοὺς εἰπεῖν, ὡς αὐτὰ δηλοῖ, ἱκανὸς δὲ καὶ ἐρωτηθεὶς ἀποκρίνασθαι κατὰ βραχὺ καὶ ἐρόμενος περιμεῖναί τε καὶ ἀποδέξασθαι τὴν ἀπόκρισιν, ἃ ὀλίγοις ἐστὶ παρεσκευασμένα. νῦν οὖν, ὦ Πρωταγόρα, σμικροῦ τινος ἐνδεής εἰμι πάντ' ἔχειν, εἴ μοι ἀποκρίναιο τόδε. τὴν ἀρετὴν φῆς διδακτὸν εἶναι, καὶ ἐγὼ εἵπερ ἄλλω τῷ ἀνθρώπῳ πειθοίμην ἄν, καὶ σοὶ πείθομαι.

329c

“So, Protagoras, I am not quite there yet, but if you were to answer the following question I would understand everything. You say that excellence can be taught, and if I were to be persuaded by anyone else in the world, I would surely be persuaded by you. But please satisfy me on an issue that surprised me when you were speaking, for you said that Zeus sent justice and respect to humankind, and what is more, on many occasions in your exposition, justice, sound-mindedness, holiness, and all the rest, were referred to by you collectively as one thing, excellence. Please go through these for me precisely, with an argument on whether excellence is one entity, of which justice, sound-mindedness and holiness are parts, or whether all these words I have just uttered are a variety of names for the same one thing. This is my only remaining desire.”

ὃ δ' ἐθαύμασά σου λέγοντος, τοῦτό μοι ἐν τῇ ψυχῇ ἀποπλήρωσον. ἔλεγες γάρ ὅτι ὁ Ζεὺς τὴν δικαιοσύνην καὶ τὴν αἰδῶ πέμψειε τοῖς ἀνθρώποις, καὶ αὖ πολλαχοῦ ἐν τοῖς λόγοις ἐλέγετο ὑπὸ σοῦ ἡ δικαιοσύνη καὶ σωφροσύνη καὶ ὁσιότης καὶ πάντα ταῦτα ὡς ἓν τι εἶη

συλλήβδην, ἀρετή ταῦτ' οὖν αὐτὰ δίδεχθαι μοι ἀκριβῶς τῷ λόγῳ, πότερον ἔν μὲν τί ἐστὶν ἡ ἀρετή, μέρη δὲ αὐτῆς ἐστὶν ἡ δικαιοσύνη καὶ σωφροσύνη καὶ ὁσιότης, ἢ ταῦτ' ἐστὶν ἅ νυνδὴ ἐγώ

329d

“Well, Socrates,” he replied, “that is an easy question to answer. Excellence is one, and you are asking about parts of it.”

329d

“Are they parts”, I said, “just as the parts of the face are parts – mouth, nose, eyes and ears? Or are they like the parts of gold, which do not differ in any way either from one another or from the whole, except in being large or small?”

ἔλεγον πάντα ὀνόματα τοῦ αὐτοῦ ἐνὸς ὄντος. τοῦτ' ἐστὶν ὃ ἔτι ἐπιποθῶ. ἀλλὰ ῥᾷδιον τοῦτό γ', ἔφη, ὦ Σώκρατες, ἀποκρίνασθαι, ὅτι ἐνὸς ὄντος τῆς ἀρετῆς μέρη ἐστὶν ἅ ἐρωτᾷς.—πότερον, ἔφην, ὥσπερ προσώπου τὰ μέρη μέρη ἐστὶν, στόμα τε καὶ ῥίς καὶ ὀφθαλμοὶ καὶ ὦτα, ἢ ὥσπερ τὰ τοῦ χρυσοῦ μέρη οὐδὲν διαφέρει τὰ ἕτερα τῶν ἐτέρων, ἀλλήλων καὶ τοῦ ὅλου, ἀλλ' ἢ μεγέθει καὶ σμικρότητι;—ἐκείνως μοι φαίνεται, ὦ

329e

“In the former sense, Socrates, in my view, as the parts of the face relate to the face as a whole.”

329e

“Now, do people also share in these, the parts of excellence, some sharing in one part and someone else sharing in another, or is it necessary that someone who has acquired one has them all?”

329e

“Not at all,” he replied. “Many people are courageous yet unjust, or just but not wise.”

Σώκρατες, ὥσπερ τὰ τοῦ προσώπου μέρη ἔχει πρὸς τὸ ὅλον πρόσωπον.—πότερον οὖν, ἦν δ' ἐγώ, καὶ μεταλαμβάνουσιν οἱ ἄνθρωποι τούτων τῶν τῆς ἀρετῆς μορίων οἱ μὲν ἄλλοι, οἱ δὲ ἄλλοι, ἢ ἀνάγκη, εἴανπερ τις ἐν λάβῃ, ἅπαντα ἔχειν;—οὐδαμῶς, ἔφη, ἐπεὶ πολλοὶ ἀνδρεῖοι εἰσιν, ἄδικοι δέ, καὶ δίκαιοι αὖ, σοφοὶ δὲ οὐ.— ΣΩ. ἔστιν γὰρ οὖν καὶ ταῦτα μέρη

330a

“So are these also parts of excellence, wisdom and courage?”

330a

“Of course,” he said, “most emphatically. And wisdom is the most important part.”

330a

“And is each of them different from the other?” I asked.

330a

“Yes.”

τῆς ἀρετῆς, ἔφην ἐγώ, σοφία τε καὶ ἀνδρεία;—πάντων μάλιστα δήπου, ἔφη καὶ μέγιστόν γε ἡ σοφία τῶν μορίων.—ἕκαστον δὲ αὐτῶν ἐστίν, ἦν δ’ ἐγώ, ἄλλο, τὸ δὲ ἄλλο;—ναί.—ἦ καὶ δύναμιν αὐτῶν ἕκαστον ἰδίαν ἔχει; ὥσπερ τὰ τοῦ προσώπου, οὐκ ἔστιν ὁφθαλμὸς οἷον τὰ ὦτα, οὐδ’ ἡ δύναμις αὐτοῦ ἡ αὐτὴ οὐδὲ τῶν ἄλλων οὐδέν ἐστιν οἷον τὸ ἕτερον οὔτε κατὰ τὴν δύναμιν οὔτε κατὰ τὰ ἄλλα ἄρ’ οὖν οὕτω καὶ τὰ τῆς ἀρετῆς μόρια οὐκ ἔστιν τὸ ἕτερον οἷον τὸ

330b

“And does each of them possess its own particular capacity? I mean, are they like the parts of the face, where the eye is not like the ear, nor does it have the same capacity, nor is any part like another part, either in its capacity or on any other basis? Is this also the case with the parts of excellence, that one part is not like the other, neither in itself nor in its capacity? Or is it quite obvious that this is the case, if it really conforms to our example anyway?”

330b

“Yes, this is the case, Socrates,” he said.

330b

And I said, “So no other part of excellence is like knowledge, no other part is like justice, or courage or sound-mindedness or holiness.”

330b

“No,” he replied.

ἕτερον, οὔτε αὐτὸ οὔτε ἡ δύναμις αὐτοῦ; ἢ δὴλα δὴ ὅτι οὕτως ἔχει, εἴπερ τῷ παραδείγματί γε ἔοικε;—ἀλλ’ οὕτως, ἔφη, ἔχει, ὦ Σώκρατες.—καὶ ἐγὼ εἶπον· οὐδὲν ἄρα ἐστὶν τῶν τῆς ἀρετῆς μορίων ἄλλο οἷον ἐπιστήμη, οὐδ’ οἷον δικαιοσύνη, οὐδ’ οἷον ἀνδρεία, οὐδ’ οἷον σωφροσύνη, οὐδ’ οἷον ὁσιότης.—οὐκ ἔφη.—φέρει δὴ, ἔφην ἐγώ, κοινῇ σκεψώμεθα ποῖόν τι αὐτῶν ἐστὶν ἕκαστον. πρῶτον μὲν τὸ τοιόνδε·

330c

“Come on, then,” I said. “Together let us consider what sort of thing each of them is. Let us ask this question first. Is justice a something or not a something? I think it is, but what about you?”

330c

“I think so too,” he replied.

330c

“What about this? If someone were to ask you and me, ‘Protagoras and Socrates, please tell me about this thing which you have named just now as justice. Is this itself just or unjust?’ I would reply that it is just, but how would you cast your vote? The same way as me, or the other way?”

330c

“The same,” he replied.

ἡ δικαιοσύνη πρᾶγμα τί ἐστὶν ἢ οὐδὲν πρᾶγμα; ἐμοὶ μὲν γὰρ δοκεῖ τί δὲ σοί;—κἄμοί, ἔφη.—τί οὖν; εἴ τις ἔροιτο ἐμέ τε καὶ σέ· ὦ Πρωταγόρα τε καὶ Σώκρατες, εἶπετον δὴ μοι, τοῦτο τὸ πρᾶγμα ὃ ὠνομάσατε ἄρτι, ἡ δικαιοσύνη, αὐτὸ τοῦτο δίκαιόν ἐστιν ἢ ἀδίκον; ἐγὼ μὲν ἂν αὐτῷ ἀποκρίναίμην ὅτι δίκαιον· σὺ δὲ τίν’ ἂν ψῆφον θεῖο; τὴν αὐτὴν ἐμοὶ ἢ ἄλλην;—τὴν αὐτὴν, ἔφη.—ἔστιν ἄρα τοιοῦτον ἡ δικαιοσύνη οἷον δίκαιον εἶναι, φαίην ἂν ἔγωγε ἀποκρινόμενος τῷ

330d

“So, in response to the questioner, I would say that justice is the sort of thing that is just. Would you say so too?”

330d

“Yes,” he said.

330d

“If he were to go on and ask us, ‘Wouldn’t you also say that there is holiness?’ I think we would agree.”

330d

“Yes,” said he.

330d

“Wouldn’t you say that it too is a something? We would agree to this wouldn’t we?”

330d

He also concurred with this.

ἐρωτῶντι· οὐκοῦν καὶ σύ;—ναί, ἔφη.—εἰ οὖν μετὰ τοῦτο ἡμᾶς ἔροιτο· οὐκοῦν καὶ ὁσιότητά τινά φατε εἶναι; φαῖμεν ἄν, ὥς ἐγώ μαι.—ναί, ἦ δ’ ὅς.—οὐκοῦν φατε καὶ τοῦτο πρᾶγμά τι εἶναι; φαῖμεν ἄν· ἢ οὐ;—καὶ τοῦτο συνέφη.—πότερον δὲ τοῦτο αὐτὸ τὸ πρᾶγμά φατε τοιοῦτον πεφυκέναι οἷον ἀνόσιον εἶναι ἢ οἷον ὅσιον; ἀγανακτήσοιμ’ ἂν ἔγωγ’, ἔφην, τῷ ἐρωτήματι, καὶ εἵποιμ’ ἄν· εὐφήμει, ὧ ἄνθρωπε· σχολῇ μεντᾶν τι ἄλλο ὅσιον εἶη, εἰ μὴ αὐτή

330e

“Would you say that this thing itself is the sort of thing that is, by nature, holy or unholy? Now, I myself would be annoyed by that question and I would say, ‘Speak respectfully, my man. Scarcely anything else would be holy if holiness itself were not holy.’ What about you? Would you respond in a similar manner?”

330e

“Very much so,” he said.

330e

“After this, if he were also to ask us, ‘Well, what were you saying a little earlier? Perhaps I did not hear you aright. I thought the two of you said that the parts of excellence are so disposed towards one another that one of them is not like the other.’”

γε ἡ ὁσιότης ὅσιον ἔσται. τί δὲ σύ; οὐχ οὕτως ἂν ἀποκρίναιο;—πάνυ μὲν οὖν, ἔφη. εἰ οὖν μετὰ τοῦτο εἴποι ἐρωτῶν ἡμᾶς πῶς οὖν ὀλίγον

πρότερον ἐλέγετε; ἄρ' οὐκ ὀρθῶς ὑμῶν κατήκουσα; ἐδόξατέ μοι φάναι τὰ τῆς ἀρετῆς μέρη εἶναι οὕτως ἔχοντα πρὸς ἄλληλα, ὥς οὐκ εἶναι τὸ ἕτερον αὐτῶν οἷον τὸ ἕτερον· ΣΩ. εἴποιμ' ἂν ἔγωγε ὅτι τὰ μὲν ἄλλα ὀρθῶς ἤκουσας, ὅτι δὲ καὶ ἐμὲ οἷε εἰπεῖν τοῦτο, παρήκουσας· Πρωταγόρας γὰρ

331a

"I would reply that for the most part you have heard right, but if you think that I said so too, you have misheard, for Protagoras here gave this answer. I was just asking the questions.

331a

"Now, if he were to say, 'Is this fellow speaking the truth, Protagoras? Are you the one who says that in the case of excellence one part is not like another? Is this your statement?' What answer would you give him?"

331a

"I would have to agree, Socrates," he said.

ὁδε ταῦτα ἀπεκρίνατο, ἐγὼ δὲ ἡρώτων. εἰ οὖν εἴποι· ἀληθῆ ὁδε λέγει, ὦ Πρωταγόρα; σὺ φῆς οὐκ εἶναι τὸ ἕτερον μέρος οἷον τὸ ἕτερον τῶν τῆς ἀρετῆς; σὺ οὗτος ὁ λόγος ἐστίν; τί ἂν αὐτῷ ἀποκρίναιο;—ἀνάγκη, ἔφη, ὦ Σώκρατες, ὁμολογεῖν. τί οὖν, ὦ Πρωταγόρα, ἀποκρινόμεθα αὐτῷ, ταῦτα ὁμολογήσαντες, ἐὰν ἡμᾶς ἐπανέρηται· οὐκ ἄρα ἐστὶν ὁσιότης οἷον δίκαιον εἶναι πρᾶγμα, οὐδὲ δικαιοσύνη οἷον ὅσιον ἀλλ' οἷον μὴ ὅσιον· ἢ δ' ὁσιότης οἷον μὴ δίκαιον, ἀλλ' ἄδικον

331b

"Well, Protagoras, having agreed to that, what answer would we give him if he were to ask us further, 'So, is holiness not like something just, and is justice not like something holy but like something unholy? And is holiness like something that is not just, and is it therefore unjust, and justice

331b

unholy?' What reply shall we give him? Now, I myself would say, on my own behalf, that justice is holy and holiness just. And I would give the

same response on your behalf too, if you would allow me, either that justness is the same as holiness, or that they are very alike, but most of all that justice is like holiness, and holiness is like justice. Well, let us see if you will disallow that response, or if this is how it seems to you too.”

ἄρα, τὸ δὲ ἀνόσιον; τί αὐτῷ ἀποκρινόμεθα; ἐγὼ μὲν γὰρ αὐτὸς ὑπὲρ γε ἑμαυτοῦ φαίην ἂν καὶ τὴν δικαιοσύνην ὅσιον εἶναι καὶ τὴν ὁσιότητα δίκαιον· καὶ ὑπὲρ σοῦ δέ, εἴ με ἐφῆς, ταῦτά ἂν ταῦτα ἀποκρinoίμην, ὅτι ἦτοι ταῦτόν γ’ ἐστὶν δικαιοσύνη ὁσιότητι ἢ ὅτι ὁμοιότατον, καὶ μάλιστα πάντων ἢ τε δικαιοσύνη οἷον ὁσιότης καὶ ἡ ὁσιότης οἷον δικαιοσύνη. ἀλλ’ ὅρα εἰ διακωλύεις ἀποκρίνεσθαι, ἢ καὶ σοὶ συνδοκεῖ οὕτως.—οὐ πάνυ μοι δοκεῖ, ἔφη, ὦ Σώκρατες, οὕτως ἀπλοῦν

331c

“I do not think it is as simple as all that, Socrates,” he replied. “I do not agree that justice is holy and that holiness is just. No, I think there is some distinction between them. But what difference does that make?” he said. “If you wish, let justice also be holy and holiness just, for our purposes.”

εἶναι, ὥστε συγχωρῆσαι τὴν τε δικαιοσύνην ὅσιον εἶναι καὶ τὴν ὁσιότητα δίκαιον, ἀλλὰ τί μοι δοκεῖ ἐν αὐτῷ διάφορον εἶναι. ἀλλὰ τί τοῦτο διαφέρει; ἔφη εἰ γὰρ βούλει, ἔστω ἡμῖν καὶ δικαιοσύνη ὅσιον καὶ ὁσιότης δίκαιον.—μή μοι, ἦν δ’ ἐγώ· οὐδὲν γὰρ δέομαι τὸ εἰ βούλει τοῦτο καὶ εἴ σοι δοκεῖ ἐλέγχεσθαι, ἀλλ’ ἐμέ τε καὶ σέ· τὸ δ’ ἐμέ τε καὶ σέ τοῦτο λέγω, οἰόμενος οὕτω τὸν λόγον βέλτιστ’

331d

“Not for mine,” I said, “for I do not want this ‘if you wish’ or ‘if you think so’ to come under scrutiny, but me and you. I say ‘me and you’, because I believe that the proposition will best come under scrutiny once the word ‘if’ is left out of it.”

ἂν ἐλέγχεσθαι, εἴ τις τὸ εἴ ἀφέλοι αὐτοῦ.—ἀλλὰ μέντοι, ἦ δ’ ὅς, προσέοικεν τι δικαιοσύνη ὁσιότητι· καὶ γὰρ ὅτιοῦν ὅτωοῦν ἀμῇ γέ πη προσέοικεν. τὸ γὰρ λευκὸν τῷ μέλανι ἔστιν ὅπῃ προσέοικεν, καὶ τὸ

σκληρὸν τῷ μαλακῷ, καὶ τᾶλλα ἃ δοκεῖ ἐναντιώτατα εἶναι ἀλλήλοις· καὶ ἃ τότε ἔφαμεν ἄλλην δύναμιν ἔχειν καὶ οὐκ εἶναι τὸ ἕτερον οἷον τὸ ἕτερον, τὰ τοῦ προσώπου μόρια, ἀμῇ γέ πη προσέοικεν καὶ ἔστιν τὸ ἕτερον οἷον τὸ ἕτερον. ὥστε τούτῳ γε τῷ τρόπῳ

331e

“But of course justice bears some resemblance to holiness,” he said. “And, indeed, anything at all resembles anything else in some way or other. For there is a sense in which white bears a resemblance to black, hard to soft, and so do others that seem completely opposite to one another. And we said at the time that the parts of the face each have their own capacity, and that one is not like the other, yet there is some sense in which they bear a resemblance and one is like the other. So, based on this approach, you could even prove, if you wanted to, that these too are all similar to one another. But it is not right to refer to things that possess some similarity as similar, even when the similarity is very minor, or to refer to things that possess some dissimilarity as dissimilar.”

331e

Now, I was surprised, and said to him, “So is this your view of the relationship between the just and the holy? Is there only a slight similarity between them?”

κἂν ταῦτα ἐλέγχοις, εἰ βούλοιο, ὡς ἅπαντά ἐστιν ὅμοια ἀλλήλοις. ἀλλ’ οὐχὶ τὰ ὁμοίων τι ἔχοντα ὅμοια δίκαιον καλεῖν, οὐδὲ τὰ ἀνόμοίων τι ἔχοντα ἀνόμοια, κἂν πάνυ μικρὸν ἔχη τὸ ὅμοιον.—καὶ ἐγὼ θαυμάσας εἶπον πρὸς αὐτόν· ἦ γὰρ οὕτω σοι τὸ δίκαιον καὶ τὸ ὅσιον πρὸς ἄλληλα ἔχει, ὥστε ὁμοίων τι μικρὸν ἔχειν ἀλλήλοις;— ΣΩ. οὐ πάνυ,

332a

“No,” he said, “this is not exactly the situation. Then again, it is not as you seem to think it is either.”

332a

“Very well,” said I, “since you are not well disposed towards this we should let it go and investigate something else you said. Is there

something you call folly?”

332a

“Yes.”

332a

“And the complete opposite of this thing is wisdom, isn’t it?”

332a

“So it seems to me anyway,” he replied.

332a

“And whenever people behave properly and beneficially, do you think they are sound-minded when behaving in this way, or the opposite?”

332a

“They are sound-minded,” he said.

ἔφη, οὕτως, οὐ μέντοι οὐδὲ αὖ ὥς σύ μοι δοκεῖς οἶεσθαι.—ἀλλὰ μήν, ἔφην ἐγώ, ἐπειδὴ δυσχερῶς δοκεῖς μοι ἔχειν πρὸς τοῦτο, τοῦτο μὲν ἐάσωμεν, τόδε δὲ ἄλλο ὧν ἔλεγες ἐπισκεψώμεθα. ἀφροσύνην τι καλεῖς;—ἔφη.—τούτῳ τῷ πράγματι οὐ πᾶν τούναντίον ἐστὶν ἡ σοφία;—ἔμοιγε δοκεῖ, ἔφη.—πότερον δὲ ὅταν πράττωσιν ἄνθρωποι ὀρθῶς τε καὶ ὠφελίμως, τότε σωφρονεῖν σοι δοκοῦσιν οὕτω πράττοντες, ἢ εἰ τούναντίον ἔπραττον;—σωφρονεῖν, ἔφη.—οὐκοῦν

332b

“Isn’t it by sound-mindedness that they are sound-minded?”

332b

“Necessarily.”

332b

“Those who do not behave properly behave foolishly, and behaving in this way they are not soundminded, are they?”

332b

“I agree,” he said.

332b

“So, is behaving foolishly the opposite of behaving sound-mindedly?”

332b

“Yes.”

332b

“Now, whatever is done foolishly is done with folly, whatever is done sound-mindedly is done with sound-mindedness.”

332b

He agreed.

332b

“Now, if something is done with strength it is done strongly, and if it is done with weakness it is done weakly. Isn’t this so?”

332b

He thought so.

σωφροσύνη σωφρονοῦσιν;—ἀνάγκη.—οὐκοῦν οἱ μὴ ὀρθῶς πράττοντες ἀφρόνως πράττουσιν καὶ οὐ σωφρονοῦσιν οὕτω πράττοντες;—συνδοκεῖ μοι, ἔφη.—τοῦναντίον ἄρα ἐστὶν τὸ ἀφρόνως πράττειν τῷ σωφρόνως;—ἔφη.—οὐκοῦν τὰ μὲν ἀφρόνως πραττόμενα ἀφροσύνη πράττεται, τὰ δὲ σωφρόνως σωφροσύνη;—ὡμολόγει.—οὐκοῦν εἴ τι ἰσχυρῶς πράττεται, ἰσχυρῶς πράττεται, καὶ εἴ τι ἀσθενείᾳ, ἀσθενῶς;—ἐδόκει.—καὶ εἴ τι μετὰ τάχους, ταχέως, καὶ εἴ τι μετὰ βραδυτῆτος,

332c

“And is something done with haste done hastily, and is something done with slowness done slowly?”

332c

“Yes.”

332c

“And if something is done in the same way, it is done by the same, and if it is done in the opposite way, it is done by the opposite.”

332c

He concurred.

332c

“Come on now,” said I, “is there such a thing as the beautiful?”

332c

He agreed.

332c

“Is there any opposite of this except the ugly?”

332c

“There is not.”

332c

“What about this? Is there such a thing as the good?”

332c

“There is.”

332c

“Is there any opposite of this apart from the bad?”

332c

“There is not.”

332c

“What about this? Is there such a thing as a high-pitched sound?”

332c

“Yes.”

332c

“Is there any opposite of this apart from a low-pitched sound?”

332c

“No.”

332c

“Now,” said I, “to each one of the opposites isn’t there only one opposite and not many?”

332c

He agreed with this.

βραδέως;—ἔφη.—καὶ εἴ τι δὴ ὡσαύτως πράττεται, ὑπὸ τοῦ αὐτοῦ πράττεται, καὶ εἴ τι ἐναντίως, ὑπὸ τοῦ ἐναντίου;—συνέφη.—φέρει δὴ, ἦν δ’ ἐγώ, ἔστιν τι καλόν;—συνεχώρει.—τούτῳ ἔστιν τι ἐναντίον πλὴν τὸ αἰσχρόν;—οὐκ ἔστιν.—τί δέ; ἔστιν τι ἀγαθόν;—ἔστιν.—τούτῳ ἔστιν τι ἐναντίον πλὴν τὸ κακόν;—οὐκ ἔστιν.—τί δέ; ἔστιν τι ὁξὺ ἐν φωνῇ;—ἔφη.—τούτῳ μὴ ἔστιν τι ἐναντίον ἄλλο πλὴν τὸ βαρύ;—οὐκ ἔφη.—οὐκοῦν, ἦν δ’ ἐγώ, ἐνὶ ἐκάστῳ τῶν ἐναντίων ἓν μόνον ἔστιν ἐναντίον καὶ οὐ πολλά;—συνωμολόγει.

332d

“Well, let us summarise the issues we have agreed on. Have we agreed that there is only one opposite of anything, and no more?”

332d

“We agreed on that.”

332d

“And that what is performed in the opposite way is performed by opposites?”

332d

“Yes.”

332d

“Did we agree that something done foolishly is done in the opposite way to something done soundmindedly?”

332d

“Yes.”

ἴθι δὴ, ἦν δ' ἐγώ, ἀναλογισώμεθα τὰ ὠμολογημένα ἡμῖν. ὠμολογήκαμεν ἓν ἐνὶ μόνον ἐναντίον εἶναι, πλείω δὲ μή;—ὠμολογήκαμεν.—τὸ δὲ ἐναντίως πραττόμενον ὑπὸ ἐναντίων πράττεσθαι;—ἔφη.—ὠμολογήκαμεν δὲ ἐναντίως πράττεσθαι ὃ ἂν ἀφρόνως πράττεται τῷ σωφρόνως πραττομένῳ;—ἔφη.—τὸ δὲ σωφρόνως πραττόμενον ὑπὸ σωφροσύνης πράττεσθαι, τὸ δὲ ἀφρόνως ὑπὸ ἀφροσύνης;

332e

“And that something done sound-mindedly is done by sound-mindedness, while something done foolishly is done by folly.”

332e

He agreed.

332e

“In that case, since they are done in opposite ways, wouldn't they be done by opposites?”

332e

“Yes.”

332e

“And if one is done by sound-mindedness, will the other be done by folly?”

332e

“Yes.”

332e

“In opposite ways?”

332e

“Entirely so.”

332e

“In that case aren’t they done by opposites?”

332e

“Yes.”

332e

“So, is folly the opposite of sound-mindedness?”

332e

“It appears so.”

332e

“Now, do you recall that we agreed in our previous discussion that folly is the opposite of wisdom?”

332e

“That was agreed.”

—συνεχώρει.—οὐκοῦν εἴπερ ἐναντίως πράττεται, ὑπὸ ἐναντίου πράττοιτ’ ἄν;—ναί.—πράττεται δὲ τὸ μὲν ὑπὸ σωφροσύνης, τὸ δὲ ὑπὸ ἀφροσύνης;—ναί.—ἐναντίως;—πάνυ γε.—οὐκοῦν ὑπὸ ἐναντίων ὄντων;—ναί.—ἐναντίον ἄρ’ ἐστὶν ἀφροσύνη σωφροσύνης;—φαίνεται.—μέμνησαι οὖν ὅτι ἐν τοῖς ἔμπροσθεν ὡμολόγηται ἡμῖν ἀφροσύνη σοφίᾳ ἐναντίον εἶναι;—συνωμολόγει.—ΣΩ. ἔν δὲ ἐνὶ μόνον ἐναντίον

333a

“And that there is only one opposite of anything?”

333a

“I agree.”

333a

“Well, Protagoras, which of our arguments are we to drop? Is it the one stating that everything has only one opposite, or the other one that said wisdom is different from sound-mindedness, although both are parts of excellence? And as well as being different, they themselves are dissimilar, just like the parts of the face, and so are the capacities they possess. So which of them should we drop?

333a

For these two arguments are not expressed in a manner that is entirely in tune. Indeed, they are neither in unison nor in harmony with one another. For how could they be in unison, if, in fact,

εἶναι;—φημί.—πότερον οὖν, ὦ Πρωταγόρα, λύσωμεν τῶν λόγων; τὸ ἐν ἐνὶ μόνον ἐναντίον εἶναι, ἢ ἐκεῖνον ἐν ᾧ ἐλέγετο ἕτερον εἶναι σωφροσύνης σοφία, μῦθον δὲ ἐκάτερον ἀρετῆς, καὶ πρὸς τῷ ἑτερον εἶναι καὶ ἀνόμοια καὶ αὐτὰ καὶ αἱ δυνάμεις αὐτῶν, ὥσπερ τὰ τοῦ προσώπου μῦθια; πότερον οὖν δὴ λύσωμεν; οὗτοι γὰρ οἱ λόγοι ἀμφοτέροι οὐ πάντῃ μουσικῶς λέγονται· οὐ γὰρ συνάδουσιν οὐδὲ συναρμόττουσιν ἀλλήλοις. πῶς γὰρ ἂν συνάδοιεν, εἴπερ γε ἀνάγκη ἐνὶ

333b

anything has necessarily only one opposite and no more? Yet, on the other hand, it appears that wisdom and sound-mindedness are both opposite to one thing, folly. Is this the case, Protagoras,” I asked, “or is it otherwise?”

333b

He agreed, very reluctantly.

333b

“So, could it be the case that sound-mindedness and wisdom are one? And what is more, we showed a moment ago that justice and holiness are almost the same.

μὲν ἐν μόνον ἐναντίον εἶναι, πλείοσιν δὲ μή, τῇ δὲ ἀφροσύνῃ ἐνὶ ὄντι σοφία ἐναντία καὶ σωφροσύνη αὖ φαίνεται· ἢ γὰρ, ὦ Πρωταγόρα, ἔφην ἐγώ, ἢ ἄλλως πως;—ὡμολόγησεν καὶ μάλ’ ἀκόντως.—οὐκοῦν ἐν ἂν εἴη

ἡ σωφροσύνη καὶ ἡ σοφία; τὸ δὲ πρότερον αὖ ἐφάνη ἡμῖν ἡ δικαιοσύνη καὶ ἡ ὁσιότης σχεδόν τι ταῦτὸν ὄν. ἴθι δὴ, ἦν δ' ἐγώ, ὦ Πρωταγόρα, μὴ ἀποκάμωμεν ἀλλὰ καὶ τὰ λοιπὰ διασκεψώμεθα. ἄρα τίς σοι δοκεῖ ἀδικῶν

333c

“Come now, Protagoras,” I said, “let us not flag. Let us consider the remaining possibilities thoroughly. Do you think that a person who is acting unjustly is sound-minded because he is acting unjustly?”

333c

“I would be ashamed to agree to that, Socrates,” he said, “even though there are a lot of people who say so.”

333c

“Now, should I direct the argument at them or at you?” I asked.

333c

“Discuss this argument first, the one that a lot of people hold, if you prefer,” he said.

333c

“Well, it makes no difference to me, as long as you are the person who responds, regardless of whether you hold these views or not. Indeed, for the most part, I am scrutinising the argument, yet it will probably turn out that I, the questioner, and my respondent, come under scrutiny too.”

ἄνθρωπος σωφρονεῖν, ὅτι ἀδικεῖ;—αἰσχυνοίμην ἂν ἔγωγ', ἔφη, ὦ Σώκρατες, τοῦτο ὁμολογεῖν, ἐπεὶ πολλοὶ γέ φασιν τῶν ἀνθρώπων.—πότερον οὖν πρὸς ἐκείνους τὸν λόγον ποιήσομαι, ἔφην, ἢ πρὸς σέ;—εἰ βούλει, ἔφη, πρὸς τοῦτον πρῶτον τὸν λόγον διαλέχθητι τὸν τῶν πολλῶν.—ἀλλ' οὐδέν μοι διαφέρει, ἐὰν μόνον σύ γε ἀποκρίνη, εἴτ' οὖν δοκεῖ σοι ταῦτα εἶτε μὴ τὸν γὰρ λόγον ἔγωγε μάλιστα ἐξετάζω, συμβαίνει μέντοι ἴσως καὶ ἐμὲ τὸν ἐρωτῶντα καὶ τὸν ἀποκρινόμενον ἐξετάζεσθαι.

333d

At first Protagoras was coy with us, deeming the argument too troublesome, but eventually he consented to respond. “Come on, then,” said I, “answer me from the beginning. Do you think some people are being sound-minded whilst acting unjustly?”

333d

“Let it be so,” he replied.

333d

“And by being sound-minded you mean thinking well?”

333d

He agreed.

333d

“And thinking well means planning well for whatever injustice they enact?”

333d

“Let it be so,” he replied.

333d

“Does this mean that their unjust actions proceed well or proceed badly?”

333d

“Well.”

333d

“Now, do you say that there are things that are good?”

333d

“I say so.”

τὸ μὲν οὖν πρῶτον ἐκαλλωπίζετο ἡμῖν ὁ Πρωταγόρας—τὸν γὰρ λόγον ἡτιᾶτο δυσχερῇ εἶναι—ἔπειτα μέντοι συνεχώρησεν ἀποκρίνεσθαι.—ἴθι δῆ, ἔφην ἐγώ, ἐξ ἀρχῆς μοι ἀπόκριναι. δοκοῦσί τινές σοι σωφρονεῖν ἀδικοῦντες;—ἔστω, ἔφη.—τὸ δὲ σωφρονεῖν λέγεις εὖ φρονεῖν;—ἔφη.—τὸ δ’ εὖ φρονεῖν εὖ βουλευέσθαι, ὅτι ἀδικοῦσιν;—ἔστω, ἔφη.—πότερον, ἦν δ’ ἐγώ, εἰ εὖ πράττουσιν ἀδικοῦντες ἢ εἰ κακῶς;—εἰ εὖ.—λέγεις οὖν ἀγαθὰ ἅττα εἶναι;—λέγω.—ἄρ’ οὖν, ἦν δ’ ἐγώ, ταῦτ’ ἐστὶν ἀγαθὰ ἃ ἐστὶν ὠφέλιμα τοῖς ἀνθρώποις;

333e

“Well, are these good things the ones that are of benefit to people?”

333e

“Yes, indeed, by Zeus,” said he, “and I refer to things as good even when they are not of benefit to mankind.”

333e

At this stage, Protagoras seemed to me to be angry and combative, and set against answering more questions. So, once I had observed the state he was in, I took care to question him gently.

—καὶ ναὶ μὰ Δί', ἔφη, κἂν μὴ τοῖς ἀνθρώποις ὠφέλιμα ᾖ, ἔγωγε καλῶ ἀγαθὰ.—καὶ μοι ἐδόκει ὁ Πρωταγόρας ἤδη τετραχύνθαι τε καὶ ἀγωνιᾶν καὶ παρατετάχθαι πρὸς τὸ ἀποκρίνεσθαι· ἐπειδὴ οὖν ἑώρων αὐτὸν οὕτως ἔχοντα, εὐλαβούμενος ἡρέμα ἡρόμην. ΣΩ. πότερον, ἦν δ' ἐγώ, λέγεις, ὦ

334a

“Protagoras,” I said, “are you referring to things that are of no benefit to any person or to those which are of no benefit whatsoever? And do you call things of that sort good?”

Πρωταγόρα, ἃ μηδενὶ ἀνθρώπων ὠφέλιμά ἐστιν, ἢ ἃ μηδὲ τὸ παράπαν ὠφέλιμα; καὶ τὰ τοιαῦτα σὺ ἀγαθὰ καλεῖς;—οὐδαμῶς, ἔφη· ἀλλ' ἔγωγε πολλὰ οἶδ' ἃ ἀνθρώποις μὲν ἀνωφελῆ ἐστι, καὶ σιτία καὶ ποτὰ καὶ φάρμακα καὶ ἄλλα μυρία, τὰ δέ γε ὠφέλιμα· τὰ δὲ ἀνθρώποις μὲν οὐδέτερα, ἵπποις δέ· τὰ δὲ βουσὶν μόνον, τὰ δὲ κυσίν· τὰ δέ γε τούτων μὲν οὐδενί, δένδροις δέ· τὰ δὲ τοῦ δένδρου ταῖς μὲν ρίζαις ἀγαθὰ, ταῖς δὲ βλάσταις πονηρά, οἶον καὶ ἡ κόπρος πάντων

334b

“Not at all,” he replied. “But I do know lots of things that are detrimental to people – foodstuffs, drink, medicines, and myriads more – and lots that are of benefit; others that have no effect upon humans, but do affect horses. Some only affect cattle, others only dogs; some affect none of these animals, but do affect trees; some are good for the roots of the tree but bad for the shoots. So manure, for instance, is

good for all plants when it is spread about the roots, but if you decided to throw it onto the saplings and young shoots it would destroy them all. Oil too is extremely bad for all plants and is utterly inimical to the hair of all other creatures except that of humans, yet it is a salve to human hair and to the rest of the body.

τῶν φυτῶν ταῖς μὲν ρίζαις ἀγαθὸν παραβαλλομένη, εἰ δ' ἐθέλοις ἐπὶ τοὺς πτόρθους καὶ τοὺς νέους κλῶνας ἐπιβάλλειν, πάντα ἀπόλλυσιν· ἐπεὶ καὶ τὸ ἔλαιον τοῖς μὲν φυτοῖς ἅπασιν ἐστὶν πάγκακον καὶ ταῖς θριξίν πολεμιώτατον ταῖς τῶν ἄλλων ζώων πλὴν ταῖς τοῦ ἀνθρώπου, ταῖς δὲ τοῦ ἀνθρώπου ἄρωγόν καὶ τῷ ἄλλῳ σώματι. οὕτω δὲ ποικίλον τί ἐστὶν τὸ ἀγαθὸν καὶ παντοδαπόν, ὥστε καὶ ἐνταῦθα τοῖς μὲν ἔξωθεν τοῦ

334c

But the good is so variegated and multifaceted that, even in our own case, the very same substance is good for the external parts of the human body and very bad for the internal parts. That is why all the physicians prohibit sick people from using oil on whatever they are going to eat, except in minute quantities to quell the nausea that arises from the odours of food and its sauces.”

σώματος ἀγαθὸν ἐστὶν τῷ ἀνθρώπῳ, τοῖς δ' ἐντὸς ταῦτόν τοῦτο κάκιστον· καὶ διὰ τοῦτο οἱ ἰατροὶ πάντες ἀπαγορεύουσιν τοῖς ἀσθενοῦσιν μὴ χρῆσθαι ἐλαίῳ ἀλλ' ἢ ὅτι σμικροτάτῳ ἐν τούτοις οἷς μέλλει ἔδεσθαι, ὅσον μόνον τὴν δυσχέρειαν κατασβέσαι τὴν ἐπὶ ταῖς αἰσθήσεσι ταῖς διὰ τῶν ῥινῶν γιγνομένην ἐν τοῖς σιτίοις τε καὶ ὄψοις. εἰπόντος οὖν ταῦτα αὐτοῦ οἱ παρόντες ἀνεθορύβησαν ὥς εὖ λέγοι, καὶ ἐγὼ εἶπον· ὦ Πρωταγόρα, ἐγὼ τυγχάνω ἐπιλήσμων τις ὢν ἄνθρωπος, καὶ ἕαν τίς μοι μακρὰ λέγῃ,

334d

Now, once he had said all this, the company applauded his well-delivered speech, and I said, “Protagoras, it so happens that I am a forgetful man, and if someone speaks to me at length I forget what topic the argument is dealing with. Now, if I had been somewhat deaf

you would have thought it necessary to speak more loudly to me than to the others, if you really wanted to converse with me. So also in this case, since I am forgetful, curtail your responses to me and make them shorter, if I am to follow you.”

334d

“So, in what sense are you instructing me to answer briefly?” he said. “Should I answer you more briefly than necessary?”

334d

“Not at all,” I replied.

334d

“As much as necessary then?” he asked.

ἐπιλανθάνομαι περὶ οὗ ἂν ἦ ὁ λόγος. ὥσπερ οὖν εἰ ἐτύγχανον ὑπόκωφος ὢν, ὧου ἂν χρῆναι, εἴπερ ἔμελλές μοι διαλέξεσθαι, μεῖζον φθέγγεσθαι ἢ πρὸς τοὺς ἄλλους, οὕτω καὶ νῦν, ἐπειδὴ ἐπιλήσμονι ἐνέτυχες, σύντεμνέ μοι τὰς ἀποκρίσεις καὶ βραχυτέρας ποίει, εἰ μέλλω σοι ἔπεσθαι. πῶς οὖν κελεύεις με βραχεὰ ἀποκρίνεσθαι; ἢ βραχυτέρά σοι, ἔφη, ἀποκρίνωμαι ἢ δεῖ; μηδαμῶς, ἦν δ' ἐγώ. ἀλλ' ὅσα δεῖ; ἔφη.

334e

“Yes,” said I.

334e

“Well, should I give you as long an answer as I deem necessary or as you deem necessary?”

ναί, ἦν δ' ἐγώ. πότερα οὖν ὅσα ἐμοὶ δοκεῖ δεῖν ἀποκρίνεσθαι, τοσαῦτά σοι ἀποκρίνωμαι, ἢ ὅσα σοί; ΣΩ. ἀκήκοα γοῦν, ἦν δ' ἐγώ, ὅτι σὺ οἴός τ' εἶ καὶ αὐτὸς καὶ ἄλλον διδάξαι περὶ τῶν αὐτῶν καὶ μακρὰ λέγειν, ἐὰν βούλῃ, οὕτως ὥστε τὸν λόγον μηδέποτε ἐπιλιπεῖν, καὶ αὖ βραχεὰ

335a

“What I have heard, anyway,” said I, “is that you yourself are able and can, if you wish, teach others to speak at such length that the speech never peters out, and, what is more, to speak with such brevity on the very same subject that no one could be more brief than you. Now, if

you intend to engage in discourse with me, please employ the latter mode of speaking, the concise one.”

335a

“Socrates,” he replied, “I have by now engaged in verbal contests with very many people, and if I had done as you are instructing me, and engaged in discourse as instructed by my adversary, I would have looked no better than anyone else, nor would the name of Protagoras be known among the Greeks.”

οὕτως ὥστε μηδένα σοῦ ἐν βραχυτέροις εἰπεῖν· εἰ οὖν μέλλεις ἐμοὶ διαλέξεσθαι, τῷ ἐτέρῳ χρῶ τρόπῳ πρὸς με, τῇ βραχυλογίᾳ. ὦ Σώκρατες, ἔφη, ἐγὼ πολλοῖς ἤδη εἰς ἀγῶνα λόγων ἀφικόμην ἀνθρώποις, καὶ εἰ τοῦτο ἐποιοῦν ὃ σὺ κελεύεις, ὥς ὁ ἀντιλέγων ἐκέλευέν με διαλέγεσθαι, οὕτω διελεγόμην, οὐδενὸς ἂν βελτίων ἐφαινόμην οὐδ’ ἂν ἐγένετο Πρωταγόρου ὄνομα ἐν τοῖς Ἑλλήσιν. καὶ ἐγὼ—ἐγνων γὰρ ὅτι οὐκ ἤρεσεν αὐτὸς αὐτῷ ταῖς

335b

I then recognised that he was not pleased with his own responses, the ones he had given earlier, and that he was not prepared to engage in discourse in the role of respondent, if he had a choice.

ἀποκρίσεσιν ταῖς ἔμπροσθεν, καὶ ὅτι οὐκ ἐθέλησοι ἐκὼν εἶναι ἀποκρινόμενος διαλέγεσθαι—ἡγησάμενος οὐκέτι ἐμὸν ἔργον εἶναι παρεῖναι ἐν ταῖς συνουσίαις, ἀλλὰ τοι, ἔφην, ὦ Πρωταγόρα, οὐδ’ ἐγὼ λιπαρῶς ἔχω παρὰ τὰ σοὶ δοκοῦντα τὴν συνουσίαν ἡμῖν γίγνεσθαι, ἀλλ’ ἐπειδὴν σὺ βούλῃ διαλέγεσθαι ὥς ἐγὼ δύναμαι ἔπεσθαι, τότε σοι διαλέξομαι. σὺ μὲν γάρ, ὥς λέγεται περὶ σοῦ, φῆς δὲ καὶ αὐτός, καὶ ἐν μακρολογίᾳ καὶ ἐν βραχυλογίᾳ οἷός τ’ εἶ συνουσίας ποιεῖσθαι

335c

So, having decided that it was not my role to be present at his gatherings any longer, I said, “Well, Protagoras, neither am I comfortable about conducting our meeting in a manner contrary to your sentiments, but whenever you are prepared to engage in discourse in a way that I can follow, then I shall discourse with you. For

they say that you are wise and can conduct gatherings based upon lengthy speeches or concise speeches, and you confirm this yourself, while for my part I am not able to handle these lengthy speeches, although I wish I could. But since you are able to do both, you should have co-operated with us so that the gathering might have proceeded. And now, since you are unwilling, and I have some business and need to be elsewhere, I am unable to remain with you as you make these lengthy speeches. So I shall depart, although I might well have enjoyed hearing you deliver them.”

—σοφὸς γὰρ εἶ—ἐγὼ δὲ τὰ μακρὰ ταῦτα ἀδύνατος, ἐπεὶ ἐβουλόμην ἂν οἷός τ' εἶναι. ἀλλὰ σὲ ἐχρῆν ἡμῖν συγχωρεῖν τὸν ἀμφοτέρωθεν δυνάμενον, ἵνα ἡ συνουσία ἐγίγνετο· νῦν δὲ ἐπειδὴ οὐκ ἐθέλεις καὶ ἐμοί τις ἀσχολία ἐστὶν καὶ οὐκ ἂν οἷός τ' εἶην σοι παραμεῖναι ἀποτείνοντι μακροὺς λόγους—ἐλθεῖν γάρ ποί με δεῖ—εἵμι· ἐπεὶ καὶ ταῦτ' ἂν ἴσως οὐκ ἀηδῶς σου ἤκουον. καὶ ἅμα ταῦτ' εἰπὼν ἀνιστάμην ὡς ἀπιών· καὶ μου ἀνισταμένου ἐπιλαμβάνεται ὁ Καλλίας τῆς χειρὸς τῇ δεξιᾷ,

335d

Once I had said this, I was getting up to leave, and, as I was doing so, Callias grabs my hand with his right hand, tugs this worn cloak of mine with his left, and says, “We shall not let you go, Socrates, for once you depart our dialogue will not proceed in the same way. So, I am asking you to remain with us, for there is nothing that would please me more than hearing yourself and Protagoras engaging in discourse. Come on, please do us all this favour.”

τῇ δ' ἀριστερᾷ ἀντελάβετο τοῦ τρίβωνος τουτουῖ, καὶ εἶπεν· οὐκ ἀφήσομέν σε, ὦ Σώκρατες· ἐὰν γὰρ σὺ ἐξέλθῃς, οὐχ ὁμοίως ἡμῖν ἔσσονται οἱ διάλογοι. δέομαι οὖν σου παραμεῖναι ἡμῖν· ὡς ἐγὼ οὐδ' ἂν ἐνὸς ἡδῖον ἀκούσαιμι ἢ σοῦ τε καὶ Πρωταγόρου διαλεγομένων. ἀλλὰ χάρισαι ἡμῖν πᾶσιν. καὶ ἐγὼ εἶπον—ἤδη δὲ ἀνείστηκη ὡς ἐξιών—ὦ παῖ Ἴππονίκου, αἰεὶ μὲν ἔγωγέ σου τὴν φιλοσοφίαν ἄγαμαι, ἀτὰρ

335e

At that stage I had stood up to make my exit, and I said, “Son of Hipponicus, I always admire your love of wisdom, and now, in particular, I praise it and love it, and so I would like to grant you a favour if you were to ask me to do something I can do. But at the moment it is as if you were asking me to follow Criso, the champion runner from Himera, when he is at his best, or to run and keep pace with one of the long-distance runners or those who can run all day, for I would reply that I want this for myself much more than you do. But I simply cannot keep pace with these runners. So, if you want to see myself and Criso running in the same race, you must ask him to drop his pace, for I am unable to run quickly, while he is capable of running slowly.

καὶ νῦν ἐπαινῶ καὶ φιλῶ, ὥστε βουλοίμην ἂν χαρίζεσθαί σοι, εἴ μου δυνατὰ δέοιο· ΣΩ. νῦν δ' ἐστὶν ὥσπερ ἂν εἰ δέοιό μου Κρίσωνι τῷ Ἰμεραίῳ δρομεῖ ἀκμάζοντι ἔπεσθαι, ἢ τῶν δολιχοδρόμων τῷ ἢ τῶν ἡμεροδρόμων διαθεῖν τε καὶ ἔπεσθαι, εἵπομαι ἂν σοι ὅτι πολὺ σοῦ μᾶλλον ἐγὼ ἐμαντοῦ δέομαι θεοῦσιν τούτοις ἀκολουθεῖν, ἀλλ' οὐ γὰρ δύναμαι, ἀλλ' εἴ τι δέη θεάσασθαι ἐν τῷ αὐτῷ ἐμέ τε καὶ Κρίσωνα θεόντας, τούτου δέου συγκαθεῖναι· ἐγὼ μὲν γὰρ οὐ δύναμαι ταχὺ θεῖν, οὗτος δὲ δύναται βραδέως. εἰ οὖν ἐπιθυμεῖς ἐμοῦ καὶ Πρωταγόρου ἀκούειν, τούτου δέου, ὥσπερ τὸ πρῶτόν μοι ἀπεκρίνατο διὰ βραχέων τε καὶ αὐτὰ τὰ ἐρωτώμενα, οὕτω καὶ νῦν ἀποκρίνεσθαι·

336b

Now, if you are eager to hear Protagoras and myself, please ask him to answer me now in the same way he answered at first, briefly, just responding to what is asked. Otherwise, what dialogue will

336b

there be? For I thought, anyway, that meeting and engaging in discourse with one another was different from public speech-making.”

336b

“But you see, Socrates,” he replied, “Protagoras seems justified in claiming that he himself should be allowed to engage in discourse in

whatever manner he prefers, and you seem justified in claiming that he should speak in the manner you prefer.”

εἰ δὲ μή, τίς ὁ τρόπος ἔσται τῶν διαλόγων; χωρὶς γὰρ ἔγωγ’ ὥμην εἶναι τὸ συνεῖναι τε ἀλλήλοις διαλεγομένους καὶ τὸ δημηγορεῖν. ἀλλ’—ὀρᾷς;—ἔφη, ὦ Σώκратες, δίκαια δοκεῖ λέγειν Πρωταγόρας ἀξιῶν αὐτῷ τε ἐξεῖναι διαλέγεσθαι ὅπως βούλεται, καὶ σὺ ὅπως ἂν αὐτὸ σὺ βούλῃ. ὑπολαβὼν οὖν ὁ Ἀλκιβιάδης, οὐ καλῶς λέγεις, ἔφη, ὦ Καλλία· Σωκράτης μὲν γὰρ ὅδε ὁμολογεῖ μὴ μετεῖναι οἱ μακρολογίας καὶ παραχωρεῖ Πρωταγόρα, τοῦ δὲ διαλέγεσθαι

336c

At this point Alcibiades took issue and said, “That is not right, Callias! Socrates here concedes that he has no capacity for lengthy speeches, and here he gives way to Protagoras. Yet, in his ability to carry on discourse, and knowing how to present an argument and deal with one, I would be surprised if he gave way to any person. Now, if Protagoras also agrees that he is inferior to Socrates in discourse, that is enough for Socrates. But if he is opposed, let him engage in discourse without stretching out each answer into a lengthy speech, beating arguments down, being unwilling to present an argument, and taking so long that most of the listeners forget what the question was about. Yet I assure you that Socrates will not forget, even though he plays games and claims to be forgetful. Now, since each of us should present his own viewpoint, it seems to me that Socrates is speaking more reasonably.”

οἷός τ’ εἶναι καὶ ἐπίστασθαι λόγον τε δοῦναι καὶ δέξασθαι θαυμάζοιμ’ ἂν εἴ τῳ ἀνθρώπων παραχωρεῖ. εἰ μὲν οὖν καὶ Πρωταγόρας ὁμολογεῖ φαυλότερος εἶναι Σωκράτους διαλεχθῆναι, ἐξαρκεῖ Σωκράτει· εἰ δὲ ἀντιποιεῖται, διαλεγέσθω ἐρωτῶν τε καὶ ἀποκρινόμενος, μὴ ἐφ’ ἐκάστη ἐρωτῇ μακρὸν λόγον ἀποτείνων, ἐκκρούων τοὺς λόγους καὶ οὐκ ἐθέλων διδόναι λόγον, ἀλλ’ ἀπομηκύνων ἕως ἂν ἐπιλάθωνται περὶ οὗτο τοῦ ἐρώτημα ἦν οἱ πολλοὶ τῶν ἀκούοντων· ἐπεὶ Σωκράτης γε ἐγὼ ἐγγυῶμαι μὴ ἐπιλήσεσθαι, οὐχ ὅτι παίζει καὶ φησιν ἐπιλήσμων εἶναι.

ἐμοὶ μὲν οὖν δοκεῖ ἐπεικέστερα Σωκράτης λέγειν· χρή γὰρ ἕκαστον τὴν ἑαυτοῦ γνώμην ἀποφαίνεσθαι. μετὰ δὲ τὸν Ἀλκιβιάδην, ὡς ἐγῶμαι, Κριτίας ἦν ὁ εἰπών· ὦ Πρόδικε καὶ Ἱππία, Καλλίας μὲν δοκεῖ μοι μάλα πρὸς

336e

I think Critias was the one who spoke after Alcibiades. “Prodicus and Hippias,” he said, “I think Callias is much disposed towards Protagoras, while Alcibiades is always eager for victory in whatever he takes on. But we should not take sides in this, either for Socrates or for Protagoras.

Πρωταγόρου εἶναι, Ἀλκιβιάδης δὲ αἰεὶ φιλόνομος ἐστὶ πρὸς ὃ ἂν ὁρμήσῃ ἡμᾶς δὲ οὐδὲν δεῖ συμφιλονικεῖν οὔτε Σωκράτει οὔτε Πρωταγόρᾳ, ἀλλὰ κοινῇ ἀμφοτέρων δεῖσθαι μὴ μεταξὺ διαλῦσαι τὴν συνουσίαν.

337a

No, we should jointly ask both of them not to break up the gathering in mid-course.”

337a

Once he had said this, Prodicus in turn said, “I think you have expressed that nicely, Critias.

ΣΩ. εἰπόντος δὲ αὐτοῦ ταῦτα, ὁ Πρόδικος, καλῶς μοι, ἔφη, δοκεῖς λέγειν, ὦ Κριτία· χρή γὰρ τοὺς ἐν τοιοῖσδε λόγοις παραγιγνομένους κοινούς μὲν εἶναι ἀμφοῖν τοῖν διαλεγόμενοι ἀκροατάς, ἴσους δὲ μὴ—ἔστιν γὰρ οὐ ταυτόν· κοινῇ μὲν γὰρ ἀκοῦσαι δεῖ ἀμφοτέρων, μὴ ἴσον δὲ νεῖμαι ἑκατέρῳ, ἀλλὰ τῷ μὲν σοφωτέρῳ πλεόν, τῷ δὲ ἀμαθεστέρῳ ἔλαττον. ἐγὼ μὲν καὶ αὐτός, ὦ Πρωταγόρα τε καὶ Σώκρατες, ἀξιῶ ὑμᾶς συγχωρεῖν καὶ ἀλλήλοις περὶ τῶν λόγων ἀμφισβητεῖν μὲν,

337b

Indeed, those who are present at discussions of this sort should grant a common hearing to both parties, but not as equals for they are not the same. We should indeed grant a common hearing to both and not assign equal status to each. Assign greater status to the more wise and less to the more foolish. I, for my part, Protagoras and Socrates, think

it best that you agree to debate these issues rather than arguing over them, for friends also debate with friends in a spirit of good will, while disputants and enemies argue with one another. So, the fairest way to conduct your meeting is through debate, for in this way you, the speakers, will best be held in good repute by us listeners, even though you may not be praised. For a good reputation rests in the souls of your listeners with no accompanying deception, while praise expressed in words is often falsely expressed and contrary to the opinion of the speaker. We, your listeners, for our part, would be most gladdened by this approach rather than pleased, for being gladdened is learning something and acquiring understanding just in the mind, while being pleased is eating something or experiencing some other pleasure just in the body.”

ἐρίζειν δὲ μή—ἀμφισβητοῦσι μὲν γὰρ καὶ δι’ εὐνοίαν οἱ φίλοι τοῖς φίλοις, ἐρίζουσιν δὲ οἱ διάφοροί τε καὶ ἐχθροὶ ἀλλήλοις—καὶ οὕτως ἂν καλλίστη ἡμῖν ἡ συνουσία γίγνοιτο· ὑμεῖς τε γὰρ οἱ λέγοντες μάλιστ’ ἂν οὕτως ἐν ἡμῖν τοῖς ἀκούουσιν εὐδοκιμοῖτε καὶ οὐκ ἐπαινοῖσθε—εὐδοκιμεῖν μὲν γὰρ ἔστιν παρὰ ταῖς ψυχαῖς τῶν ἀκούοντων ἄνευ ἀπάτης, ἐπαινεῖσθαι δὲ ἐν λόγῳ πολλάκις παρὰ δόξαν ψευδομένων—ἡμεῖς τ’ αὖ οἱ ἀκούοντες μάλιστ’ ἂν οὕτως εὐφραينوίμεθα, οὐχ ἡδοίμεσθα—εὐφραίνεσθαι μὲν γὰρ ἔστιν μαθάνοντά τι καὶ φρονήσεως μεταλαμβάνοντα αὐτῇ τῇ διανοίᾳ, ἡδεσθαι δὲ ἐσθιοντά τι ἢ ἄλλο ἡδὺ πάσχοντα αὐτῷ τῷ σώματι. ταῦτα οὖν εἰπόντος τοῦ Προδίκου πολλοὶ πάνν τῶν παρόντων ἀπεδέξαντο· μετὰ δὲ τὸν πρόδικον Ἱππίας ὁ σοφὸς εἶπεν, ὦ ἄνδρες, ἔφη, οἱ παρόντες, ἡγοῦμαι ἐγὼ ὑμᾶς συγγενεῖς τε καὶ οἰκείους καὶ πολίτας ἅπαντας εἶναι—

337d

When Prodicus had said all this, the vast majority of those present accepted it. The wise Hippias spoke after Prodicus. “Gentlemen here present,” he said, “I consider you all to be kindred, family and fellow citizens, by nature but not by convention, for by nature like is kindred to like, while convention, the tyrant of humanity, exercises force in general opposition to nature. So, it would be disgraceful for us who

understand the nature of things, we who are the wisest of the Greeks, gathered together now for this very reason in the very shrine of wisdom of the Greek world and, in this, the greatest and most prosperous household in that very city, it would be a disgrace, I say, if we were to display nothing worthy of our status but were to quarrel with one another just like commonest of people. So, Protagoras and Socrates, I have a request. I advise you to come to an agreement as though you were being brought to a middle ground by us arbitrators. Socrates, you should not pursue this accurate form of discourse that is excessively short if it does not please Protagoras. You should, rather, let go, and loose the restraints upon the speeches so that they may sound more grandiose and elegant to us. Nor should Protagoras, for his part, hoist every sail and run before the wind, hastening out into an ocean of words, out of sight of land. Instead, you should both steer a middle course. So do as I say, and on my advice select an umpire or overseer or president who will keep watch over the due measure of your speeches in each case.”

φύσει, οὐ νόμῳ· τὸ γὰρ ὅμοιον τῷ ὁμοίῳ φύσει συγγενές ἐστιν, ὁ δὲ νόμος, τύραννος ὢν τῶν ἀνθρώπων, πολλὰ παρὰ τὴν φύσιν βιάζεται— ἡμᾶς οὖν αἰσχρὸν τὴν μὲν φύσιν τῶν πραγμάτων εἶδέναι, σοφωτάτους δὲ ὄντας τῶν Ἑλλήνων, καὶ κατ’ αὐτὸ τοῦτο νῦν συνεληλυθότας τῆς τε Ἑλλάδος εἰς αὐτὸ τὸ πρυτανεῖον τῆς σοφίας καὶ αὐτῆς τῆς πόλεως εἰς τὸν μέγιστον καὶ ὀλβιώτατον οἶκον τόνδε, μηδὲν τούτου τοῦ ἀξιώματος ἄξιον ἀποφύνασθαι, ἀλλ’ ὥσπερ τοὺς φαυλοτάτους τῶν ἀνθρώπων διαφέρεισθαι ἀλλήλοις. ΣΩ. ἐγὼ μὲν οὖν καὶ δέομαι καὶ συμβουλεύω, ὦ Πρωταγόρα τε καὶ Σώκρατες, συμβῆναι ὑμᾶς ὥσπερ ὑπὸ διαιτητῶν ἡμῶν συμβιβαζόντων εἰς τὸ μέσον, καὶ μήτε σὲ τὸ ἀκριβὲς τοῦτο εἶδος τῶν διαλόγων ζητεῖν τὸ κατὰ βραχὺ λίαν, εἰ μὴ ἡδὺ Πρωταγόρα, ἀλλ’ ἐφεῖναι καὶ χαλάσαι τὰς ἡνίας τοῖς λόγοις, ἵνα μεγαλοπρεπέστεροι καὶ εὐσχημονέστεροι ἡμῖν φαίνωνται, μήτ’ αὖ Πρωταγόραν πάντα κάλων ἐκτείναντα, οὐρία ἐφέντα, φεύγειν εἰς τὸ πέλαγος τῶν λόγων ἀποκρύψαντα γῆν, ἀλλὰ μέσον τι ἀμφοτέρους τεμεῖν. ὥς οὖν ποιήσετε, καὶ πείθεσθέ μοι ῥαβδοῦχον καὶ ἐπιστάτην καὶ

πρῦτανιν ἐλέσθαι ὃς ὑμῖν φυλάξει τὸ μέτριον μῆκος τῶν λόγων ἐκατέρου. ταῦτα ἤρεσε τοῖς παροῦσι, καὶ πάντες ἐπῆνεσαν, καὶ ἐμέ τε ὁ Καλλίας οὐκ ἔφη ἀφήσειν καὶ ἐλέσθαι ἐδέοντο ἐπιστάτην. εἶπον οὖν ἐγὼ ὅτι αἰσχρὸν εἶη βραβευτὴν ἐλέσθαι τῶν λόγων. εἴτε γὰρ χειρῶν ἔσται ἡμῶν ὁ αἰρεθεὶς, οὐκ ὀρθῶς ἂν ἔχοι τὸν χεῖρω τῶν βελτιόνων ἐπιστατεῖν, εἴτε ὅμοιος, οὐδ' οὕτως ὀρθῶς· ὁ γὰρ ὅμοιος ἡμῖν ὅμοια καὶ ποιήσει, ὥστε ἐκ

338c

The company was pleased at this, and everyone signalled their approval. Callias would not allow me to depart, and they asked me to select an overseer. I said that it would be a shame to select an adjudicator for the discussions. “For,” said I, “if the person chosen were of lesser rate than the two of us, it would be inappropriate that an inferior should oversee his superiors. If he were just like us, that would not be right either, for someone like us would behave as we do and it would be pointless to choose him. And so, you will select someone who is superior to both of us.

περιττοῦ ἡρήσεται. ἀλλὰ δὴ βελτίονα ἡμῶν αἰρήσεσθε. τῇ μὲν ἀληθείᾳ, ὥς ἐγὼμαι, ἀδύνατον ὑμῖν ὥστε Πρωταγόρου τοῦδε σοφώτερόν τινα ἐλέσθαι· εἰ δὲ αἰρήσεσθε μὲν μηδὲν βελτίω, φήσετε δέ, αἰσχρὸν καὶ τοῦτο τῷδε γίγνεται, ὥσπερ φαύλῳ ἀνθρώπῳ ἐπιστάτην αἰρεῖσθαι, ἐπεὶ τό γ' ἐμὸν οὐδὲν μοι διαφέρει. ἀλλ' οὕτωςι ἐθέλω ποιῆσαι, ἵν' ὁ προθυμεῖσθε συνουσία τε καὶ διάλογοι ἡμῖν γίγνωνται· εἰ μὴ βούλεται

338d

But, in truth, I think it is an impossibility for you to select someone who is wiser than this man, Protagoras. And if you choose someone who is not superior, but you assert that he is, this would also debase Protagoras by treating him like an ordinary fellow and assigning him a supervisor. As for myself, well, it makes no difference to me. So, here is what I propose to do so that the meeting and conversation you are all so keen on may take place. If Protagoras does not wish to answer questions, then he should ask questions and I shall answer. At the same time, I shall try to show him how, in my view, a respondent should

answer a question. And since I am prepared to answer as many questions as the man wishes to ask, he should in turn submit to me and respond in a similar manner. Now, if he seems reluctant to answer a particular question he is asked, then you and I together must implore him, just as you implored me, not to break up the gathering. And to this end, no single person need act as an overseer; rather you will all share in the process of supervision.” Everyone thought that this was the right way to proceed, and although Protagoras was not very keen, he was compelled nevertheless to agree to ask questions and, once he had asked enough of them, to take his turn at giving brief responses to any questions put to him.

Πρωταγόρας ἀποκρίνεσθαι, οὗτος μὲν ἐρωτάτω, ἐγὼ δὲ ἀποκρινοῦμαι, καὶ ἅμα πειράσσομαι αὐτῷ δεῖξαι ὡς ἐγὼ φημι χρῆναι τὸν ἀποκρινόμενον ἀποκρίνεσθαι· ἐπειδὴ δὲ ἐγὼ ἀποκρίνωμαι ὅποσ’ ἂν οὗτος βούληται ἐρωτᾶν, πάλιν οὗτος ἐμοὶ λόγον ὑποσχέτω ὁμοίως. ἐὰν οὖν μὴ δοκῇ πρόθυμος εἶναι πρὸς αὐτὸ τὸ ἐρωτώμενον ἀποκρίνεσθαι, καὶ ἐγὼ καὶ ὑμεῖς κοινῇ δεησόμεθα αὐτοῦ ἅπερ ὑμεῖς ἐμοῦ, μὴ διαφθεῖρειν τὴν συνουσίαν· καὶ οὐδὲν δεῖ τοῦτου ἔνεκα ἕνα ἐπιστάτην γενέσθαι, ἀλλὰ πάντες κοινῇ ἐπιστατήσετε. ἐδόκει πᾶσιν οὕτω ποιητέον εἶναι· καὶ ὁ Πρωταγόρας πάνυ μὲν οὐκ ἤθελεν, ὅμως δὲ ἡναγκάσθη ὁμολογεῖν ἐρωτήσεις, καὶ ἐπειδὴ ἱκανῶς ἐρωτήσῃ, πάλιν δώσειν λόγον κατὰ σμικρὸν ἀποκρινόμενος. ΣΩ. ἤρξατο οὖν ἐρωτᾶν οὕτωςί πως· —ήγοῦμαι, ἔφη, ὦ Σώκρατες, ἐγὼ ἀνδρὶ παιδείας μέγιστον μέρος εἶναι περὶ ἐπῶν

339a

So Protagoras began his questioning in some such manner as this. “I believe, Socrates,” he said, “that a most significant part of a man’s education is proficiency in relation to poetry. This consists of being able to appreciate which of the poets’ writings are well composed and which are not, and knowing how to distinguish between them and give an account of them when questioned. And, indeed, my question will now relate to the very matter you and I are now discussing – that is, excellence. But the question will be transferred to the realm of

poetry, and to this extent alone it will be different. Indeed, Simonides, speaking to Scopas, the son of Creon of Thessaly, says somewhere,

δεινὸν εἶναι ἔστιν δὲ τοῦτο τὰ ὑπὸ τῶν ποιητῶν λεγόμενα οἷόν τ' εἶναι
 συνιέναι ἅ τε ὀρθῶς πεποιήται καὶ ἅ μὴ, καὶ ἐπίστασθαι διελεῖν τε καὶ
 ἐρωτῶμενον λόγον δοῦναι. καὶ δὴ καὶ νῦν ἔσται τὸ ἐρώτημα περὶ τοῦ
 αὐτοῦ μὲν περὶ οὐπὲρ ἐγὼ τε καὶ σὺ νῦν διαλεγόμεθα, περὶ ἀρετῆς,
 μετενηγεγμένον δ' εἰς ποίησιν· τοσοῦτον μόνον διοίσει. λέγει γάρ που
 Σιμωνίδης πρὸς Σκόπαν τὸν Κρέοντος υἱὸν τοῦ Θεταλοῦ ὅτι—

339b

*For a man to become good truly is hard,
 foursquare in hand, foot and intellect,
 fashioned without a flaw.*

339b

“Do you know this ode, or shall I recite it all to you?”

339b

“It is not necessary,” I replied, “for I know this ode, and as it happens I have studied it closely.”

339b

“It is good that you say so,” said he. “Now, do you think it has been beautifully and properly composed or not?”

339b

“Beautifully and properly composed in every way,” I replied.

339b

“But do you think it is beautifully composed if the poet contradicts himself?”

339b

“No, not beautifully,” I replied.

ἄνδρ' ἀγαθὸν μὲν ἀλαθέως γενέσθαι χαλεπόν, χερσίν τε καὶ ποσὶ καὶ
 νόῳ τετράγωνον, ἄνευ ψόγου τετυγμένον. τοῦτο ἐπίστασαι τὸ ἄσμα, ἢ

πάν σοι διεξέλθω; καὶ ἐγὼ εἶπον ὅτι οὐδὲν δεῖ ἐπίσταμαί τε γάρ, καὶ πάνυ μοι τυγχάνει μεμεληκὸς τοῦ ἄσματος. εὖ, ἔφη, λέγεις. πότερον οὖν καλῶς σοι δοκεῖ πεποιῆσθαι καὶ ὀρθῶς, ἢ οὔ;—πάνυ, ἔφην ἐγώ, καλῶς τε καὶ ὀρθῶς.—δοκεῖ δέ σοι καλῶς πεποιῆσθαι, εἰ ἐναντία λέγει αὐτὸς αὐτῷ ὁ ποιητής;—οὐ καλῶς, ἦν δ' ἐγώ.—ὅρα δὴ, ἔφη,

339c

“Then take a better look at it,” he said.

339c

“But, my good man, I have scrutinised it quite sufficiently!”

339c

“In that case you know that as the ode continues it somehow says,

339c

*Nor do I regard Pittacus²¹ statement as sound,
even though the man was wise,
when he says that 'tis hard to be noble.*

339c

“You do realise that the same person who said this also made the previous statement?”

339c

“I know,” I said.

339c

“Well,” he asked, “do you think these words are in agreement with the others?”

339c

“So it seems to me anyway,” I replied, but at the same time I was afraid that he might have a point. “Why?” I asked. “Do they not seem so to you?”

βέλτιον.—ἀλλ', ὠγαθέ, ἔσκεμμαι ἱκανῶς.—οἶσθα οὖν, ἔφη, ὅτι προϊόντος τοῦ ἄσματος λέγει που—οὐδέ μοι ἐμμελέως τὸ Πιττάκειον

νέμεται,καίτοι σοφοῦ παρὰ φωτὸς εἰρημένον· χαλεπὸν φάτ' ἐσθλὸν ἔμμεναι. ἐννοεῖς ὅτι ὁ αὐτὸς οὗτος καὶ τάδε λέγει κάκεῖνα τὰ ἔμπροσθεν;—οἶδα, ἦν δ' ἐγώ.—δοκεῖ οὖν σοι, ἔφη, ταῦτα ἐκείνοις ὁμολογεῖσθαι;—φαίνεται ἔμοιγε (καὶ ἅμα μέντοι ἐφοβούμην μὴ τί λέγοι) ἀτάρ, ἔφην ἐγώ, σοὶ οὐ φαίνεται;—πῶς γὰρ ἂν

339d

“Well, how could someone who makes these two statements show a semblance of agreement with himself? He himself first proposed that it is difficult for a man to become truly good, and a little later in the poem he forgets this and censures Pittacus who says the same thing as himself – that it is difficult to be noble – and refuses to accept from Pittacus the same point he himself is making. What is more, whenever he censures someone who says the same things as himself, it is obvious that he is censuring himself, and so either his earlier statement or his last statement is incorrectly formulated.”

φαίνοιτο ὁμολογεῖν αὐτὸς ἑαυτῷ ὁ ταῦτα ἀμφοτέρα λέγων, ὅς γε τὸ μὲν πρῶτον αὐτὸς ὑπέθετο χαλεπὸν εἶναι ἄνδρα ἀγαθὸν γενέσθαι ἀλαθείᾳ, ὀλίγον δὲ τοῦ ποιήματος εἰς τὸ πρόσθεν προελθὼν ἐπελάθετο, καὶ Πιττακὸν τὸν ταῦτα λέγοντα ἑαυτῷ, ὅτι χαλεπὸν ἐσθλὸν ἔμμεναι, τοῦτον μέμφεται τε καὶ οὐ φησιν ἀποδέχεσθαι αὐτοῦ τὰ αὐτὰ ἑαυτῷ λέγοντος; καίτοι ὁπότε τὸν ταῦτα λέγοντα αὐτῷ μέμφεται, δῆλον ὅτι καὶ ἑαυτὸν μέμφεται, ὥστε ἦτοι τὸ πρότερον ἢ ὕστερον οὐκ ὀρθῶς λέγει. εἰπὼν οὖν ταῦτα πολλοῖς θόρυβον παρέσχεν καὶ ἔπαινον

339e

Now, once he had said all this, it drew a clamour of approval from most of the audience. At first it was as if I had been punched by a good boxer. I went blank and became dizzy due to the words he had spoken and the general commotion. Then – and to tell you the truth, it was to give me time to consider what the poet might be saying – I turned to Prodicus, addressed him and said, “Prodicus, Simonides was of course a fellow citizen of yours, so it is only right that you come to the man’s aid. So I think I will call upon you, just as Scamander, according to Homer, called upon Simois when he was besieged by Achilles, by saying,

τῶν ἀκουόντων· καὶ ἐγὼ τὸ μὲν πρῶτον, ὥσπερ εἰ ὑπὸ ἀγαθοῦ πύκτου πληγεῖς, ἐσκοτώθην τε καὶ ἱλιγγίασα εἰπόντος αὐτοῦ ταῦτα καὶ τῶν ἄλλων ἐπιθορυβησάντων· ἔπειτα—ὥς γε πρὸς σέ εἰρῆσθαι τάληθῃ, ἵνα μοι χρόνος ἐγγένηται τῇ σκέψει τί λέγοι ὁ ποιητής—τρέπομαι πρὸς τὸν πρόδικον, καὶ καλέσας αὐτόν, ὦ Πρόδικε, ἔφην ἐγώ, σὸς μέντοι Σιμωνίδης πολίτης· δίκαιος εἶ βοηθεῖν τῷ ἀνδρί. ΣΩ. δοκῶ οὖν μοι ἐγὼ παρακαλεῖν σέ· ὥσπερ ἔφη Ὅμηρος τὸν Σκάμανδρον πολιορκούμενον ὑπὸ τοῦ Ἀχιλλέως τὸν Σιμόεντα παρακαλεῖν, εἰπόντα—φίλε κασίγνητε, σθένος ἀνέρος ἀμφοτέροί περσχωμέν, ἀτὰρ καὶ ἐγὼ σέ παρακαλῶ, μὴ ἡμῖν ὁ Πρωταγόρας τὸν Σιμωνίδην ἐκπέρσῃ. καὶ γὰρ οὖν καὶ δεῖται τὸ ὑπὲρ Σιμωνίδου ἐπανόρθωμα τῆς σῆς μουσικῆς, ἥ τό τε βούλεσθαι καὶ

340b

*Dear brother, let us both, together, restrain
the strength of this man.²²*

“So too do I call upon you, lest Protagoras wreak destruction upon Simonides. And at this stage we really need this art of yours to make a correction on Simonides’ behalf, this art whereby you distinguish wishing from desiring, and show that they are not the same, and make lots more beautiful distinctions as you did a moment ago. Let us find out if this seems to you as it does to me, for it is not obvious that Simonides is contradicting himself. But you should state your opinion first, Prodicus. Do you think that ‘to become’ is the same as ‘to be’, or are they different?”

340b

“They are different, by Zeus,” replied Prodicus.

ἐπιθυμεῖν διαιρεῖς ὥς οὐ ταῦτόν ὄν, καὶ ἃ νυνδὴ εἶπες πολλά τε καὶ καλά. καὶ νῦν σκόπει εἴ σοι συνδοκεῖ ὅπερ ἐμοί. οὐ γὰρ φαίνεται ἐναντία λέγειν αὐτὸς αὐτῷ Σιμωνίδης. σὺ γάρ, ὦ Πρόδικε, προαπόφηναι τὴν σὴν γνώμην· ταυτόν σοι δοκεῖ εἶναι τὸ γενέσθαι καὶ τὸ εἶναι, ἢ ἄλλο;—ἄλλο νῆ Δί', ἔφη ὁ Πρόδικος.—οὐκοῦν, ἔφην ἐγώ, ἐν

μὲν τοῖς πρώτοις αὐτὸς ὁ Σιμωνίδης τὴν ἑαυτοῦ γνώμην ἀπεφήνατο, ὅτι ἄνδρα

340c

“In those first lines,” said I, “didn’t Simonides express his own opinion that it would be difficult for a man, in truth, to become good?”

340c

“That is true,” said Prodicus.

ἀγαθὸν ἀληθείᾳ γενέσθαι χαλεπὸν εἶη;—ἀληθῆ λέγεις, ἔφη ὁ Πρόδικος. —τὸν δέ γε Πιττακόν, ἦν δ’ ἐγώ, μέμφεται, οὐχ ὡς οἶεται Πρωταγόρας, ταῦτόν ἑαυτῷ λέγοντα, ἀλλ’ ἄλλο. οὐ γὰρ τοῦτο ὁ Πιττακὸς ἔλεγεν τὸ χαλεπὸν, γενέσθαι ἐσθλόν, ὥσπερ ὁ Σιμωνίδης, ἀλλὰ τὸ ἔμμεναι ἔστιν δὲ οὐ ταῦτόν, ὃ Πρωταγόρα, ὡς φησιν Πρόδικος ὅδε, τὸ εἶναι καὶ τὸ γενέσθαι. εἰ δὲ μὴ τὸ αὐτὸ ἔστιν τὸ εἶναι τῷ γενέσθαι, οὐκ ἐναντία λέγει ὁ Σιμωνίδης αὐτὸς αὐτῷ. καὶ ἴσως ἂν

340d

“Yes. And he then censured Pittacus”, I said, “for saying something different, and not, as Protagoras alleges, for saying the same thing as he himself says. For Pittacus did not, like Simonides, say that it is difficult to become noble, but that it is difficult to be noble. But to be and to become are not the same, Protagoras, as Prodicus here affirmed. And if to be is not the same as to become, then Simonides is not contradicting himself. Yet Prodicus here, and many others, would probably say with Hesiod that it is hard to become good because

340d

*The gods have decreed that sweat
Is a precondition for excellence.*

340d

*But once someone has attained its pinnacle
It is easy thereafter to keep it
Even though it was difficult to acquire.”²³*

Now, when Prodicus heard this he complimented me, but Protagoras said, “Your correction, Socrates, contains a greater error than what you are correcting!”

φαίη Πρόδικος ὅδε καὶ ἄλλοι πολλοὶ καθ’ Ἡσίοδον γενέσθαι μὲν ἀγαθὸν χαλεπὸν εἶναι—τῆς γὰρ ἀρετῆς ἔμπροσθεν τοὺς θεοὺς ἰδρῶτα θεῖναι—ὅταν δέ τις αὐτῆς εἰς ἄκρον ἵκηται, ῥηϊδίην δῆπείτα πέλειν, χαλεπὴν περ ἐοῦσαν, ἐκτῆσθαι. ὁ μὲν οὖν Πρόδικος ἀκούσας ταῦτα ἐπήνεσέν με· ὁ δὲ Πρωταγόρας, τὸ ἐπανόρθωμά σοι, ἔφη, ὦ Σώκρατες, μεῖζον ἀμάρτημα ἔχει ἢ ὁ ἐπανορθοῖς. καὶ ἐγὼ εἶπον· κακὸν ἄρα μοι εἵργασται, ὡς ἔοικεν, ὦ

340e

“Well, Protagoras,” said I, “it seems that I have caused harm, and I am a comical physician who makes the disease worse in the process of curing it.”

340e

“Yes, so you are,” he said.

340e

“How so?” I asked.

340e

“It would be gross ignorance on the part of the poet to claim that the retention of excellence is a trivial matter when in the opinion of everyone else it is the most difficult thing of all.”

340e

“By Zeus,” said I, “it is timely then that this man Prodicus is present for our discussions.

Πρωταγόρα, καὶ εἰμί τις γελοῖος ἰατρός· ἰώμενος μεῖζον τὸ νόσημα ποιῶ. ἀλλ’ οὕτως ἔχει, ἔφη. πῶς δὲ; ἦν δ’ ἐγώ. πολλὴ ἄν, ἔφη, ἀμαθία εἶη τοῦ ποιητοῦ, εἰ οὕτω φαῦλόν τι φησιν εἶναι τὴν ἀρετὴν ἐκτῆσθαι, ὃ

ἐστιν πάντων χαλεπώτατον, ὡς ἅπασιν δοκεῖ ἀνθρώποις. ΣΩ. καὶ ἐγὼ εἶπον· νῆ τὸν Δία, εἰς καιρὸν γε παρατετύχηκεν ἡμῖν ἐν τοῖς λόγοις Πρόδικος ὅδε. κινδυνεύει γάρ τοι, ὦ

341a

For I am telling you, Protagoras, this wisdom of Prodicus may well be divine and ancient, going back to Simonides, or to times even more ancient. And you, who are experienced in so many other areas, appear to have no experience of this wisdom, unlike myself who am experienced due to being a pupil of this very man, Prodicus. Right now I do not think you understand that Simonides does not interpret this word ‘difficult’ in the same way you interpret it. Rather it is like the word ‘terrible’. The same Prodicus corrects me every time, whenever I praise you or anyone else by saying that Protagoras is a terribly wise man, and he asks me if I am not ashamed of myself for referring to what is good as terrible, for he says that whatever is terrible is bad.

Πρωταγόρα, ἡ Προδίκου σοφία θεία τις εἶναι πάλαι, ἥτοι ἀπὸ Σιμωνίδου ἀρξαμένη, ἢ καὶ ἔτι παλαιότερα. σὺ δὲ ἄλλων πολλῶν ἔμπειρος ὢν ταύτης ἄπειρος εἶναι φαίνει, οὐχ ὥσπερ ἐγὼ ἔμπειρος διὰ τὸ μαθητῆς εἶναι Προδίκου τουτουῖ· καὶ νῦν μοι δοκεῖς οὐ μαθάνειν ὅτι καὶ τὸ χαλεπὸν τοῦτο ἴσως οὐχ οὕτως Σιμωνίδης ὑπελάμβανεν ὥσπερ σὺ ὑπολαμβάνεις, ἀλλ’ ὥσπερ περὶ τοῦ δεινοῦ Πρόδικός με οὕτοσί νουθετεῖ ἐκάστοτε, ὅταν ἐπαινῶν ἐγὼ ἢ σὲ ἢ ἄλλον τινὰ λέγω ὅτι Πρωταγόρας σοφὸς καὶ δεινὸς ἐστὶν ἀνὴρ, ἐρωτᾷ εἰ οὐκ αἰσχύνομαι τάγαθὰ δεινὰ καλῶν. τὸ γὰρ δεινόν, φησὶν, κακόν ἐστιν· οὐδεὶς γοῦν λέγει ἐκάστοτε δεινοῦ πλούτου οὐδὲ δεινῆς εἰρήνης οὐδὲ δεινῆς ὑγιείας, ἀλλὰ δεινῆς νόσου καὶ δεινοῦ πολέμου καὶ δεινῆς πενίας, ὡς τοῦ δεινοῦ κακοῦ ὄντος. ἴσως οὖν καὶ τὸ χαλεπὸν αὖ οἱ Κεῖοι καὶ ὁ Σιμωνίδης ἢ κακὸν ὑπολαμβάνουσι ἢ ἄλλο τι ὃ σὺ οὐ μαθάνεις· ἐρώμεθα οὖν πρόδικον—δίκαιον γὰρ τὴν Σιμωνίδου φωνὴν τοῦτον ἐρωτᾶν—τί ἔλεγεν, ὦ Πρόδικε, τὸ

341c

So, for example, no one refers to terrible wealth or to terrible peace or to terrible health, but they do refer to terrible disease or terrible war

or terrible poverty, because whatever is terrible is bad. Now, perhaps the people of Ceos, including Simonides, also interpret this word ‘difficult’ in turn as bad, or as something else that you do not understand. So let us ask Prodicus, for it is only right to ask him about Simonides’ dialect. Prodicus, what did Simonides mean by the word ‘difficult’?”

341c

“Bad,” he replied.

341c

“So, Prodicus,” said I, “that is why he censures Pittacus for saying that it is difficult to be noble. It is as if he were to hear him saying that it is bad to be noble.”

341c

“Well, Socrates,” he replied, “what else do you think Simonides means if he doesn’t mean this? He is censuring Pittacus because he did not know how to distinguish words correctly. He was, after all, from Lesbos, and brought up to speak a foreign dialect.”

χαλεπὸν Σιμωνίδης; κακόν, ἔφη. διὰ ταῦτ’ ἄρα καὶ μέμφεται, ἦν δ’ ἐγώ, ὃ Πρόδικε, τὸν Πιττακὸν λέγοντα χαλεπὸν ἐσθλὸν ἔμμεναι, ὥσπερ ἂν εἰ ἤκουεν αὐτοῦ λέγοντος ὅτι ἐστὶν κακὸν ἐσθλὸν ἔμμεναι. ἀλλὰ τί οἶει, ἔφη, λέγειν, ὃ Σώκρατες, Σιμωνίδην ἄλλο ἢ τοῦτο, καὶ ὀνειδίζειν τῷ Πιττακῷ ὅτι τὰ ὀνόματα οὐκ ἠπίστατο ὀρθῶς διαιρεῖν ἅτε Λέσβιος ὢν καὶ ἐν φωνῇ βαρβάρῳ τεθραμμένος; ἀκούεις δὴ, ἔφην ἐγώ, ὃ Πρωταγόρα, Προδίκου τοῦδε.

341d

“So, Protagoras,” said I, “you have heard Prodicus himself. Have you anything to say about this?”

341d

And Protagoras responded, “This is very far from being the case, Prodicus. No, I know full well that Simonides meant what everyone else means when he said ‘difficult’ – not ‘bad’, but whatever is not easy, and is brought about through a great deal of trouble.”

ἔχεις τι πρὸς ταῦτα λέγειν; καὶ ὁ Πρωταγόρας, πολλοῦ γε δεῖ, ἔφη, οὕτως ἔχειν, ὃ Πρόδικε· ἀλλ' ἐγὼ εὖ οἶδ' ὅτι καὶ Σιμωνίδης τὸ χαλεπὸν ἔλεγεν ὅπερ ἡμεῖς οἱ ἄλλοι, οὐ τὸ κακόν, ἀλλ' ὃ ἂν μὴ ῥάδιον ἢ ἀλλὰ διὰ πολλῶν πραγμάτων γίγνηται. ἀλλὰ καὶ ἐγὼ οἶμαι, ἔφην, ὃ Πρωταγόρα, τοῦτο λέγειν Σιμωνίδην, καὶ Πρόδικόν γε τόνδε εἰδέναι, ἀλλὰ παίζειν καὶ σοῦ δοκεῖν ἀποπειρᾶσθαι εἰ οἷός τ' ἔσῃ τῷ σαυτοῦ λόγῳ βοηθεῖν. ἐπεὶ ὅτι γε Σιμωνίδης οὐ λέγει τὸ χαλεπὸν

341e

“Yes, Protagoras,” I said, “I too believe that this is what Simonides means, and that Prodicus here knows this and is playing a game. And he seems to be testing your ability to come to the aid of your own argument. For there is strong evidence that Simonides does not mean that what is difficult is bad, in the very next sentence, when he says

341e

The distinction would belong to God alone.

κακόν, μέγα τεκμήριόν ἐστιν εὐθὺς τὸ μετὰ τοῦτο ῥῆμα· λέγει γὰρ ὅτι—
θεὸς ἂν μόνος τοῦτ' ἔχοι γέρας, οὐδ' ἄν τοῦτό γε λέγων, κακὸν
ἐσθλὸν ἔμμεναι, εἴτα τὸν θεὸν φησιν μόνον τοῦτο ἂν ἔχειν καὶ τῷ θεῷ
τοῦτο γέρας ἀπένειμε μόνῳ· ἀκόλαστον γὰρ ἂν τινα λέγοι Σιμωνίδην ὁ
Πρόδικος καὶ οὐδαμῶς Κεῖον. ΣΩ. ἀλλ' ἃ μοι δοκεῖ διανοεῖσθαι
Σιμωνίδης ἐν τούτῳ τῷ ᾄσματι, ἐθέλω σοι εἰπεῖν,

342a

“Presumably he cannot mean that it is bad to be noble, when he goes on to say that this belongs to God alone, and he attributes this distinction to God alone. For then Prodicus would surely say that Simonides is a degenerate, and not at all a citizen of Ceos. But I would like to tell you what, in my view, Simonides has in mind in this ode, if you would like to test where I stand ‘in relation to poetry’, to use your phrase. Or if you prefer, I shall listen to you.”

342a

When Protagoras heard my suggestion, he said, “As you wish, Socrates.”

εἰ βούλει λαβεῖν μου πείραν ὅπως ἔχω, ὃ σὺ λέγεις τοῦτο, περὶ ἐπῶν· ἐὰν δὲ βούλῃ, σοῦ ἀκούσομαι. ὁ μὲν οὖν Πρωταγόρας ἀκούσας μου ταῦτα λέγοντος, εἰ σὺ βούλει, ἔφη, ὦ Σώκρατες· ὁ δὲ Πρόδικός τε καὶ ὁ Ἱππίας ἐκελευέτην πάνυ, καὶ οἱ ἄλλοι. ἐγὼ τοίνυν, ἦν δ' ἐγώ, ἃ γέ μοι δοκεῖ περὶ τοῦ ἄσματος τούτου, πειράσομαι ὑμῖν διεξελεῖν. φιλοσοφία γάρ ἐστιν παλαιότατη τε καὶ πλείστη τῶν Ἑλλήνων ἐν Κρήτῃ τε καὶ

342b

And Prodicus and Hippias urged me on, forcibly, and so did the others. “In that case,” said I, “I shall attempt to recount my own views on this ode to you. Indeed, love of wisdom is most ancient and most prevalent among the Greeks of Crete and Sparta, and these regions contain the greatest number of sophists. Yet, just like the sophists Protagoras was talking about, they utterly deny this and put on a show of ignorance so that people may not discover that it is in wisdom that the

ἐν Λακεδαίμονι, καὶ σοφισταὶ πλεῖστοι γῆς ἐκεῖ εἰσιν· ἀλλ' ἐξαρνοῦνται καὶ σχηματίζονται ἀμαθεῖς εἶναι, ἵνα μὴ κατάδηλοι ὦσιν ὅτι σοφία τῶν Ἑλλήνων περίεσιν, ὥσπερ οὐς Πρωταγόρας ἔλεγε τοὺς σοφιστάς, ἀλλὰ δοκῶσιν τῷ μάχεσθαι καὶ ἀνδρεῖα περιεῖναι, ἡγούμενοι, εἰ γνωσθεῖεν ὅτι περίεσιν, πάντας τοῦτο ἀσκήσειν, τὴν σοφίαν. νῦν δὲ ἀποκρυψάμενοι ἐκεῖνο ἐξηπατήκασιν τοὺς ἐν ταῖς πόλεσι λακωνίζοντας, καὶ οἱ μὲν ὧτά τε κατάγνυνται μιμούμενοι

342c

Spartans are pre-eminent among the Greeks. Instead, they give the impression that they are preeminent in warfare and courage, believing that if everyone were to realise the means by which they are pre-eminent, they would all practise this wisdom. They have concealed this fact so well that they have deceived the people in our cities who favour Spartan ways, who then develop cauliflower ears in order to imitate them, bind their knuckles, become keen on gymnastics, and take to wearing short cloaks as if it is through these fashions that the Spartans

hold sway over the Greek world. But when the Spartans wish to consult with their own sophists in an unrestrained manner, and are fed up with meeting in secret, they carry out an expulsion of these ‘imitators of Sparta’ and any other foreigners who are residing there, and consult with their sophists unknown to the foreigners. Nor do they allow any of their young folk to visit other cities, nor do the Cretans, so that their young will not unlearn what they are taught. And in these cities, not only are there men who are proud of their education, but there are women too.

αὐτούς, καὶ ἱμάντας περιελίττονται καὶ φιλογυμναστοῦσιν καὶ βραχείας ἀναβολὰς φοροῦσιν, ὥς δὴ τούτοις κρατοῦντας τῶν Ἑλλήνων τοὺς Λακεδαιμονίους· οἱ δὲ Λακεδαιμόνιοι, ἐπειδὰν βούλωνται ἀνέδην τοῖς παρ’ αὐτοῖς συγγενέσθαι σοφισταῖς καὶ ἤδη ἄχθωνται λάθρᾳ συγγιγνόμενοι, ξηνηλασίας ποιοῦμενοι τῶν τε λακωνιζόντων τούτων καὶ ἐάν τις ἄλλος ξένος ὦν ἐπιδημήσῃ, συγγίγνονται τοῖς σοφισταῖς λανθάνοντες τοὺς ξένους, καὶ αὐτοὶ οὐδένα ἑῷσιν τῶν νέων εἰς τὰς ἄλλας πόλεις ἐξιέναι, ὥσπερ οὐδὲ Κρήτες, ἵνα μὴ ἀπομανθάνωσιν ἃ αὐτοὶ διδάσκουσιν. εἰσὶν δὲ ἐν ταύταις ταῖς πόλεσιν οὐ μόνον ἄνδρες ἐπὶ παιδεύσει μέγα φρονοῦντες, ἀλλὰ καὶ γυναῖκες. γνοῖτε δ’ ἂν ὅτι ἐγὼ ταῦτα ἀληθῆ λέγω καὶ Λακεδαιμόνιοι πρὸς φιλοσοφίαν καὶ λόγους ἄριστα πεπαίδευνται, ὥδε· εἰ γὰρ ἐθέλει τις Λακεδαιμονίων τῷ φαυλοτάτῳ συγγενέσθαι, τὰ μὲν πολλὰ ἐν τοῖς λόγοις εὐρήσει

342e

“You may appreciate that I am speaking the truth when I say that the Spartans receive the best education in love of wisdom and discourse as follows. If you are prepared to converse with even the most ordinary man from Sparta, you will find that for most of the discourse he appears quite ordinary; but then, regardless of how the conversation is proceeding, he suddenly throws in a telling phrase, short and terse, like a skilled spear thrower, so that his interlocutor looks no better than a child. Now, there are people today, and among our ancestors, who have recognised the fact that being a Spartan consists much more in being a lover of wisdom than in being keen on gymnastics, and who

know that the ability to utter phrases of this kind belongs to a perfectly educated person. Thales of Miletus was one such person, as was Pittacus of Mytilene, Bias of Priene, our own Solon, Cleobolus of Lindos, Myson of Chen, and the seventh was said to be a Spartan, Chilon.²⁴ These were all zealous admirers, devotees and pupils of Spartan education, and you may discern that their own wisdom is of this sort from the short phrases that each of them has spoken, phrases well worth remembering. When these seven gathered together, they dedicated the first fruits of wisdom to Apollo at the temple that is in Delphi, writing those words that everyone repeats: ‘Know Thyself’ and ‘Nothing in Excess’.

αὐτὸν φαῦλόν τινα φαινόμενον, ἔπειτα, ὅπου ἂν τύχη τῶν λεγομένων, ἐνέβαλεν ῥῆμα ἄξιον λόγου βραχὺ καὶ συνεστραμμένον ὥσπερ δεινὸς ἀκοντιστής, ὥστε φαίνεσθαι τὸν προσδιαλεγόμενον παιδὸς μηδὲν βελτίω. ΣΩ. τοῦτο οὖν αὐτὸ καὶ τῶν νῦν εἰσὶν οἱ κατανεοήκασι καὶ τῶν πάλοι, ὅτι τὸ λακωνίζειν πολὺ μᾶλλον ἐστὶν φιλοσοφεῖν ἢ φιλογυμναστεῖν, εἰδότες ὅτι τοιαῦτα οἷόν τ’ εἶναι ῥήματα φθέγγεσθαι τελῶς πεπαιδευμένου ἐστὶν ἀνθρώπου. τούτων ἦν καὶ Θαλῆς ὁ Μιλήσιος καὶ Πιττακὸς ὁ Μυτιληναῖος καὶ Βίας ὁ Πριηνεὺς καὶ Σόλων ὁ ἡμέτερος καὶ Κλεόβουλος ὁ Λίνδιος καὶ Μύσων ὁ Χηνεὺς, καὶ ἔβδομος ἐν τούτοις ἐλέγετο Λακεδαιμόνιος Χίλων. οὗτοι πάντες ζηλωταὶ καὶ ἐρασταὶ καὶ μαθηταὶ ἦσαν τῆς Λακεδαιμονίων παιδείας, καὶ καταμάθοι ἂν τις αὐτῶν τὴν σοφίαν τοιαύτην οὔσαν, ῥήματα βραχέα ἀξιομνημόνευτα ἐκάστω εἰρημένα· οὗτοι καὶ κοινῇ συνελθόντες ἀπαρχὴν τῆς σοφίας ἀνέθεσαν τῷ Ἀπόλλωνι εἰς τὸν νεῶν τὸν ἐν Δελφοῖς, γράψαντες ταῦτα ἃ δὴ πάντες ὑμνοῦσιν, γινῶθι σαυτὸν καὶ μηδὲν ἄγαν. τοῦ δὴ ἔνεκα ταῦτα λέγω; ὅτι οὗτος ὁ τρόπος ἦν τῶν παλαιῶν τῆς φιλοσοφίας, βραχυλογία τις Λακωνικὴ καὶ δὴ καὶ τοῦ Πιττακοῦ ἰδίᾳ περιεφέρετο τοῦτο τὸ ῥῆμα ἐγκωμιαζόμενον ὑπὸ τῶν σοφῶν, τὸ χαλεπὸν ἐσθλὸν ἔμμεναι. ὁ οὖν Σιμωνίδης,

343c

“So why do I mention this? Because this was the manner of philosophy among the ancients, a laconic brevity. What is more, this phrase from

Pittacus circulated in private and was praised by the wise: ‘It is hard to be good’. Now, since Simonides was eager to gain a reputation for wisdom, he realised that if he were to overthrow this maxim, as if it were a famous athlete, and if he were to prevail over it, he himself would become famous among the people of that age. And so, for these reasons, he targeted this maxim, and it appears to me that he composed the entire ode with the intention of putting it down.

ἄτε φιλότιμος ὢν ἐπὶ σοφίᾳ, ἔγνω ὅτι εἰ καθέλοι τοῦτο τὸ ῥῆμα ὥσπερ εὐδοκιμοῦντα ἀθλητὴν καὶ περιγένοιτο αὐτοῦ, αὐτὸς εὐδοκιμήσει ἐν τοῖς τότε ἀνθρώποις. εἰς τοῦτο οὖν τὸ ῥῆμα καὶ τούτου ἕνεκα τούτῳ ἐπιβουλεύων κολοῦσαι αὐτὸ ἅπαν τὸ ἄσμα πεποίηκεν, ὥς μοι φαίνεται. ἐπισκεψώμεθα δὴ αὐτὸ κοινῇ ἅπαντες, εἰ ἄρα ἐγὼ ἀληθῆ λέγω. εὐθὺς γὰρ τὸ πρῶτον τοῦ ἄσματος μανικὸν ἂν φανείη, εἰ βουλόμενος λέγειν ὅτι ἄνδρα ἀγαθὸν γενέσθαι χαλεπὸν,

343d

“So, let us all consider this together. Is what I am saying actually true? The first line of the ode would indeed sound insane if, while intending to state that it is difficult for a man to become good, he then inserted a contrasting phrase. For this does not appear to be a reasonable insertion, unless one assumes that Simonides is arguing against the maxim of Pittacus. Pittacus says that it is hard to be good, but Simonides disputes this and says, ‘No, rather it is hard for a man to become good, Pittacus. That is what is truly hard.’ He does not say ‘truly good’. That is not where he applies the word ‘truly’, as if he were saying that some men are truly good, while others are good yet not truly so, for that would sound silly and unworthy of Simonides. So, we need to suppose that the position of the word ‘truly’ is changed poetically in the ode, and in some way or other this is hinting at the phrase from Pittacus, as if we are to presume that Pittacus himself is speaking and Simonides is replying. Pittacus is saying, ‘People, it is difficult to be good’, while Simonides replies, ‘Pittacus, you are not speaking the truth, for what is truly difficult for a man is not to be good, but to become so, foursquare in hand, foot and intellect,

fashioned without a flaw'. In this way the insertion appears reasonable, and 'truly' lies where it should, at the end. And everything that follows supports the assertion that this is what it means. Indeed, there is a lot more in the various phrases of the ode to demonstrate that it has been well composed, for it is a delightful and intricate piece of work, but it would take too long to go through it in this way. Yet we should scrutinise the character of the work as a whole, and its intention, which is undoubtedly, throughout the entire ode, the refutation of that maxim of Pittacus.

ἔπειτα ἐνέβαλε τὸ μὲν. τοῦτο γὰρ οὐδὲ πρὸς ἓνα λόγον φαίνεται ἐμβεβληθῆναι, ἐὰν μὴ τις ὑπολάβῃ πρὸς τὸ τοῦ Πιττακοῦ ῥῆμα ὥσπερ ἐρίζοντα λέγειν τὸν Σιμωνίδην· λέγοντος τοῦ Πιττακοῦ ὅτι χαλεπὸν ἐσθλὸν ἔμμεναι, ἀμφισβητοῦντα εἰπεῖν ὅτι οὐκ, ἀλλὰ γενέσθαι μὲν χαλεπὸν ἄνδρα ἀγαθὸν ἐστίν, ὃ Πιττακέ, ὡς ἀληθῶς—οὐκ ἀληθείᾳ ἀγαθόν, οὐκ ἐπὶ τούτῳ λέγει τὴν ἀλήθειαν, ὡς ἄρα ὄντων τινῶν τῶν μὲν ὡς ἀληθῶς ἀγαθῶν, τῶν δὲ ἀγαθῶν μὲν, οὐ μέντοι ἀληθῶς—εὐῆθες γὰρ τοῦτό γε φανείη ἂν καὶ οὐ Σιμωνίδου— ΣΩ. ἀλλ' ὑπερβᾶτον δεῖ θεῖναι ἐν τῷ ᾄσματι τὸ ἀλαθέως, οὕτωςί πως ὑπειπόντα τὸ τοῦ Πιττακοῦ, ὥσπερ ἂν εἰ θεῖμεν αὐτὸν λέγοντα τὸν Πιττακὸν καὶ Σιμωνίδην ἀποκρινόμενον εἰπόντα ὃ ἄνθρωποι, χαλεπὸν ἐσθλὸν ἔμμεναι, τὸν δὲ ἀποκρινόμενον ὅτι ὃ Πιττακέ, οὐκ ἀληθῆ λέγεις· οὐ γὰρ εἶναι ἀλλὰ γενέσθαι μὲν ἐστὶν ἄνδρα ἀγαθὸν χερσί τε καὶ ποσὶ καὶ νόφω τετράγωνον, ἄνευ ψόγου τετυγμένον, χαλεπὸν ἀλαθέως. οὕτω φαίνεται τὸ πρὸς λόγον τὸ μὲν ἐμβεβλημένον καὶ τὸ ἀλαθέως ὀρθῶς ἐπ' ἐσχάτῳ κείμενον· καὶ τὰ ἐπιόντα πάντα τούτῳ μαρτυρεῖ, ὅτι οὕτως εἴρηται. πολλὰ μὲν γὰρ ἔστι καὶ περὶ ἐκάστου τῶν ἐν τῷ ᾄσματι εἰρημένων ἀποδείξαι ὡς εὖ πεποιήται—πάνυ γὰρ χαριέντως καὶ μεμελημένως ἔχει—ἀλλὰ μακρὸν ἂν εἴη αὐτὸ οὕτω διελθεῖν· ἀλλὰ τὸν τύπον αὐτοῦ τὸν ὅλον διεξέλθωμεν καὶ τὴν βούλησιν, ὅτι παντὸς μᾶλλον ἔλεγχός ἐστιν τοῦ Πιττακείου ῥήματος διὰ παντὸς τοῦ ᾄσματος. λέγει γὰρ μετὰ τοῦτο ὀλίγα διελθών, ὡς ἂν εἰ λέγοι λόγον, ὅτι γενέσθαι μὲν ἄνδρα ἀγαθὸν χαλεπὸν ἀλαθέως, οἷόν τε μέντοι ἐπὶ γε χρόνον τινά· γενόμενον δὲ διαμένειν

344c

“In fact, a little after this he goes on to say, as if he were lapsing into prose, ‘To become a good man is truly difficult, although it is, of course, possible for a period of time. Yet to remain in this condition once it has been attained, and actually be a good man, is as you say, Pittacus, impossible and inhuman. This distinction belongs instead to God alone.’

344c

*But a man cannot avoid being bad
when irresistible misfortune overthrows him.*

344c

“Now, in the case of the command of a ship, whom does irresistible misfortune overthrow?

ἐν ταύτῃ τῇ ἔξει καὶ εἶναι ἄνδρα ἀγαθόν, ὥς σὺ λέγεις, ὦ Πιττακέ, ἀδύνατον καὶ οὐκ ἀνθρώπειον, ἀλλὰ θεὸς ἂν μόνος τοῦτο ἔχοι τὸ γέρας, ἄνδρα δ' οὐκ ἔστι μὴ οὐ κακὸν ἔμμεναι, ὃν ἂν ἀμήχανος συμφορὰ καθέλῃ. τίνα οὖν ἀμήχανος συμφορὰ καθαιρεῖ ἐν πλοίου ἀρχῇ; δῆλον ὅτι οὐ τὸν ἰδιώτην· ὁ μὲν γὰρ ἰδιώτης ἀεὶ καθήρηται. ὥσπερ οὖν οὐ τὸν κείμενόν τις ἂν καταβάλοι, ἀλλὰ τὸν μὲν ἐστῶτά ποτε καταβάλοι ἂν τις ὥστε κείμενον ποιῆσαι, τὸν δὲ κείμενον

344d

Obviously not the unskilled person, for the unskilled person has been overthrown already. So, just as one cannot cast down someone who is already prostrate, but one may cast down a man who is standing and render him prostrate, although you cannot do this to the prostrate man, in like manner, someone capable of resisting may be overthrown by an irresistible misfortune, but not someone who is not capable. So the ship's captain may be rendered incapable of resistance when a huge storm befalls him; harsh weather may render a farmer incapable of resistance, and the same thing may happen to a physician. So it is

possible for the good to become bad. And another poet bears witness to this when he says,

344d

*What is more a good man is
Occasionally bad, occasionally noble.*

οὐ, οὕτω καὶ τὸν εὐμήχανον ὄντα ποτὲ ἀμήχανος ἂν συμφορὰ κατέλοι, τὸν δὲ αἰεὶ ἀμήχανον ὄντα οὐ, καὶ τὸν κυβερνήτην μέγας χειμῶν ἐπιπεσὼν ἀμήχανον ἂν ποιήσειεν, καὶ γεωργὸν χαλεπὴ ὥρα ἐπελθοῦσα ἀμήχανον ἂν θείη, καὶ ἱατρὸν ταῦτά ταῦτα. τῷ μὲν γὰρ ἐσθλῷ ἐγχωρεῖ κακῷ γενέσθαι, ὥσπερ καὶ παρ' ἄλλου ποιητοῦ μαρτυρεῖται τοῦ εἰπόντος—αὐτὰρ ἀνὴρ ἀγαθὸς τοτὲ μὲν κακός, ἄλλοτε δ' ἐσθλός·

344e

“But it is not possible for the bad to become bad, rather they must always be bad. So the capable, wise and good man cannot avoid being bad once irresistible fortune overthrows him. Yet you say, Pittacus, that it is hard to be good. But in point of fact although it is hard to become good, it is not impossible. But it is impossible to be good.

344e

*Any man who fares well is indeed good
While he who fares badly, is bad.*

τῷ δὲ κακῷ οὐκ ἐγχωρεῖ γενέσθαι, ἀλλ' αἰεὶ εἶναι ἀνάγκη. ὥστε τὸν μὲν εὐμήχανον καὶ σοφὸν καὶ ἀγαθὸν ἐπειδὴν ἀμήχανος συμφορὰ κατέλη, οὐκ ἔστι μὴ οὐ κακὸν ἔμμεναι· σὺ δὲ φῆς, ὦ Πιττακέ, χαλεπὸν ἐσθλὸν ἔμμεναι· τὸ δ' ἐστὶ γενέσθαι μὲν χαλεπὸν, δυνατόν δέ, ἐσθλόν, ἔμμεναι δὲ ἀδύνατον· πράξας μὲν γὰρ εὖ πᾶς ἀνὴρ ἀγαθός, κακὸς δ' εἰ κακῶς. ΣΩ.

345a

“Now, when it comes to writing, what is ‘good-faring’, and what faring makes a man good at writing? Surely it is learning the subject. And what ‘faring-well’ produces a good physician? Surely it is learning how to care for the sick. And faring badly in this produces a bad physician. Now, who may become a bad physician? Surely someone who happens firstly to be a physician, and then a good physician, for he may also become bad, while we who are unskilled in medicine may never, by faring badly, become either physicians or builders or anything else of this sort. And whoever is unable to become a physician by faring badly obviously cannot become a bad physician either.

τίς οὖν εἰς γράμματα ἀγαθὴ πρᾶξις ἐστίν, καὶ τίς ἄνδρα ἀγαθὸν ποιεῖ εἰς γράμματα; δῆλον ὅτι ἡ τούτων μάθησις. τίς δὲ εὐπραγία ἀγαθὸν ἰατρὸν ποιεῖ; δῆλον ὅτι ἡ τῶν καμνόντων τῆς θεραπείας μάθησις. κακὸς δὲ κακῶς· τίς οὖν ἂν κακὸς ἰατρὸς γένοιτο; δῆλον ὅτι ὃ πρῶτον μὲν ὑπάρχει ἰατρῷ εἶναι, ἔπειτα ἀγαθῷ ἰατρῷ—οὗτος γὰρ ἂν καὶ κακὸς γένοιτο—ἡμεῖς δὲ οἱ ἰατρικῆς ἰδιῶται οὐκ ἂν ποτε γενοίμεθα κακῶς πράξαντες οὔτε ἰατροὶ οὔτε τέκτονες οὔτε ἄλλο οὐδὲν τῶν τοιούτων· ὅστις δὲ μὴ ἰατρὸς ἂν γένοιτο κακῶς πράξας, δῆλον ὅτι οὐδὲ κακὸς ἰατρός. οὕτω καὶ ὁ μὲν ἀγαθὸς ἀνὴρ γένοιτ’ ἂν ποτε καὶ κακὸς ἢ ὑπὸ χρόνου ἢ ὑπὸ πόνου ἢ ὑπὸ νόσου ἢ ὑπὸ ἄλλου τινὸς περιπτώματος—αὕτη γὰρ μόνῃ ἐστὶ κακὴ πρᾶξις, ἐπιστήμης στέρηθῆναι—ὁ δὲ κακὸς ἀνὴρ οὐκ ἂν ποτε γένοιτο κακός—ἔστιν γὰρ ἀεὶ—ἀλλ’ εἰ μέλλει κακὸς γενέσθαι, δεῖ αὐτὸν πρότερον ἀγαθὸν γενέσθαι. ὥστε καὶ τοῦτο τοῦ ἔσματος πρὸς τοῦτο τείνει,

345c

Accordingly, the good man may also, at some stage, become bad, either through age or hardship or disease, or by some other calamity which deprives him of knowledge. The bad man, on the other hand, may never become bad for he is always bad, and if he is going to become bad he must first become good. So this part of the poem is making the point that it is not possible to be a good man, continually good that is, but it is possible for him to become good, and for the same man to

become bad. And those whom the gods love are indeed best for the longest time.

345c

“All this is directed against Pittacus, and this becomes even more obvious as the ode proceeds, for he says,

345c

*I shall not ever cast away my portion of eternity,
In search of that which cannot be,
On an empty, unavailing hope
Of finding an utterly blameless person,
Amongst us, as we feed upon the fruit
Of this broad earth.*

345c

If I find one I will tell you.

ὅτι εἶναι μὲν ἄνδρα ἀγαθὸν οὐχ οἷόν τε, διατελοῦντα ἀγαθόν, γενέσθαι δὲ ἀγαθὸν οἷόν τε, καὶ κακὸν γε τὸν αὐτὸν τοῦτον· ἐπὶ πλεῖστον δὲ καὶ ἄριστοί εἰσιν οὓς ἂν οἱ θεοὶ φιλῶσιν. ταῦτά τε οὖν πάντα πρὸς τὸν Πιττακὸν εἴρηται, καὶ τὰ ἐπιόντα γε τοῦ ἄσματος ἔτι μᾶλλον δηλοῖ. φησὶ γάρ—τοῦνεκεν οὐ ποτ’ ἐγὼ τὸ μὴ γενέσθαι δυνατὸν διζήμενος κενεὰν ἐς ἅ-πρακτον ἐλπίδα μοῖραν αἰῶνος βαλέω, πανάμωμον ἄνθρωπον, εὐρυεδοῦς ὅσοικαρπὸν αἰνύμεθα χθονός· ἐπὶ θ’ ὑμῖν εὐρὼν ἀπαγγελέω,

345d

“And his onslaught on the maxim of Pittacus is so intense throughout the ode as a whole that he says,

345d

*I willingly praise and love all those
Who perform no base action,
Yet even the gods do not fight against necessity.*

φησίν—οὕτω σφόδρα καὶ δι’ ὅλου τοῦ ἄσματος ἐπεξέρχεται τῷ τοῦ Πιττακοῦ ῥήματι—πάντας δ’ ἐπαίνημι καὶ φιλέω ἐκὼν ὅστις ἔρδημηδὲν αἰσχρόν· ἀνάγκη δ’ οὐδὲ θεοὶ μάχονται· καὶ τοῦτ’ ἐστὶ πρὸς τὸ αὐτὸ τοῦτο εἰρημένον. οὐ γὰρ οὕτως ἀπαίδευτος ἦν Σιμωνίδης, ὥστε τούτους φάναι ἐπαινεῖν, ὃς ἂν ἐκὼν μηδὲν κακὸν ποιῇ, ὡς ὄντων τινῶν οἱ ἐκόντες κακὰ ποιοῦσιν. ἐγὼ γὰρ σχεδὸν τι οἶμαι τοῦτο, ὅτι οὐδεὶς τῶν

345e

“This verse too is directed against the same maxim. For Simonides was not so ill-educated as to claim that Pittacus praised those who enact nothing bad willingly, as though there are some people who do perform bad actions willingly. For I could scarce imagine any wise man believing that any people make mistakes willingly, or willingly enact anything shameful or bad. Rather, they know very well that all who perform shameful or bad actions do so unwillingly. And indeed Simonides does not say that he praises those who do not perform bad actions willingly. No, he applies the word ‘willingly’ to himself. For he was of the view that the noble and good man often forces himself to praise someone and befriend someone, as often happens when a man has a problematic mother or father or native land, or something else of that sort. Now, when something of this sort happens to degenerate people, it is as if they are pleased to see the degeneracy of their parents or their native land, and to point this out disapprovingly, and criticise it, so that people may not accuse them of neglecting these issues or blame them for such neglect. So they express even stronger disapproval, and add unnecessary feuds to those that are inevitable. The good people, on the other hand, conceal the issue and force

themselves to express praise, and should they be angered at being treated unjustly by their parents or their native land, they placate themselves, reconcile themselves to the injustice, and make themselves love and praise their own people. I often wonder if Simonides believed that he himself was praising and extolling a tyrant or someone else of that sort, and doing so unwillingly and under compulsion. And so, what he says to Pittacus is, 'Pittacus, I am not criticising you because I love criticising people, since

σοφῶν ἀνδρῶν ἡγεῖται οὐδένα ἀνθρώπων ἐκόντα ἐξαμαρτάνειν οὐδὲ αἰσχροῖ τε καὶ κακὰ ἐκόντα ἐργάζεσθαι, ἀλλ' εὖ ἴσασιν ὅτι πάντες οἱ τὰ αἰσχροῖ καὶ τὰ κακὰ ποιοῦντες ἄκοντες ποιοῦσιν· καὶ δὴ καὶ ὁ Σιμωνίδης οὐχ ὅς ἂν μὴ κακὰ ποιῇ ἐκόν, τούτων φησὶν ἐπαινέτης εἶναι, ἀλλὰ περὶ ἑαυτοῦ λέγει τοῦτο τὸ ἐκόν. ΣΩ. ἡγεῖτο γὰρ ἄνδρα καλὸν κάγαθόν πολλάκις αὐτὸν ἐπαναγκάζειν φίλον τινὶ γίγνεσθαι καὶ ἐπαινέτην φιλεῖν καὶ ἐπαινεῖν, οἷον ἀνδρὶ πολλάκις συμβῆναι μητέρα ἢ πατέρα ἀλλόκοτον ἢ πατρίδα ἢ ἄλλο τι τῶν τοιούτων. τοὺς μὲν οὖν πονηροὺς, ὅταν τοιοῦτόν τι αὐτοῖς συμβῇ, ὥσπερ ἀσμένους ὁρᾶν καὶ ψέγοντας ἐπιδεικνύναι καὶ κατηγορεῖν τὴν πονηρίαν τῶν γονέων ἢ πατρίδος, ἵνα αὐτοῖς ἀμελοῦσιν αὐτῶν μὴ ἐγκαλῶσιν οἱ ἄνθρωποι μὴδ' ὀνειδίζωσιν ὅτι ἀμελοῦσιν, ὥστε ἔτι μᾶλλον ψέγειν τε αὐτοὺς καὶ ἔχθρας ἐκουσίους πρὸς ταῖς ἀναγκαίαις προστίθεσθαι τοὺς δ' ἀγαθοὺς ἐπικρύπτεσθαι τε καὶ ἐπαινεῖν ἀναγκάζεσθαι, καὶ ἂν τι ὀργισθῶσιν τοῖς γονεῦσιν ἢ πατρίδι ἀδικηθέντες, αὐτοὺς ἑαυτοὺς παραμυθεῖσθαι καὶ διαλλάττεσθαι προσαναγκάζοντας ἑαυτοὺς φιλεῖν τοὺς ἑαυτῶν καὶ ἐπαινεῖν. πολλάκις δὲ οἶμαι καὶ Σιμωνίδης ἡγήσατο καὶ αὐτὸς ἢ τύραννον ἢ ἄλλον τινὰ τῶν τοιούτων ἐπαινεῖσαι καὶ ἐγκωμιάσαι οὐχ ἐκόν, ἀλλ' ἀναγκαζόμενος. ταῦτα δὴ καὶ τῷ Πιττακῷ λέγει ὅτι ἐγώ,

346c

A man who is not bad, he suffices for me.

346c

*One who knows justice, the profit of a city
A sound man, him I shall not blame.*

346c

‘Indeed, I am no lover of blame,

346c

For the tribe of fools is without limit.

346c

‘So, if anyone delights in apportioning blame, he may have his fill through blaming the fools.

ὦ Πιπτακέ, οὐ διὰ ταῦτά σε ψέγω, ὅτι εἰμὶ φιλόσογος, ἐπεὶ—ἔμοιγ’ ἐξαρκεῖδς ἂν μὴ κακὸς ἦ μηδ’ ἄγαν ἀπάλαμνος, εἰ-δὼς τ’ ὀνησίπολιν δίκαν ὑγιῆς ἀνὴρ· οὐ μιν ἐγὼ μωμήσομαι—οὐ γάρ εἰμι φιλόμωμος—τῶν γὰρ ἡλιθίων ἀπείρων γενέθλα, πάντα τοι καλὰ, τοῖσί τ’ αἰσχρὰ μὴ μέμεικται.

346d

Yes, all is fair that is not mixed with baseness.

’ “But he is not saying this as if he were to say that all is white that is not mixed with black. That would be absurd in many ways. No, he is saying that he accepts the average people, and so he does not criticise them. And he says, ‘I am not searching for an utterly blameless person among those who feed upon the fruit of this broad earth, but if I find one I will tell you. This is in case I shall have no one to praise. No, it is enough for me if he is moderate and does nothing bad, since I love and

praise all these willingly.’ And he uses the dialect of Mytilene here, because it is to Pittacus he is saying, ‘I love and praise all these willingly’, and we should break the phrase at ‘willingly’ and then go on to say, ‘who perform no base action, but there are some whom I praise and love unwillingly.’ In your case, Pittacus, if you were saying anything even moderately reasonable and true, I would never have censured you. But now, since you are uttering falsehoods on matters of the utmost importance, while seeming to speak the truth, I rebuke you for so doing.’ So, Prodicus and Protagoras,” said I, “that in my view is what Simonides had in mind in composing this ode.”

οὐ τοῦτο λέγει, ὥσπερ ἂν εἰ ἔλεγε πάντα τοι λευκά, οἷς μέλανα μὴ μέμικται—γελοῖον γὰρ ἂν εἶη πολλαχῇ—ἀλλ’ ὅτι αὐτὸς καὶ τὰ μέσα ἀποδέχεται ὥστε μὴ ψέγειν. καὶ οὐ ζητῶ, ἔφη, πανάμωμον ἄνθρωπον, εὐρυεδοῦς ὅσοι καρπὸν αἰνύμεθα χθονός, ἐπὶ θ’ ὑμῖν εὐρὼν ἀπαγγελέω· ὥστε τούτου γ’ ἔνεκα οὐδένα ἐπαινέσομαι, ἀλλὰ μοι ἐξαρκεῖ ἂν ἥ μέσος καὶ μηδὲν κακὸν ποιῇ, ὡς ἐγὼ πάντας φιλέω καὶ ἐπαίνημι—καὶ τῇ φωνῇ ἐνταῦθα κέχρηται τῇ τῶν Μυτιληναίων, ὡς πρὸς Πιττακὸν λέγων τὸ πάντας δὲ ἐπαίνημι καὶ φιλέω ἐκὼν—ἐνταῦθα δεῖ ἐν τῷ ἐκὼν διαλαβεῖν λέγοντα—ὅστις ἔρδη μηδὲν αἰσχρόν, ἄκων δ’ ἔστιν οὐς ἐγὼ ἐπαινῶ καὶ φιλῶ. ΣΩ. σὲ οὖν, καὶ εἰ μέσως ἔλεγες ἐπεικῇ καὶ ἀληθῇ, ὃ Πιττακέ, οὐκ ἂν ποτε ἔψεγον· νῦν δὲ σφόδρα γὰρ καὶ περὶ τῶν μεγίστων ψευδόμενος δοκεῖς ἀληθῇ λέγειν, διὰ ταῦτά σε ἐγὼ ψέγω. ταῦτά μοι δοκεῖ, ὃ Πρόδικε καὶ Πρωταγόρα, ἦν δ’ ἐγώ, Σιμωνίδης διανοούμενος πεποιηκέναι τοῦτο τὸ ᾄσμα. καὶ ὁ Ἰππίας, εὖ μὲν μοι δοκεῖς, ἔφη, ὃ Σώκρατες, καὶ σὺ περὶ τοῦ ᾄσματος διεληλυθέναι· ἔστιν μέντοι, ἔφη, καὶ

347b

Then Hippias said, “I think you have indeed explained the ode quite nicely, Socrates. Yes, I too have a nice account of it, which I can present to you all if you wish.”

347b

“Yes, Hippias,” said Alcibiades, “some other time though. At the moment it is only right, based on the agreement between Protagoras

and Socrates, that if Protagoras still wants to ask questions, Socrates should answer them, and if he wants to be questioned by Socrates, then Socrates should ask questions.”

ἐμοὶ λόγος περὶ αὐτοῦ εὖ ἔχων, ὃν ὑμῖν ἐπιδείξω, ἂν βούλησθε. καὶ ὁ Ἀλκιβιάδης, ναί, ἔφη, ὦ Ἱππία, εἰς αὐθὶς γε· νῦν δὲ δίκαιόν ἐστιν ἃ ὠμολογησάτην πρὸς ἀλλήλω Πρωταγόρας καὶ Σωκράτης, Πρωταγόρας μὲν εἰ ἔτι βούλεται ἐρωτᾶν, ἀποκρίνεσθαι Σωκράτη, εἰ δὲ δὴ βούλεται Σωκράτει ἀποκρίνεσθαι, ἐρωτᾶν τὸν ἕτερον. καὶ ἐγὼ εἶπον· Ἐπιτρέπω μὲν ἔγωγε Πρωταγόρᾳ ὁπότερον αὐτῷ ἥδιον· εἰ δὲ βούλεται, περὶ μὲν ἁσμάτων τε καὶ ἐπῶν

347c

“And,” I said, “I leave it to Protagoras to choose whatever option pleases him. Yet if he does not mind, let us bid farewell to discussion of odes and poems. But I would be glad to bring the first question I asked you, Protagoras, to a conclusion by investigating it along with you. In fact, discussing poetry is, in my opinion, much like what happens at the drinking parties of ordinary, common folk. Yes, indeed, these people, due to their lack of education, are unable to keep company with one another over a drink through their own sound and their own words. So they give respectability to flute girls by paying a lot of money for the alien sound of flutes, and they keep company with one another through the sound of those instruments. But when it is a drinking party of the noble and good, and they are educated people, you would see neither flute girls nor dancing girls nor harp girls. Rather, they are sufficient company for themselves, through their own sound, as they speak and listen to themselves in turn in an orderly manner, without these trivial playthings, even if they drink a vast amount of wine. And so gatherings of this kind, when constituted of men such as most of us claim to be, have no need of alien sounds, or of poets who cannot be questioned about the topic they are speaking of. And when the majority of people quote them in discussions, some say the poet means one thing while others say he means something else, and they end up discussing matters they are unable to resolve. But the

others bid farewell to such gatherings as these, and commune among themselves, testing one another on their own arguments and being tested in turn. I think you and I should rather imitate people of this sort, and setting the poets aside, direct our discussion towards one another on our own terms, putting the truth and ourselves to the test.

ἔάσωμεν, περὶ δὲ ὧν τὸ πρῶτον ἐγὼ σε ἠρώτησα, ὦ Πρωταγόρα, ἡδέως ἂν ἐπὶ τέλος ἔλθοιμι μετὰ σοῦ σκοπούμενος. καὶ γὰρ δοκεῖ μοι τὸ περὶ ποιήσεως διαλέγεσθαι ὁμοιότατον εἶναι τοῖς συμποσίοις τοῖς τῶν φαύλων καὶ ἀγοραίων ἀνθρώπων. καὶ γὰρ οὗτοι, διὰ τὸ μὴ δύνασθαι ἀλλήλοις δι' ἑαυτῶν συνεῖναι ἐν τῷ πότῳ μηδὲ διὰ τῆς ἑαυτῶν φωνῆς καὶ τῶν λόγων τῶν ἑαυτῶν ὑπὸ ἀπαιδευσίας, τιμίας ποιοῦσι τὰς αὐλητρίδας, πολλοῦ μισθούμενοι ἀλλοτρίαν φωνὴν τὴν τῶν αὐλῶν, καὶ διὰ τῆς ἐκείνων φωνῆς ἀλλήλοις σύνεισιν· ὅπου δὲ καλοὶ κἀγαθοὶ συμπόται καὶ πεπαιδευμένοι εἰσίν, οὐκ ἂν ἴδοις οὔτ' αὐλητρίδας οὔτε ὀρχηστρίδας οὔτε ψαλτρίδας, ἀλλὰ αὐτοὺς αὐτοῖς ἱκανοὺς ὄντας συνεῖναι ἄνευ τῶν λήρων τε καὶ παιδιῶν τούτων διὰ τῆς αὐτῶν φωνῆς, λέγοντάς τε καὶ ἀκούοντας ἐν μέρει ἑαυτῶν κοσμίως, κἂν πάνυ πολὺν οἶνον πίωσιν. οὕτω δὲ καὶ αἱ τοιαῖδε συνουσίαι, ἐὰν μὲν λάβωνται ἀνδρῶν οἵοιπερ ἡμῶν οἱ πολλοὶ φασιν εἶναι, οὐδὲν δέονται ἀλλοτρίας φωνῆς οὐδὲ ποιητῶν, οὓς οὔτε ἀνερέεσθαι οἶόν τ' ἐστὶν περὶ ὧν λέγουσιν, ἐπαγόμενοί τε αὐτοὺς οἱ πολλοὶ ἐν τοῖς λόγοις οἱ μὲν ταῦτά φασιν τὸν ποιητὴν νοεῖν, οἱ δ' ἕτερα, περὶ πράγματος διαλεγόμενοι ὃ ἀδυνατοῦσι ἐξελέγξαι· ΣΩ. ἀλλὰ τὰς μὲν τοιαύτας συνουσίας ἐῷσιν χαίρειν, αὐτοὶ δ' ἑαυτοῖς σύνεισιν δι' ἑαυτῶν, ἐν τοῖς ἑαυτῶν λόγοις πεῖραν ἀλλήλων λαμβάνοντες καὶ διδόντες. τοὺς τοιοῦτους μοι δοκεῖ χρῆναι μᾶλλον μιμεῖσθαι ἐμέ τε καὶ σέ, καταθεμένους τοὺς ποιητὰς αὐτοὺς δι' ἡμῶν αὐτῶν πρὸς ἀλλήλους τοὺς λόγους ποιεῖσθαι, τῆς ἀληθείας καὶ ἡμῶν αὐτῶν πεῖραν λαμβάνοντας· κἂν μὲν βούλῃ ἔτι ἐρωτᾶν, ἔτοιμός εἰμί σοι παρέχειν ἀποκρινόμενος· ἐὰν δὲ βούλῃ, σὺ ἐμοὶ παράσχες, περὶ ὧν μεταξὺ ἐπαυσάμεθα διεξιόντες, τούτοις τέλος ἐπιθεῖναι.

“Now, if you still want to ask questions, I am ready to act as your respondent. Or, if you would prefer to conclude the topic whose development we interrupted in midstream, then you should respond to me.” As I was making this point and others like it, Protagoras did not clarify which alternative he would take. So Alcibiades looked at Callias and said, “Callias, do you think, even now, that Protagoras is acting appropriately by being unwilling to clarify whether he will act as respondent or not? I certainly do not think so. For he should either engage in discourse or declare that he does not wish to do so, so that we may all know where we stand here and Socrates may engage in discourse with someone else, or anyone may converse with anyone they want to.”

λέγοντος οὖν ἐμοῦ ταῦτα καὶ τοιαῦτα ἄλλα οὐδὲν ἀπεσάφει ὁ Πρωταγόρας ὁπότερα ποιήσοι. εἶπεν οὖν ὁ Ἀλκιβιάδης πρὸς τὸν Καλλίαν βλέψας, ὦ Καλλία, δοκεῖ σοι, ἔφη, καὶ νῦν καλῶς Πρωταγόρας ποιεῖν, οὐκ ἐθέλων εἶτε δώσει λόγον εἶτε μὴ διασαφεῖν; ἐμοὶ γὰρ οὐ δοκεῖ· ἀλλ’ ἤτοι διαλεγέσθω ἢ εἰπέτω ὅτι οὐκ ἐθέλει διαλέγεσθαι, ἵνα τούτῳ μὲν ταῦτα συνειδῶμεν, Σωκράτης δὲ ἄλλῳ τῷ διαλέγεται ἢ ἄλλος ὅστις ἂν βούληται ἄλλῳ.

348c

I thought Protagoras was shamed by the words of Alcibiades. And at the request of Callias, and almost everyone else who was present, he was persuaded very reluctantly to engage in discourse, and he directed me to ask questions so that he could respond.

348c

So I said, “Protagoras, do not presume that I am conversing with you from any other motive than to investigate those issues that constantly perplex me. For I believe that a line from Homer says it all:

καὶ ὁ Πρωταγόρας αἰσχυνθείς, ὥς γέ μοι ἔδοξεν, τοῦ τε Ἀλκιβιάδου ταῦτα λέγοντος καὶ τοῦ Καλλίου δεομένου καὶ τῶν ἄλλων σχεδόν τι τῶν παρόντων, μόγις προουτράπετο εἰς τὸ διαλέγεσθαι καὶ ἐκέλευεν ἑρωτᾶν αὐτὸν ὥς ἀποκρινόμενος. εἶπον δὴ ἐγώ· ὦ Πρωταγόρα, μὴ

οἷου διαλέγεσθαι μέ σοι ἄλλο τι βουλόμενον ἢ ἃ αὐτὸς ἀπορῶ
ἐκάστοτε, ταῦτα διασκέψασθαι. ἡγοῦμαι γὰρ πάνυ λέγειν τι τὸν
Ὅμηρον τὸ—

348d

*When two go together, one observes before the other.*²⁵

“For in this way we shall all be more resourceful people in every action, word and thought. But if someone has an insight on his own, he immediately goes about searching until he meets someone to whom he can present it, and with whom he can confirm it. So for this very reason I would gladly converse with you, more so than anyone else, because I believe that you will best enquire into the

σύν τε δὴ ἐρχομένω, καὶ τε πρὸ δὲ τοῦ ἐνόησεν. εὐπορώτεροι γὰρ πως
ἅπαντές ἐσμεν οἱ ἄνθρωποι πρὸς ἅπαν ἔργον καὶ λόγον καὶ διανόημα·
μοῦνος δ’ εἴπερ τε νοήσῃ, αὐτίκα περιῶν ζητεῖ ὅτῳ ἐπιδείξῃται καὶ μεθ’
οὔτου βεβαιώσῃται, ἕως ἂν ἐντύχῃ. ὥσπερ καὶ ἐγὼ ἔνεκα τούτου σοὶ
ἡδέως διαλέγομαι μᾶλλον ἢ ἄλλῳ τινί, ἡγούμενός σε βέλτιστ’ ἂν
ἐπισκέψασθαι καὶ περὶ τῶν ἄλλων

348e

wide range of issues that a reasonable person is likely to consider, and especially into excellence.

περὶ ὧν εἰκὸς σκοπεῖσθαι τὸν ἐπιεικῆ, καὶ δὴ καὶ περὶ ἀρετῆς. τίνα γὰρ
ἄλλον ἢ σέ; ὅς γε οὐ μόνον αὐτὸς οἶει καλὸς καγαθὸς εἶναι, ὥσπερ τινὲς
ἄλλοι αὐτοὶ μὲν ἐπιεικεῖς εἰσιν, ἄλλους δὲ οὐ δύνανται ποιεῖν. ΣΩ. σὺ δὲ
καὶ αὐτὸς ἀγαθὸς εἶ καὶ ἄλλους οἷός τ’ εἶ ποιεῖν ἀγαθοῦς, καὶ οὕτω
πεπίστευκας σαυτῷ, ὥστε καὶ ἄλλων ταύτην τὴν τέχνην
ἀποκρυπτομένον

349a

Indeed, who else could I choose but you? You not only believe yourself to be noble and good, just like others who are reasonable but unable to

make other people reasonable, but you, by contrast, are good, and are also able to make others good. What is more, you have such belief in yourself that while others conceal this skill, you have proclaimed yourself openly throughout the entire Greek world, giving yourself the title of a sophist, a self-declared teacher of culture and excellence, the first person who thought it right to demand payment for this. So, what could I do but call you into this enquiry, question you and consult with you? There is no other option. And now I want to go back to the beginning, to the issues I was asking you about at the outset, and have you remind me of some, and conduct a joint and thorough investigation of others. The question I believe was as follows. Are wisdom, sound-mindedness, courage, justice and holiness five names for a single thing, or, underlying each of these names, is there a distinct essence, each with its own capacity, each being unlike the other? Now, you said that they are not names of a single thing, but that each of these five names applies to a distinct thing, and these are all parts of excellence, not in the way that the parts of gold are similar to one another, and to the whole of which they are parts, but in the way that the parts of the face, each possessing a distinct capacity, are dissimilar to the whole of which they are parts, and to one another. Now, if you still think what you thought earlier, say so. If you somehow think otherwise, state this clearly, as I, for my part, will not hold you to that should you now say something different. Indeed, I would not be surprised if you were testing me out earlier when you said what you said.”

σύ γ' ἀναφανδὸν σεαυτὸν ὑποκηρυζάμενος εἰς πάντας τοὺς Ἕλληνας, σοφιστὴν ἐπονομάσας σεαυτόν, ἀπέφηνας παιδεύσεως καὶ ἀρετῆς διδάσκαλον, πρῶτος τούτου μισθὸν ἀξιώσας ἄρτυσθαι. πῶς οὖν οὐ σέ χρῆν παρακαλεῖν ἐπὶ τὴν τούτων σκέψιν καὶ ἐρωτᾶν καὶ ἀνακοινοῦσθαι; οὐκ ἔσθ' ὅπως οὐ. καὶ νῦν δὴ ἐγὼ ἐκεῖνα, ἅπερ τὸ πρῶτον ἡρώτων περὶ τούτων, πάλιν ἐπιθυμῶ ἐξ ἀρχῆς τὰ μὲν ἀναμνησθῆναι παρὰ σοῦ, τὰ δὲ συνδιασκέψασθαι. ἦν δέ, ὡς ἐγῴμαι, τὸ ἐρώτημα τόδε· σοφία καὶ σωφροσύνη καὶ ἀνδρεία καὶ δικαιοσύνη καὶ

οσιότης, πότερον ταῦτα, πέντε ὄντα ὀνόματα, ἐπὶ ἐνὶ πράγματι ἐστίν, ἢ ἐκάστω τῶν ὀνομάτων τούτων ὑπόκειται τις ἴδιος οὐσία καὶ πρᾶγμα ἔχον ἑαυτοῦ δύναμιν ἕκαστον, οὐκ ὃν οἷον τὸ ἕτερον αὐτῶν τὸ ἕτερον; ἔφησθα οὖν σὺ οὐκ ὀνόματα ἐπὶ ἐνὶ εἶναι, ἀλλὰ ἕκαστον ἰδίῳ πράγματι τῶν ὀνομάτων τούτων ἐπικεῖσθαι, πάντα δὲ ταῦτα μόρια εἶναι ἀρετῆς, οὐχ ὡς τὰ τοῦ χρυσοῦ μόρια ὁμοιά ἐστιν ἀλλήλοις καὶ τῷ ὄλῳ οὗ μόριά ἐστιν, ἀλλ' ὡς τὰ τοῦ προσώπου μόρια καὶ τῷ ὄλῳ οὗ μόριά ἐστιν καὶ ἀλλήλοις ἀνόμοια, ἰδίαν ἕκαστα δύναμιν ἔχοντα. ταῦτα εἰ μὲν σοι δοκεῖ ἔτι ὥσπερ τότε, φάθι· εἰ δὲ ἄλλως πως, τοῦτο διόρισαι, ὡς ἔγωγε οὐδέν σοι ὑπόλογον τίθεμαι, ἐάν πῃ ἄλλη νῦν φήσης· οὐ γὰρ ἂν θαυμάζοιμι εἰ τότε ἀποπειρώμενός

349d

“Well, Socrates,” said he, “I am telling you that although all these are parts of excellence, and four of them are fairly similar to one another, courage for its part is entirely different from all the others. You may recognise the truth of what I am saying as follows, for you will find many people who are extremely unjust, unholy, unrestrained and unlearned, yet most outstandingly courageous.”

μου ταῦτα ἔλεγες, ἀλλ' ἐγὼ σοι, ἔφη, λέγω, ὃ Σώκρατες, ὅτι ταῦτα πάντα μόρια μὲν ἐστίν ἀρετῆς, καὶ τὰ μὲν τέτταρα αὐτῶν ἐπιεικῶς παραπλήσια ἀλλήλοις ἐστίν, ἡ δὲ ἀνδρεία πάνυ πολὺ διαφέρειν πάντων τούτων. ὥδε δὲ γνώσῃ ὅτι ἐγὼ ἀληθῆ λέγω· εὐρήσεις γὰρ πολλοὺς τῶν ἀνθρώπων ἀδικωτάτους μὲν ὄντας καὶ ἀνοσιωτάτους καὶ ἀκολαστοτάτους καὶ ἀμαθεστάτους, ἀνδρειοτάτους δὲ διαφερόντως.

349e

“Hold it there,” said I, “for it is worth investigating what you are saying. Do you assert that courageous people are daring, or something else?”

349e

“Yes, and impulsive enough to go where most people are afraid to go,” he said.

349e

“Come now, would you say that excellence is something noble? And do you offer yourself as a teacher of this on the basis that it is noble?”

349e

“Yes, it is utterly noble, unless I am a madman anyway,” he replied.

349e

“So,” I asked, “does it involve a base aspect and a noble aspect, or is it wholly noble?”

349e

“Surely it is wholly noble, to the greatest extent possible.”

ἔχε δὴ, ἔφην ἐγώ· ἄξιον γάρ τοι ἐπισκέψασθαι ὃ λέγεις, πότερον τοὺς ἀνδρείους θαρραλέους λέγεις ἢ ἄλλο τι;—καὶ ἵτας γε, ἔφη, ἐφ’ ἃ οἱ πολλοὶ φοβοῦνται ἰέναι.—φέρει δὴ, τὴν ἀρετὴν καλὸν τι φῆς εἶναι, καὶ ὡς καλοῦ ὄντος αὐτοῦ σὺ διδάσκαλον σαυτὸν παρέχεις;—κάλλιστον μὲν οὖν, ἔφη, εἰ μὴ μαίνομαι γε.—πότερον οὖν, ἣν δ’ ἐγώ, τὸ μὲν τι αὐτοῦ αἰσχρόν, τὸ δέ τι καλόν, ἢ ὅλον καλόν;—ὅλον που καλὸν ὡς οἶόν τε μάλιστα.— ΣΩ. οἶσθα οὖν τίνες εἰς τὰ

350a

“Now, do you know what people dive daringly into wells?”

350a

“I do. I know that they are the divers.”

350a

“Is it because they have knowledge, or for some other reason?”

350a

“Because they have knowledge.”

350a

“And who are daring when it comes to fighting on horseback? Is it the horsemen or the nonhorsemen?”

350a

“The horsemen.”

350a

“And when it comes to light infantry, is it the light infantrymen or the others?”

φρέατα κολυμβῶσιν θαρραλέως;—ἔγωγε, ὅτι οἱ κολυμβηταί.—πότερον διότι ἐπίστανται ἢ δι' ἄλλο τι;—ὅτι ἐπίστανται.—τίνες δὲ ἀπὸ τῶν ἵππων πολεμεῖν θαρραλέοι εἰσίν; πότερον οἱ ἱππικοὶ ἢ οἱ ἄφιπποι;—οἱ ἱππικοί.—τίνες δὲ πέλτας ἔχοντες; οἱ πελταστικοὶ ἢ οἱ μή;—οἱ πελταστικοί. καὶ τὰ ἄλλα γε πάντα, εἰ τοῦτο ζητεῖς, ἔφη, οἱ ἐπιστήμονες τῶν μὴ ἐπισταμένων θαρραλεώτεροι εἰσιν, καὶ αὐτοὶ ἐαυτῶν

350b

“It is the light infantrymen,” he replied. “And if this is the answer you are looking for, in all other cases those with knowledge are more daring than those without knowledge, and they themselves are more daring after they have learned than they were before.”

350b

“But have you, on occasion, seen people who lack knowledge of all these who are daring in respect of each of them?”

350b

“I have indeed,” he replied, “excessively daring too.”

350b

“So, are these daring fellows also courageous?”

350b

“In that case,” said he, “courage would be base, since these people are mad.”

350b

“Well,” I asked, “what did you mean by ‘the courageous men’? Wasn’t it the daring men?”

350b

“Yes, and I still say so now,” he replied.

ἐπειδὴν μάθωσιν ἢ πρὶν μαθεῖν.—ἦδη δέ τινας ἐώρακας, ἔφην, πάντων τούτων ἀνεπιστήμονας ὄντας, θαρροῦντας δὲ πρὸς ἕκαστα τούτων;—ἔγωγε, ἦ δ' ὅς, καὶ λίαν γε θαρροῦντας.—οὐκοῦν οἱ θαρραλέοι οὗτοι καὶ ἀνδρεῖοι εἰσιν;—αἰσχρὸν μεντᾶν, ἔφη, εἴη ἡ ἀνδρεία· ἐπεὶ οὗτοί γε μαινόμενοί εἰσιν.—πῶς οὖν, ἔφην ἐγώ, λέγεις τοὺς ἀνδρείους; οὐχὶ τοὺς θαρραλέους εἶναι;—καὶ νῦν γ', ἔφη.—

350c

“In that case,” said I, “don’t these people, who are daring in this way, turn out to be insane rather than courageous? And in the other case, aren’t the wisest men also the most courageous since they are the most daring? And based upon this argument, would wisdom be courage?”

οὐκοῦν οὗτοι, ἦν δ’ ἐγώ, οἱ οὕτω θαρραλέοι ὄντες οὐκ ἀνδρεῖοι ἀλλὰ μαινόμενοι φαίνονται; καὶ ἐκεῖ αὖ οἱ σοφώτατοι οὗτοι καὶ θαρραλεώτατοί εἰσιν, θαρραλεώτατοι δὲ ὄντες ἀνδρειότατοι; καὶ κατὰ τοῦτον τὸν λόγον ἡ σοφία ἂν ἀνδρεία εἴη; οὐ καλῶς, ἔφη, μνημονεύεις, ὦ Σώκρατες, ἃ ἔλεγόν τε καὶ ἀπεκρινόμην σοι. ἔγωγε ἐρωτηθεὶς ὑπὸ σοῦ εἰ οἱ ἀνδρεῖοι θαρραλέοι εἰσίν, ὡμολόγησα· εἰ δὲ καὶ οἱ θαρραλέοι ἀνδρεῖοι, οὐκ ἠρωτήθην—εἰ γάρ με τότε ἤρου, εἶπον ἂν ὅτι

350d

“Socrates,” he replied, “you are not remembering properly what I said, or the answer I gave you. When you asked me if the courageous are daring, I agreed. However, I was not also asked if the daring are courageous, for had I been asked that I would have said that they are not all courageous. But in no way have you proved that I was wrong in agreeing to what I did agree, that the courageous are daring. After that, you demonstrate that those who are knowledgeable are themselves more daring than they themselves were before, and more daring than others who are not knowledgeable, and on this basis you presume that courage and wisdom are the same. But proceeding in this manner, you might also presume that strength is wisdom. Yes, proceeding like this, you might first ask me if strong people are capable, and I would agree; next, whether those who know how to wrestle are more capable than those who do not know how to wrestle, and are more capable after they have learned than they themselves were before, and I would agree. Once I had agreed to these, you would be able, using those very same conclusions, to state that according to what I have agreed, wisdom is strength. But I do not agree at all, and I am not agreeing here, that the capable people are strong, even though I agree that the strong people are capable. For capability and strength

are not the same. One, capability, arises from knowledge or from madness or from desire, while the other, strength, comes from the nature and proper nurture of our bodies. Similarly, in the other case, daring and courage are not the same, so it turns out that those who are courageous are daring, even though the daring are not all courageous. For daring arises in people from skill, from desire and from madness, just like capability, while courage arises from the nature and proper nurture of our souls.”

οὐ πάντες—τούς δὲ ἀνδρείους ὡς οὐ θαρραλέοι εἰσίν, τὸ ἐμὸν ὁμολόγημα οὐδαμοῦ ἐπέδειξας ὡς οὐκ ὀρθῶς ὡμολόγησα. ἔπειτα τοὺς ἐπισταμένους αὐτοὺς ἑαυτῶν θαρραλεωτέρους ὄντας ἀποφαίνεις καὶ μὴ ἐπισταμένων ἄλλων, καὶ ἐν τούτῳ οἶει τὴν ἀνδρείαν καὶ τὴν σοφίαν ταῦτόν εἶναι· τούτῳ δὲ τῷ τρόπῳ μετιῶν καὶ τὴν ἰσχὺν οἰηθείης ἂν εἶναι σοφίαν. πρῶτον μὲν γὰρ εἰ οὕτω μετιῶν ἕροίό με εἰ οἱ ἰσχυροὶ δυνατοὶ εἰσιν, φαίην ἂν· ἔπειτα, εἰ οἱ ἐπιστάμενοι παλαίειν δυνατώτεροί εἰσιν τῶν μὴ ἐπισταμένων παλαίειν καὶ αὐτοὶ αὐτῶν ἐπειδὴν μάθωσιν ἢ πρὶν μαθεῖν, φαίην ἂν· ταῦτα δὲ ἐμοῦ ὁμολογήσαντος ἐξείη ἂν σοι, χρωμένῳ τοῖς αὐτοῖς τεκμηρίοις τούτοις, λέγειν ὡς κατὰ τὴν ἐμὴν ὁμολογίαν ἡ σοφία ἐστὶν ἰσχὺς. ΣΩ. ἐγὼ δὲ οὐδαμοῦ οὐδ’ ἐνταῦθα ὁμολογῶ τοὺς δυνατοὺς ἰσχυροὺς εἶναι, τοὺς μέντοι ἰσχυροὺς δυνατούς· οὐ γὰρ ταῦτόν εἶναι δύνάμιν τε καὶ ἰσχύν, ἀλλὰ τὸ μὲν καὶ ἀπὸ ἐπιστήμης γίγνεσθαι, τὴν δύναμιν, καὶ ἀπὸ μανίας γε καὶ θυμοῦ, ἰσχὺν δὲ ἀπὸ φύσεως καὶ εὐτροφίας τῶν σωμάτων. οὕτω δὲ κακῆ οὐ ταῦτόν εἶναι θάρσος τε καὶ ἀνδρείαν· ὥστε συμβαίνει τοὺς μὲν ἀνδρείους θαρραλέους εἶναι, μὴ μέντοι τοὺς γε θαρραλέους ἀνδρείους πάντας· θάρσος μὲν γὰρ καὶ ἀπὸ τέχνης γίγνεται ἀνθρώποις καὶ

351b

“Protagoras,” I said, “do you agree that some people live their lives well, others badly?”

351b

He agreed.

351b

“And do you think any person would live his life well if he were to live in distress and suffering?”

351b

“No,” he said.

351b

“What if he were to live his life pleasantly to the very end? Don’t you think he would have lived his life well in so doing?”

351b

“I do,” he replied.

ἀπὸ θυμοῦ γε καὶ ἀπὸ μανίας, ὥσπερ ἡ δύναμις, ἀνδρεία δὲ ἀπὸ φύσεως καὶ εὐτροφίας τῶν ψυχῶν γίγνεται. λέγεις δέ τινας, ἔφη, ὦ Πρωταγόρα, τῶν ἀνθρώπων εὖ ζῆν, τοὺς δὲ κακῶς;—ἔφη.—ἄρ’ οὖν δοκεῖ σοι ἄνθρωπος ἂν εὖ ζῆν, εἰ ἀνιώμενός τε καὶ ὀδυνώμενος ζῶν;—οὐκ ἔφη.—τί δ’ εἰ ἡδέως βίους τὸν βίον τελευτήσκειν; οὐκ εὖ ἂν σοι δοκεῖ οὕτως βεβιωκέναι;—ἔμοιγ’, ἔφη.—τὸ μὲν ἄρα

351c

“So to live pleasantly is good, while to live unpleasantly is bad.”

351c

“Yes,” he said, “provided, at any rate, one lives one’s life being pleased by what is noble.”

351c

“What about this, Protagoras? Surely you don’t, like most people, refer to some pleasures as bad and some suffering as good? I mean, on the basis that they are pleasant, aren’t they also good on this basis, unless some other consequence emerges from them? And doesn’t the same argument also apply to sufferings? Aren’t they bad insofar as they involve suffering?”

ἡδέως ζῆν ἀγαθόν, τὸ δ’ ἀηδῶς κακόν.—εἴπερ τοῖς καλοῖς γ’, ἔφη, ζῶν ἡδόμενος.—τί δὴ, ὦ Πρωταγόρα; μὴ καὶ σύ, ὥσπερ οἱ πολλοί, ἡδέ’ ἅττα καλεῖς κακὰ καὶ ἀνιαρὰ ἀγαθὰ; ἐγὼ γὰρ λέγω, καθ’ ὃ ἡδέα ἐστίν, ἄρα κατὰ τοῦτο οὐκ ἀγαθὰ, μὴ εἴ τι ἀπ’ αὐτῶν ἀποβήσεται ἄλλο; καὶ αὖθις αὖ

τὰ ἀνιαρὰ ὡσαύτως οὕτως οὐ καθ' ὅσον ἀνιαρά, κακά;—οὐκ οἶδα, ὦ Σώκρατες, ἔφη, ἀπλῶς οὕτως, ὡς σὺ ἐρωτᾷς,

351d

“Socrates,” he replied, “I do not know if I should answer your question in the unqualified manner that you have framed it, that the pleasures are all good and the sufferings bad. I think, rather, that the safer answer, not only in relation to the present question but in relation to my life in general, is that there are some pleasures that are not good, and in the case of sufferings, some are not bad and some are, and there is a third class that is neither good nor bad.”

εἰ ἐμοὶ ἀποκριτέον ἐστὶν ὡς τὰ ἡδέα τε ἀγαθὰ ἐστὶν ἅπαντα καὶ τὰ ἀνιαρὰ κακά· ἀλλὰ μοι δοκεῖ οὐ μόνον πρὸς τὴν νῦν ἀπόκρισιν ἐμοὶ ἀσφαλέστερον εἶναι ἀποκρίνασθαι, ἀλλὰ καὶ πρὸς πάντα τὸν ἄλλον βίον τὸν ἐμόν, ὅτι ἔστι μὲν ἃ τῶν ἡδέων οὐκ ἔστιν ἀγαθὰ, ἔστι δ' αὖ καὶ ἃ τῶν ἀνιαρῶν οὐκ ἔστι κακά, ἔστι δ' ἃ ἔστι, καὶ τρίτον ἃ οὐδέτερα, οὔτε κακὰ οὔτ' ἀγαθὰ.—ἡδέα δὲ καλεῖς, ἦν δ' ἐγώ, οὐ τὰ ἡδονῆς

351e

“But,” I asked, “don’t you refer to whatever partakes of pleasure or produces pleasure as pleasant?”

351e

“Certainly,” he replied.

351e

“Well, that is what I mean. They are good insofar as they are pleasant. I am asking if pleasure itself is good.”

351e

“As you are always saying, Socrates, let us investigate this, and if the argument seems reasonable, and pleasant and good prove to be the same, we shall be in agreement. If not, we shall argue over it at that stage.”

351e

“So would you like to take control of the investigation, or should I lead it?”

351e

“It is only right that you lead it,” he said, “since you are actually initiating the discussion.”

μετέχοντα ἢ ποιοῦντα ἡδονήν;—πάνυ γ’, ἔφη.—τοῦτο τοίνυν λέγω, καθ’ ὅσον ἡδέα ἐστίν, εἰ οὐκ ἀγαθά, τὴν ἡδονὴν αὐτὴν ἐρωτῶν εἰ οὐκ ἀγαθόν ἐστιν.—ὥσπερ σὺ λέγεις, ἔφη, ἐκάστοτε, ὦ Σώκρατες, σκοπώμεθα αὐτό, καὶ ἐὰν μὲν πρὸς λόγον δοκῇ εἶναι τὸ σκέμμα καὶ τὸ αὐτὸ φαίνεται ἡδύ τε καὶ ἀγαθόν, συγχωρησόμεθα· εἰ δὲ μή, τότε ἤδη ἀμφισβητήσομεν. πότερον οὖν, ἦν δ’ ἐγώ, σὺ βούλει ἡγεμονεύειν τῆς σκέψεως, ἢ ἐγὼ ἡγῶμαι; δίκαιος, ἔφη, σὺ ἡγεῖσθαι· σὺ γὰρ καὶ κατάρχεις τοῦ λόγου.

352a

“Well, then,” said I, “would the following approach clarify the matter for us? It is as if someone, considering a person’s health, or some other of the body’s functions, on the basis of his appearance, were to look at his face and arms and say, ‘Come on now, uncover your chest and back and show them to me, so that I may examine you more thoroughly’. I too have a similar urge in relation to this enquiry. Having seen where you stand in relation to the good and the pleasant, as you state it, I want to say something like this: ‘Come on now, Protagoras, also uncover this aspect of your thought to me. Where do you stand in relation to knowledge?’

ΣΩ. ἄρ’ οὖν, ἦν δ’ ἐγώ, τῇδέ πη καταφανὲς ἂν ἡμῖν γένοιτο; ὥσπερ εἴ τις ἄνθρωπον σκοπῶν ἐκ τοῦ εἶδους ἢ πρὸς ὑγίειαν ἢ πρὸς ἄλλο τι τῶν τοῦ σώματος ἔργων, ἰδὼν τὸ πρόσωπον καὶ τὰς χεῖρας ἄκρας εἴποι· ἴθι δὴ μοι ἀποκαλύψας καὶ τὰ στήθη καὶ τὸ μετάφρενον ἐπίδειξον, ἵνα ἐπισκέψωμαι σαφέστερον, καὶ ἐγὼ τοιοῦτόν τι ποθῶ πρὸς τὴν σκέψιν· θεασάμενος ὅτι οὕτως ἔχεις πρὸς τὸ ἀγαθὸν καὶ τὸ ἡδύ ὡς φῆς, δέομαι τοιοῦτόν τι εἰπεῖν· ἴθι δὴ μοι, ὦ Πρωταγόρα, καὶ τόδε τῆς διανοίας ἀποκάλυψον· πῶς ἔχεις πρὸς ἐπιστήμην; πότερον καὶ τοῦτό σοι δοκεῖ ὥσπερ τοῖς πολλοῖς ἀνθρώποις, ἢ ἄλλως; δοκεῖ δὲ τοῖς πολλοῖς περὶ ἐπιστήμης τοιοῦτόν τι, οὐκ ἰσχυρὸν οὐδ’ ἡγεμονικὸν οὐδ’ ἀρχικὸν εἶναι· οὐδὲ ὡς περὶ τοιούτου αὐτοῦ ὄντος διανοοῦνται, ἀλλ’ ἐνούσης

πολλάκις ἀνθρώπῳ ἐπιστήμης οὐ τὴν ἐπιστήμην αὐτοῦ ἄρχειν ἀλλ’ ἄλλο τι, τοτὲ μὲν θυμόν, τοτὲ δὲ ἡδονήν, τοτὲ δὲ λύπην, ἐνίοτε δὲ ἔρωτα, πολλάκις δὲ φόβον, ἀτεχνῶς

352c

“Do you think it is what most people think it is, or do you think otherwise? Most people think knowledge is not really strong or authoritative or fit to rule. They do not think it is like this at all. They think, rather, that very often when a person is endowed with knowledge, it is not the knowledge but something else that rules him, desire at one moment, then pleasure, then pain, sometimes passion, very often fear. They think of knowledge almost as if it were a battle-captured slave who is dragged about by all these other factors. Well now, is this also what you think about knowledge? Or do you think it is something noble that is able to rule a person, and that once a person recognises what is good and what is bad he would never be dominated by anything else and do anything else except what knowledge directs him to do? And is understanding enough to save a person?”

διανοούμενοι περὶ τῆς ἐπιστήμης ὥσπερ περὶ ἀνδραπόδου, περιελκομένης ὑπὸ τῶν ἄλλων ἀπάντων. ἄρ’ οὖν καὶ σοὶ τοιοῦτόν τι περὶ αὐτῆς δοκεῖ, ἢ καλόν τε εἶναι ἢ ἐπιστήμη καὶ οἷον ἄρχειν τοῦ ἀνθρώπου, καὶ ἐάνπερ γινώσκη τις τάγαθὰ καὶ τὰ κακὰ, μὴ ἂν κρατηθῆναι ὑπὸ μηδενὸς ὥστε ἄλλ’ ἅττα πράττειν ἢ ἂν ἐπιστήμη κελεύῃ, ἀλλ’ ἱκανὴν εἶναι τὴν φρόνησιν βοηθεῖν τῷ ἀνθρώπῳ; καὶ δοκεῖ, ἔφη, ὥσπερ σὺ λέγεις, ὦ Σώκρατες, καὶ ἅμα,

352d

“Socrates,” he replied, “I agree fully with what you are saying. And what is more, it would be disgraceful for me in particular to deny that wisdom and knowledge are the most exalted of all things human.”

εἵπερ τῷ ἄλλῳ, αἰσχρόν ἐστι καὶ ἐμοὶ σοφίαν καὶ ἐπιστήμην μὴ οὐχὶ πάντων κράτιστον φάναι εἶναι τῶν ἀνθρωπείων πραγμάτων. καλῶς γε, ἔφη, ἐγώ, σὺ λέγων καὶ ἀληθῆ. οἶσθα οὖν ὅτι οἱ πολλοὶ τῶν ἀνθρώπων ἐμοί τε καὶ σοὶ οὐ πείθονται, ἀλλὰ πολλοὺς φασὶ γινώσκοντας τὰ

βέλτιστα οὐκ ἐθέλειν πράττειν, ἐξὸν αὐτοῖς, ἀλλὰ ἄλλα πράττειν· καὶ ὅσους δὴ ἐγὼ ἠρόμην ὅτι ποτε αἰτιὸν ἐστι τούτου, ὑπὸ ἡδονῆς φασιν

352e

“You have expressed that beautifully, and it is true,” I said. “Now, you know that most people are not persuaded by our views, and they maintain that many people who realise what is best do not wish to enact it, even when they can, and that they do something else instead. And when I ask them what exactly causes this behaviour, they say that those who do this, do so because they yield to pleasure and pain, or are overpowered by one of those factors I mentioned just now.”

352e

“Indeed, Socrates,” he replied, “in my view people also say a great deal else that is incorrect.”

ἡττωμένους ἢ λύπης ἢ ὧν νυνδὴ ἐγὼ ἔλεγον ὑπὸ τινος τούτων κρατουμένους ταῦτα ποιεῖν τοὺς ποιοῦντας. πολλὰ γὰρ οἶμαι, ἔφη, ὦ Σώκρατες, καὶ ἄλλα οὐκ ὀρθῶς λέγουσιν οἱ ἄνθρωποι. ΣΩ. ἴθι δὴ μετ’ ἐμοῦ ἐπιχείρησον πείθειν τοὺς ἀνθρώπους καὶ διδάσκειν ὃ ἐστιν αὐτοῖς τοῦτο τὸ πάθος, ὃ φασιν ὑπὸ

353a

“Come on then, join me, and let us try to persuade the people and teach them what this experience of theirs is, the one they describe as yielding to pleasures, and for that reason not doing what is best, even when they realise what is best. Perhaps if we were to tell them that what they are saying is incorrect and that they are speaking falsely, they would ask us, ‘Protagoras and Socrates, if this experience does not involve yielding to pleasure, then what exactly is it? What is it according to you? Tell us’.”

353a

“But, Socrates, why should we consider the opinion that the majority of people hold? They only say whatever happens to occur to them.”

τῶν ἡδονῶν ἡττᾶσθαι καὶ οὐ πράττειν διὰ ταῦτα τὰ βέλτιστα, ἐπεὶ γινώσκειν γε αὐτά. ἴσως γὰρ ἂν λεγόντων ἡμῶν ὅτι οὐκ ὀρθῶς

λέγετε, ὦ ἄνθρωποι, ἀλλὰ ψεύδεσθε, ἔρουντ' ἂν ἡμᾶς· ὦ Πρωταγόρα τε καὶ Σώκρατες, εἰ μὴ ἔστιν τοῦτο τὸ πάθημα ἡδονῆς ἡττᾶσθαι, ἀλλὰ τί ποτ' ἔστιν, καὶ τί ὑμεῖς αὐτό φατε εἶναι; εἵπατον ἡμῖν. τί δέ, ὦ Σώκρατες, δεῖ ἡμᾶς σκοπεῖσθαι τὴν τῶν πολλῶν δόξαν ἀνθρώπων, οἳ ὅτι ἂν τύχωσι τοῦτο λέγουσιν;

353b

“Well,” said I, “I believe this is significant for us in discovering where courage stands in relation to the other parts of excellence. Now, if you think we should abide by what we agreed earlier, that I should lead in the manner that in my view best clarifies the issue, then please follow my lead.

353b

But if you do not want to, I bid the issue farewell, if that is what you prefer.”

353b

“No, you are quite right,” he said. “Proceed as you have begun.”

οἶμαι, ἦν δ' ἐγώ, εἶναι τι ἡμῖν τοῦτο πρὸς τὸ ἐξευρεῖν περὶ ἀνδρείας, πρὸς τᾶλλα μόρια τὰ τῆς ἀρετῆς πῶς ποτ' ἔχει. εἰ οὖν σοι δοκεῖ ἐμμένειν οἷς ἄρτι ἔδοξεν ἡμῖν, ἐμὲ ἡγήσασθαι ἢ οἶμαι ἂν ἔγωγε κάλλιστα φανερόν γενέσθαι, ἔπου· εἰ δὲ μὴ βούλει, εἴ σοι φίλον, ἐὼ χαίρειν. ἀλλ', ἔφη, ὀρθῶς λέγεις· καὶ πέραινε ὥσπερ ἤρξω.

353c

“Once again, then,” said I, “if they were to ask us, ‘So what are you saying this is, this experience we termed yielding to pleasures?’ What I would say to them is, ‘Listen, and Protagoras and I shall try to explain it to you. Don’t you good people say that this happens in situations where, for instance, you are overpowered, as so often happens, by the pleasures of food and drink or sexual gratification, and engage in these nevertheless, even though you recognise that they are bad?’”

353c

“They would agree.”

πάλιν τοίνυν, ἔφην ἐγώ, εἰ ἔροιντο ἡμᾶς τί οὖν φατε τοῦτο εἶναι, ὃ ἡμεῖς ἤττω εἶναι τῶν ἡδονῶν ἐλέγομεν; εἵπομι' ἂν ἔγωγε πρὸς αὐτοὺς ὡδί· Ἀκούετε δὴ πειρασόμεθα γὰρ ὑμῖν ἐγώ τε καὶ Πρωταγόρας φράσαι. ἄλλο τι γάρ, ὦ ἄνθρωποι, φατὲ ὑμῖν τοῦτο γίγνεσθαι ἐν τοῖσδε, οἷον πολλάκις ὑπὸ σίτων καὶ ποτῶν καὶ ἀφροδισίων κρατούμενοι ἡδέων ὄντων, γιγνώσκοντες ὅτι πονηρὰ ἐστίν, ὅμως αὐτὰ πράττειν;—φάτιν ἄν.—οὐκοῦν ἐροίμεθ' ἂν αὐτοὺς ἐγώ τε καὶ σὺ πάλιν· Πονηρὰ δὲ αὐτὰ πῇ φατε εἶναι;

353d

“In that case, you and I would ask them again, ‘In what sense are you saying they are bad? Is it because they provide this pleasure in the moment and because each of them is pleasant, or because some time later they produce disease and poverty, and bring on many other such afflictions? Or even if they bring on none of these afflictions afterwards, but produce only delight, could they be bad anyway, just because they produce delight in some way or other?’ Now, Protagoras, I think they can only reply that they are not bad because of the production of momentary pleasure, but due to the diseases and whatever else arises later.”

πότερον ὅτι τὴν ἡδονὴν ταύτην ἐν τῷ παραχρῆμα παρέχει καὶ ἡδὺ ἐστὶν ἕκαστον αὐτῶν, ἢ ὅτι εἰς τὸν ὕστερον χρόνον νόσους τε ποιεῖ καὶ πενίας καὶ ἄλλα τοιαῦτα πολλὰ παρασκευάζει; ἢ καὶ εἴ τι τούτων εἰς τὸ ὕστερον μηδὲν παρασκευάζει, χαίρειν δὲ μόνον ποιεῖ, ὅμως δ' ἂν κακὰ ἦν, ὅτι μαθόντα χαίρειν ποιεῖ καὶ ὀπιοῦν; ἄρ' οἰόμεθ' ἂν αὐτούς, ὦ Πρωταγόρα, ἄλλο τι ἀποκρίνασθαι ἢ ὅτι οὐ κατὰ τὴν αὐτῆς τῆς ἡδονῆς τῆς παραχρῆμα ἐργασίαν κακὰ ἐστίν,

353e

“Yes,” said Protagoras, “I believe that most people would give that answer.”

353e

“And in producing disease, don’t they produce distress? And in producing poverty, don’t they produce distress?” I presume they would agree with that.”

353e

Protagoras concurred.

ἀλλὰ διὰ τὰ ὕστερον γιγνόμενα, νόσους τε καὶ τᾶλλα.—ἐγὼ μὲν οἶμαι, ἔφη ὁ Πρωταγόρας, τοὺς πολλοὺς ἂν ταῦτα ἀποκρίνασθαι.—οὐκοῦν νόσους ποιοῦντα ἀνίας ποιεῖ, καὶ πενίας ποιοῦντα ἀνίας ποιεῖ; Ὁμολογοῖεν ἂν, ὡς ἐγὼ μαι.—συνέφη ὁ Πρωταγόρας.— ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν φαίνεται, ὦ ἄνθρωποι, ὑμῖν, ὥς φαμεν ἐγὼ τε καὶ Πρωταγόρας, δι' οὐδὲν ἄλλο ταῦτα κακὰ ὄντα ἢ διότι εἰς ἀνίας τε ἀποτελευτᾷ καὶ ἄλλων

354a

“So, good people, is it your view, as Protagoras and I are saying, that these pleasures are bad only because they end in distress and deprive you of other pleasures?” Would they agree?”

354a

We both concurred.

354a

“Well, suppose we were to put the opposite question to them. ‘You, good people, who also maintain that what is good can be distressful, are you saying, for example, that physical exercise, military activity or medical treatment brought about through burning, cutting, drugs and fasting are good, even though they are distressful?’ Would they agree?”

354a

He concurred.

ἡδονῶν ἀποστερεῖ; Ὁμολογοῖεν ἂν;—συνεδόκει ἡμῖν ἀμφοῖν.—οὐκοῦν πάλιν ἂν αὐτοὺς τὸ ἐναντίον εἰ ἐροίμεθα ὦ ἄνθρωποι οἱ λέγοντες αὐτὰ ἀγαθὰ ἀνιαρὰ εἶναι, ἄρα οὐ τὰ τοιάδε λέγετε, οἷον τὰ τε γυμνάσια καὶ τὰς στρατείας καὶ τὰς ὑπὸ τῶν ἱατρῶν θεραπείας τὰς διὰ καύσεων τε καὶ τομῶν καὶ φαρμακείων καὶ λιμοκτονιῶν γιγνομένης, ὅτι ταῦτα ἀγαθὰ μὲν ἐστίν, ἀνιαρὰ δέ; φαῖεν ἂν;—συνεδόκει.—πότερον

354b

“Now, is that why you call them good, because of the extreme pain and the suffering they cause at the time? Or is it because of the health, bodily vigour, the civic safeguards, the dominion over others, and the

wealth that arises from them afterwards?" I presume they would agree."

354b

He concurred.

οὖν κατὰ τόδε ἀγαθὰ αὐτὰ καλεῖτε, ὅτι ἐν τῷ παραχρῆμα ὀδύνας τὰς ἐσχάτας παρέχει καὶ ἀλγηδόνας, ἢ ὅτι εἰς τὸν ὕστερον χρόνον ὑγίειαί τε ἀπ' αὐτῶν γίνονται καὶ εὐεξίαί τῶν σωμάτων καὶ τῶν πόλεων σωτηρίαί καὶ ἄλλων ἀρχαὶ καὶ πλοῦτοι; φαῖεν ἄν, ὡς ἐγῶμαι.—συνεδόκει.—ταῦτα δὲ ἀγαθὰ ἐστὶ δι' ἄλλο τι ἢ ὅτι εἰς ἡδονὰς ἀποτελευτᾷ καὶ λυπῶν ἀπαλλαγὰς τε καὶ ἀποτροπὰς; ἢ ἔχετε τι ἄλλο τέλος

354c

"And are these good for any other reason than because they end in pleasure, and relieve or avert pain? Or can you think of any other outcome that you might refer to when describing them as good, apart from pleasure and pain?" I think they would say no."

354c

"I think so too," said Protagoras.

354c

"So, do you pursue pleasure as good, and flee from pain as bad?"

354c

He agreed.

λέγειν, εἰς ὃ ἀποβλέψαντες αὐτὰ ἀγαθὰ καλεῖτε, ἀλλ' ἢ ἡδονὰς τε καὶ λύπας; οὐκ ἂν φαῖεν, ὡς ἐγῶμαι.—οὐδ' ἐμοὶ δοκεῖ, ἔφη ὁ Πρωταγόρας.—οὐκοῦν τὴν μὲν ἡδονὴν διώκετε ὡς ἀγαθὸν ὄν, τὴν δὲ λύπην φεύγετε ὡς κακόν;—συνεδόκει.—τοῦτ' ἄρα ἡγεῖσθ' εἶναι κακόν, τὴν λύπην, καὶ ἀγαθὸν τὴν ἡδονήν, ἐπεὶ καὶ αὐτὸ τὸ χαίρειν τότε λέγετε κακὸν εἶναι, ὅταν μειζόνων ἡδονῶν ἀποστερῇ ἢ ὅσας αὐτὸ ἔχει, ἢ λύπας μείζους παρασκευάζῃ τῶν ἐν

354d

"So, this pain is what you regard as bad, and pleasure is what you regard as good. Then, you also say that delight itself is bad whenever it

deprives you of greater pleasures than those that the delight affords, or brings on pains greater than the pleasures it contains. Now, if you refer to the delight itself as bad on any other basis, or by referring to any other outcome, you would also be able to tell us what it is. But you cannot.”

354d

“No, I don’t think they can,” said Protagoras.

αὐτῷ ἡδονῶν· ἐπεὶ εἰ κατ’ ἄλλο τι αὐτὸ τὸ χαίρειν κακὸν καλεῖτε καὶ εἰς ἄλλο τι τέλος ἀποβλέψαντες, ἔχοιτε ἂν καὶ ἡμῖν εἰπεῖν· ἄλλ’ οὐχ ἔξετε.—οὐδ’ ἐμοὶ δοκοῦσιν, ἔφη ὁ Πρωταγόρας.—ἄλλο τι οὖν πάλιν καὶ περὶ αὐτοῦ τοῦ λυπεῖσθαι ὁ αὐτὸς τρόπος; τότε καλεῖτε αὐτὸ τὸ λυπεῖσθαι ἀγαθόν, ὅταν ἢ μείζους λύπας τῶν ἐν αὐτῷ οὐσῶν ἀπαλλάττῃ ἢ μείζους ἡδονὰς τῶν λυπῶν παρασκευάζῃ; ἐπεὶ εἰ πρὸς ἄλλο τι τέλος ἀποβλέπετε, ὅταν καλῇτε αὐτὸ τὸ λυπεῖσθαι

354e

“Then again, is it the same way with the experience of pain itself? Do you call the experience of pain itself good whenever it relieves you of greater pains than the pain it contains or provides pleasures that exceed the pain? Now, if you refer to any other outcome, whenever you call the experience of pain itself good, you would be able to tell us what it is. But you cannot.”

354e

“What you are saying is true,” said Protagoras.

354e

“‘Again, in that case, good people,’ said I, ‘if you should ask me, “Why ever are you saying so much and speaking in so many different ways about this matter?” I would reply, “Please excuse me, but firstly it is not easy to demonstrate what precisely this experience you call ‘yielding to

ἀγαθόν, ἢ πρὸς ὃ ἐγὼ λέγω, ἔχετε ἡμῖν εἰπεῖν· ἄλλ’ οὐχ ἔξετε.—ἀληθῆ, ἔφη, λέγεις, ὁ Πρωταγόρας. πάλιν τοίνυν, ἔφην ἐγώ, εἴ με ἀνέροισθε, ὦ ἄνθρωποι, τίνος οὖν δήποτε ἔνεκα πολλὰ περὶ τούτου λέγεις καὶ

πολλαχῇ; Συγγιγνώσκετέ μοι, φαίην ἂν ἔγωγε. πρῶτον μὲν γὰρ οὐ ῥᾶδιον ἀποδείξαι τί ἐστὶν ποτε τοῦτο ὃ ὑμεῖς καλεῖτε τῶν ἡδονῶν ἥττω εἶναι· ἔπειτα ἐν τούτῳ εἰσὶν πᾶσαι αἱ ἀποδείξεις, ΣΩ. ἀλλ' ἔτι καὶ νῦν ἀναθέσθαι ἔξεστιν,

355a

pleasures' actually is, and secondly, all our examples involve this issue." But even now it is still possible to retract, if you are somehow able to assert that the good is something other than pleasure, and the bad something other than distress. Or are you satisfied with a life lived pleasantly, a life without pain? If this is satisfactory and you are unable to say that anything is good or bad unless it ends in pleasure or pain, then hear what follows. For I tell you that if this is the case, the argument becomes ridiculous once you state that a person who knows that bad deeds are bad, often enacts them anyway when they can be avoided, as he is led and stricken by pleasures, and also, when you go on to state that a person who knows what is good is not prepared to enact it, because he yields to the pleasures of the moment.'

εἴ πη ἔχετε ἄλλο τι φάναι εἶναι τὸ ἀγαθὸν ἢ τὴν ἡδονήν, ἢ τὸ κακὸν ἄλλο τι ἢ τὴν ἀνίαν· ἢ ἀρκεῖ ὑμῖν τὸ ἡδέως καταβιῶναι τὸν βίον ἄνευ λυπῶν; εἰ δὲ ἀρκεῖ καὶ μὴ ἔχετε μηδὲν ἄλλο φάναι εἶναι ἀγαθὸν ἢ κακὸν ὃ μὴ εἰς ταῦτα τελευτᾷ, τὸ μετὰ τοῦτο ἀκούετε. φημί γὰρ ὑμῖν τούτου οὕτως ἔχοντος γελοῖον τὸν λόγον γίνεσθαι, ὅταν λέγητε ὅτι πολλάκις γιγνώσκων τὰ κακὰ ἄνθρωπος ὅτι κακά ἐστιν, ὅμως πράττει αὐτά, ἐξὸν μὴ πράττειν, ὑπὸ τῶν ἡδονῶν ἀγόμενος καὶ ἐκπληττόμενος· καὶ αὐθις αὖ λέγετε ὅτι γιγνώσκων ὁ ἄνθρωπος τὰγαθὰ πράττειν οὐκ ἐθέλει διὰ τὰς παραχρῆμα ἡδονάς, ὑπὸ τούτων ἡττώμενος. ὥς δὲ ταῦτα γελοῖα ἐστίν, κατὰδηλον ἔσται, ἐὰν μὴ πολλοῖς ὀνόμασι χρώμεθα ἅμα, ἡδεῖ τε καὶ ἀνιαρῶ καὶ ἀγαθῶ καὶ κακῶ, ἀλλ' ἐπειδὴ δύο ἐφάνη ταῦτα, δυοῖν καὶ ὀνόμασιν προσαγορεύωμεν αὐτά, πρῶτον μὲν ἀγαθῶ καὶ κακῶ, ἔπειτα αὐθις ἡδεῖ τε

355c

"And it will be obvious that these arguments are ridiculous, once we stop using lots of names at the same time – pleasure and distress, good

and bad. Rather, since it turns out that there are only two things, let's refer to them by two names, first by good and bad, and after that by pleasure and distress. Then, having assigned the names in this way, we should state that a person who knows that bad deeds are bad, enacts them anyway. So if someone asks us, 'Why did he do it?' we shall reply that he yielded. 'Yielded to what?' the fellow will ask us. But we are no longer allowed to say that he yields to pleasure, for another word, the good, has been substituted in place of pleasure. So when we are asked the question and we say he yields, he will say, 'To what?' and we shall say, 'By Zeus, to the good.' Now, if our questioner happens to be arrogant, he will laugh and say, 'You are describing an absurd state of affairs if someone does what is bad knowing that it is bad, when he doesn't need to do it, because he yields to what is good'. So he will say, 'Does the bad within you prevail over the good, while being worth more or being worth less?' Obviously, we shall say by way of reply that it is worth less, otherwise the person whom we describe as yielding to pleasures would not have erred. He will probably ask, 'But on what basis is the good worth less than the bad, or the bad than the good? Is there any basis other than one being larger and the other smaller, or one being more numerous and the other less so?' We shall be unable to offer any alternatives to this. 'It's obvious, then,' he will say, 'that by this "yielding" you mean getting less good in place of more bad.'

καὶ ἀνιαρῶ. θέμενοι δὴ οὕτω λέγωμεν ὅτι Γινώσκων ὁ ἄνθρωπος τὰ κακὰ ὅτι κακὰ ἐστίν, ὅμως αὐτὰ ποιεῖ. ἐὰν οὖν τις ἡμᾶς ἔρηται, διὰ τί; Ἡττώμενος, φήσομεν· ὑπὸ τοῦ; ἐκεῖνος ἐρήσεται ἡμᾶς· ἡμῖν δὲ ὑπὸ μὲν ἡδονῆς οὐκέτι ἔξεστιν εἰπεῖν—ἄλλο γὰρ ὄνομα μετείληφεν ἀντὶ τῆς ἡδονῆς τὸ ἀγαθόν—ἐκείνῳ δὲ ἀποκρινώμεθα καὶ λέγωμεν ὅτι Ἡττώμενος—ὑπὸ τίνος; φήσει. τοῦ ἀγαθοῦ, φήσομεν νῆ Δία. ἂν οὖν τύχη ὁ ἐρόμενος ἡμᾶς ὑβριστῆς ὢν, γελάσεται καὶ ἐρεῖ· ἢ γελοῖον λέγετε πρᾶγμα, εἰ πράττει τις κακὰ, γινώσκων ὅτι κακὰ ἐστίν, οὐ δέον αὐτὸν πράττειν, ἡττώμενος ὑπὸ τῶν ἀγαθῶν. ἄρα, φήσει, οὐκ ἀξίων ὄντων νικᾶν ἐν ὑμῖν τῶν ἀγαθῶν τὰ κακὰ, ἢ ἀξίων; φήσομεν δηλὸν ὅτι ἀποκρινόμενοι, ὅτι οὐκ ἀξίων ὄντων· οὐ γὰρ ἂν ἐξημάρτανεν ὃν φαμεν

ἥττω εἶναι τῶν ἡδονῶν. κατὰ τί δέ, φήσει ἴσως, ἀνάξιά ἐστιν τὰγαθὰ τῶν κακῶν ἢ τὰ κακὰ τῶν ἀγαθῶν; ἢ κατ' ἄλλο τι ἢ ὅταν τὰ μὲν μείζω, τὰ δὲ σμικρότερα ἢ; ἢ πλείω, τὰ δὲ ἐλάττω ἢ; οὐχ ἔξομεν εἰπεῖν ἄλλο ἢ τοῦτο. δῆλον ἄρα, φήσει, ὅτι τὸ ἡττᾶσθαι τοῦτο λέγετε, ἀντὶ ἐλαττόνων ἀγαθῶν μείζω κακὰ λαμβάνειν. ταῦτα μὲν οὖν οὕτω. ΣΩ. μεταλάβωμεν δὴ τὰ ὀνόματα πάλιν τὸ ἡδύ τε καὶ ἀνιαρὸν ἐπὶ τοῖς αὐτοῖς τούτοις, καὶ λέγωμεν ὅτι Ἄνθρωπος πράττει—τότε μὲν ἐλέγομεν τὰ κακὰ, νῦν δὲ λέγωμεν τὰ ἀνιαρά, γινώσκων ὅτι ἀνιαρά ἐστιν, ἡττώμενος

356a

“So in the case of these names, that is the outcome. Let us then substitute the names once more and apply pleasure and distress to those same things. And we would then state that a person enacts what we previously referred to as bad – but should now refer to as distressful – knowing that it is distressful, having yielded to pleasures which obviously are not worthy of victory. Apart from mutual excess or deficiency, is there any other way that pleasure is worth less than pain? And these involve pleasure and pain becoming larger and smaller than one another, or more numerous and less numerous, or more intense and less intense. For suppose someone were to say, ‘But, Socrates, the pleasure of the moment differs greatly from the pleasure and pain that will come later’, I would reply, ‘Is there any other way they could differ than in pleasure and in pain? Indeed, there is no other way they can differ. Rather, just like a person who is good at weighing, you take the pleasures and the pains, together with their proximity or remoteness, place them in the balance, and state which weighs more. So, if you are weighing pleasures against pleasures, the greater and more numerous are always chosen. If it is pains against pains, the lesser and fewer are always chosen. If it is pleasures against pains, you adopt the course of action in which the distress is exceeded by the pleasure, whether the near exceeds the far or the far exceeds the near. And if the pleasures are exceeded by the distress, the action is not to be performed.’ So I would say, ‘Good people, isn’t this how matters stand?’ And I know they would be unable to say otherwise.”

ὑπὸ τῶν ἡδέων, δῆλον ὅτι ἀναξίων ὄντων νικᾷν. καὶ τίς ἄλλη ἀναξία ἡδονῇ πρὸς λύπην ἐστίν, ἀλλ' ἢ ὑπερβολὴ ἀλλήλων καὶ ἔλλειψις; ταῦτα δ' ἐστὶ μείζω τε καὶ σμικρότερα γιγνόμενα ἀλλήλων καὶ πλείω καὶ ἐλάττω καὶ μᾶλλον καὶ ἥττον. εἰ γάρ τις λέγοι ὅτι ἀλλὰ πολὺ διαφέρει, ὦ Σώκρατες, τὸ παραχρημα ἡδὺ τοῦ εἰς τὸν ὕστερον χρόνον καὶ ἡδέος καὶ λυπηροῦ, μῶν ἄλλω τῷ, φαίην ἂν ἔγωγε, ἢ ἡδονῇ καὶ λύπῃ; οὐ γὰρ ἔσθ' ὅτῳ ἄλλω. ἀλλ' ὥσπερ ἀγαθὸς ἰστάναι ἄνθρωπος, συνθεῖς τὰ ἡδέα καὶ συνθεῖς τὰ λυπηρά, καὶ τὸ ἐγγὺς καὶ τὸ πόρρω στήσας ἐν τῷ ζυγῷ, εἰπὲ πότερα πλείω ἐστίν. ἐὰν μὲν γὰρ ἡδέα πρὸς ἡδέα ἰσῆς, τὰ μείζω ἀεὶ καὶ πλείω ληπτέα· ἐὰν δὲ λυπηρά πρὸς λυπηρά, τὰ ἐλάττω καὶ σμικρότερα· ἐὰν δὲ ἡδέα πρὸς λυπηρά, ἐὰν μὲν τὰ ἀνιάρᾳ ὑπερβάλληται ὑπὸ τῶν ἡδέων, ἐάντε τὰ ἐγγὺς ὑπὸ τῶν πόρρω ἐάντε τὰ πόρρω ὑπὸ τῶν ἐγγύς, ταύτην τὴν πρᾶξιν πρακτέον ἐν ἧ ἂν ταῦτ' ἐνῇ· ἐὰν

356c

Protagoras also agreed with that.

356c

“In this circumstance, I shall say, ‘I have a question for you. Do the same objects appear larger to you when they are nearer, and smaller when far away, or is this not the case?’”

356c

“They will agree.”

356c

“And does the same go for their thickness or the quantity of them? And are equal sounds louder when nearer, and fainter when they are far away?”

356c

“They would agree.”

δὲ τὰ ἡδέα ὑπὸ τῶν ἀνιάρων, οὐ πρακτέα. μή πη ἄλλη ἔχει, φαίην ἂν, ταῦτα, ὧ ἄνθρωποι; οἷδ' ὅτι οὐκ ἂν ἔχοιεν ἄλλως λέγειν.—συνεδόκει καὶ ἐκείνῳ. ὅτε δὴ τοῦτο οὕτως ἔχει, τότε μοι ἀποκρίνασθε, φήσω. φαίνεται ὑμῖν τῇ ὅψει τὰ αὐτὰ μεγέθη ἐγγύθεν μὲν μείζω, πόρρωθεν δὲ ἐλάττω ἢ οὐ;—φήσουσιν.—καὶ τὰ παχέα καὶ τὰ πολλὰ ὡσαύτως; καὶ αἱ

φωναὶ αἱ ἴσαι ἐγγύθεν μὲν μείζους, πόρρωθεν δὲ μικρότεραι;—φαῖεν ἄν.—εἰ οὖν

356d

“Now, if our welfare consisted in this, in enacting or adopting whatever has a large measure, and avoiding and not enacting whatever has a small measure, what would the salvation of our lives prove to be? Would it be skill in measurement or the power of appearance? Or is it the latter power that sets us astray and makes us change our views back and forth so often, and regret our actions, and our choices of greater and lesser; while measurement, for its part – would it have rendered this illusion powerless, and by revealing the truth would it have made the soul peaceful, abiding in the truth, and would it have saved our life? So in view of this, would the people agree that the skill of measurement would save us, or would it be a different one?”

ἐν τούτῳ ἡμῖν ἦν τὸ εὖ πράττειν, ἐν τῷ τὰ μὲν μεγάλα μήκη καὶ πράττειν καὶ λαμβάνειν, τὰ δὲ μικρὰ καὶ φεύγειν καὶ μὴ πράττειν, τίς ἂν ἡμῖν σωτηρία ἐφάνη τοῦ βίου; ἄρα ἡ μετρητικὴ τέχνη ἢ ἡ τοῦ φαινομένου δύναμις; ἢ αὕτη μὲν ἡμᾶς ἐπλάνα καὶ ἐποίει ἄνω τε καὶ κάτω πολλάκις μεταλαμβάνειν ταῦτα καὶ μεταμέλειν καὶ ἐν ταῖς πράξεσιν καὶ ἐν ταῖς αἰρέσεσιν τῶν μεγάλων τε καὶ μικρῶν, ἢ δὲ μετρητικὴ ἄκυρον μὲν ἂν ἐποίησε τοῦτο τὸ φάντασμα, δηλώσασα

356e

“Measurement,” he agreed.

δὲ τὸ ἀληθὲς ἡσυχίαν ἂν ἐποίησεν ἔχειν τὴν ψυχὴν μένουσαν ἐπὶ τῷ ἀληθεῖ καὶ ἔσωσεν ἂν τὸν βίον; ἄρ' ἂν ὁμολογοῖεν οἱ ἄνθρωποι πρὸς ταῦτα ἡμᾶς τὴν μετρητικὴν σφάζειν ἂν τέχνην ἢ ἄλλην;—τὴν μετρητικὴν, ὡμολόγει.— ΣΩ. τί δ' εἰ ἐν τῇ τοῦ περιττοῦ καὶ ἄρτίου αἰρέσει ἡμῖν ἦν ἡ σωτηρία τοῦ βίου, ὅποτε τὸ πλεον ὀρθῶς ἔδει ἐλέσθαι καὶ ὅποτε τὸ ἔλαττον, ἢ αὐτὸ πρὸς ἑαυτὸ ἢ τὸ ἕτερον πρὸς τὸ ἕτερον, εἴτ' ἐγγὺς εἴτε πόρρω εἴη; τί ἂν ἔσωζεν ἡμῖν τὸν

357a

“What if the salvation of our life lay in the selection of odd and even, and when we should rightly choose the greater and when the lesser, either in relation to themselves or to one another, whether near or far away? What would save our life? Wouldn’t it be knowledge, indeed some form of measurement, since this skill deals with excess and deficiency? And since it involves odd and even, what could it be but arithmetic? Would the people agree with us or not?”

357a

Protagoras also thought they would agree.

βίον; ἄρ’ ἂν οὐκ ἐπιστήμη; καὶ ἄρ’ ἂν οὐ μετρητική τις, ἐπειδὴ περ ὑπερβολῆς τε καὶ ἐνδείας ἐστὶν ἡ τέχνη; ἐπειδὴ δὲ περιττοῦ τε καὶ ἀρτίου, ἄρα ἄλλη τις ἢ ἀριθμητική; Ὁμολογοῖεν ἂν ἡμῖν οἱ ἄνθρωποι ἢ οὐ;—ἐδόκουν ἂν καὶ τῷ Πρωταγόρᾳ ὁμολογεῖν.—εἶεν, ὦ ἄνθρωποι· ἐπεὶ δὲ δὴ ἡδονῆς τε καὶ λύπης ἐν ὀρθῇ τῇ αἰρέσει ἐφάνη ἡμῖν ἡ σωτηρία τοῦ βίου οὕσα, τοῦ τε πλέονος καὶ ἐλάττονος καὶ

357b

“So be it, good people, but since the salvation of our life has turned out to lie in the right selection of pleasure and pain, of more numerous and less numerous, larger and smaller, far and near, firstly, isn’t it the case that measurement is an enquiry into their excess and deficiency, or their equality in relation to one another?”

357b

“It must be.”

357b

“Then measurement must presumably be a skill and knowledge.”

357b

“They will concur.”

μείζονος καὶ μικροτέρου καὶ πορρωτέρω καὶ ἐγγυτέρω, ἄρα πρῶτον μὲν οὐ μετρητικὴ φαίνεται, ὑπερβολῆς τε καὶ ἐνδείας οὕσα καὶ ἰσότητος πρὸς ἀλλήλας σκέψις;—ἀλλ’ ἀνάγκη.—ἐπεὶ δὲ μετρητικὴ, ἀνάγκη δήπου τέχνη καὶ ἐπιστήμη.—συμφήσουσιν.—ἥτις μὲν τοίνυν τέχνη καὶ

ἐπιστήμη ἐστὶν αὕτη, εἰς αὐθις σκεψόμεθα· ὅτι δὲ ἐπιστήμη ἐστίν, τοσοῦτον ἐξαρκεῖ πρὸς τὴν ἀπόδειξιν ἣν ἐμὲ δεῖ καὶ Πρωταγόραν

357c

“Well, we shall consider on another occasion what this skill and knowledge itself is. The fact that it is knowledge will suffice for the demonstration that Protagoras and I must present in answer to your question. You asked a question, if you recall, when we two agreed that nothing is more powerful than knowledge, and wherever it resides it always dominates over pleasure and all the other factors. You, in contrast, maintained that pleasure often dominates even the man who knows, and as we did not agree with you, you proceeded to ask us, ‘Protagoras and Socrates, if this experience does not consist in yielding to pleasure, then what precisely is it? And what do you say that it is?’

ἀποδείξαι περὶ ὧν ἤρεσθ’ ἡμᾶς. ἤρεσθε δέ, εἰ μέμνησθε, ἡνίκα ἡμεῖς ἀλλήλοις ὡμολογοῦμεν ἐπιστήμης μηδὲν εἶναι κρεῖττον, ἀλλὰ τοῦτο αἰεὶ κρατεῖν, ὅπου ἂν ἐνῇ, καὶ ἡδονῆς καὶ τῶν ἄλλων ἀπάντων· ὑμεῖς δὲ δὴ ἔφατε τὴν ἡδονὴν πολλακίς κρατεῖν καὶ τοῦ εἰδότος ἀνθρώπου, ἐπειδὴ δὲ ὑμῖν οὐχ ὡμολογοῦμεν, μετὰ τοῦτο ἤρεσθε ἡμᾶς· ὧ Πρωταγόρα τε καὶ Σώκρατες, εἰ μὴ ἔστι τοῦτο τὸ πάθημα ἡδονῆς ἡττᾶσθαι, ἀλλὰ τί ποτ’ ἐστὶν καὶ τί ὑμεῖς αὐτό φατε εἶναι; εἴπατε

357d

Tell us.’

ἡμῖν. εἰ μὲν οὖν τότε εὐθὺς ὑμῖν εἶπομεν ὅτι ἀμαθία, κατεγελάτε ἂν ἡμῶν· νῦν δὲ ἂν ἡμῶν καταγελάτε, καὶ ὑμῶν αὐτῶν καταγελάσεσθε. καὶ γὰρ ὑμεῖς ὡμολογήκατε ἐπιστήμης ἐνδεία ἐξαμαρτάνειν περὶ τὴν τῶν ἡδονῶν αἴρεσιν καὶ λυπῶν τοὺς ἐξαμαρτάνοντας—ταῦτα δὲ ἐστὶν ἀγαθὰ τε καὶ κακά—καὶ οὐ μόνον ἐπιστήμης, ἀλλὰ καὶ ἥς τὸ πρόσθεν ἔτι ὡμολογήκατε ὅτι μετρητικῆς· ἡ δὲ ἐξαμαρτανομένη πρᾶξις

357e

“If, at the time, we had then replied immediately that it is ignorance, you would have laughed at us. But if you laugh at us now, you will be laughing at yourselves too. For you have actually agreed that it is

through deficiency of knowledge that those who err in their choice of pleasures and pains, which correspond to good and bad, fall into error. And later on you agreed that the deficiency is not just deficiency of knowledge, but of knowledge of measurement, and I presume you yourselves know that an action performed in error, without knowledge, is performed in ignorance. Consequently, that is what this yielding to pleasure is, the greatest ignorance, which Protagoras here claims to cure, as do Prodicus and Hippias. But because you do not regard this as ignorance but as something else, you do not send your children to those who teach this, these sophists here, nor do you go to them yourselves because it is not teachable. You care instead for money, and you will not give it to these teachers, so you fare badly in your private and public lives.

ἄνευ ἐπιστήμης ἴστε πού καὶ αὐτοὶ ὅτι ἀμαθία πράττεται. ὥστε τοῦτ' ἐστὶν τὸ ἡδονῆς ἥττω εἶναι, ἀμαθία ἢ μεγίστη, ἧς Πρωταγόρας ὅδε φησὶν ἰατρὸς εἶναι καὶ Πρόδικος καὶ Ἱππίας· ὑμεῖς δὲ διὰ τὸ οἶεσθαι ἄλλο τι ἢ ἀμαθίαν εἶναι οὔτε αὐτοὶ οὔτε τοὺς ὑμετέρους παῖδας παρὰ τοὺς τούτων διδασκάλους τούσδε τοὺς σοφιστὰς πέμπετε, ὥς οὐ διδακτοῦ ὄντος, ἀλλὰ κηδόμενοι τοῦ ἀργυρίου καὶ οὐ διδόντες τούτοις κακῶς πράττετε καὶ ἰδίᾳ καὶ δημοσίᾳ.

358a

“These then are the answers we would have given to most people. And now, along with Protagoras, I am asking you, Hippias and Prodicus, do you think I am speaking the truth or speaking falsely? Let us involve the two of you in the argument.”

358a

It seemed to everyone, without reservation, that what had been said was true.

ΣΩ. ταῦτα μὲν τοῖς πολλοῖς ἀποκεκριμένοι ἂν ἤμεν· ὑμᾶς δὲ δὴ μετὰ Πρωταγόρου ἐρωτῶ, ὦ Ἱππία τε καὶ Πρόδικε (κοινὸς γὰρ δὴ ἔστω ὑμῖν ὁ λόγος) πότερον δοκῶ ὑμῖν ἀληθῆ λέγειν ἢ ψεύδεσθαι.—ὕπερφυῶς ἐδόκει ἅπασιν ἀληθῆ εἶναι τὰ εἰρημένα.—ὁμολογεῖτε ἄρα, ἦν δ' ἐγώ, τὸ

μὲν ἡδὺ ἀγαθὸν εἶναι, τὸ δὲ ἀνιαρὸν κακόν. τὴν δὲ Προδίκου τοῦδε διαίρεσιν τῶν ὀνομάτων παραιτοῦμαι· εἴτε γὰρ ἡδὺ εἴτε τερπνὸν λέγεις εἴτε χαρτόν, εἴτε ὀπόθεν καὶ ὅπως χαίρεις τὰ τοιαῦτα

358b

“So, you agree,” said I, “that pleasure is good and distress is bad. And I am avoiding Prodicus’ distinctions between words, for whether you say pleasure is enjoyment or delight or however else you may enjoy assigning names of this sort, good Prodicus, please answer my question, as it is intended.”

358b

Prodicus laughed at this and he agreed, as did the others.

358b

“Well, gentlemen,” said I, “what about all actions towards this end, towards living pleasantly and painlessly – aren’t they all noble? And is a noble deed good and beneficial?”

358b

They agreed.

ὀνομάζων, ὦ βέλτιστε Πρόδικε, τοῦτό μοι πρὸς ὃ βούλομαι ἀποκρίναι. —γελάσας οὖν ὁ Πρόδικος συνωμολόγησε, καὶ οἱ ἄλλοι.—τί δὲ δή, ὦ ἄνδρες, ἔφην ἐγώ, τὸ τοιόνδε; αἱ ἐπὶ τούτου πράξεις ἅπασαι, ἐπὶ τοῦ ἀλύπως ζῆν καὶ ἡδέως, ἅρ’ οὐ καλαί καὶ ὠφέλιμοι; καὶ τὸ καλὸν ἔργον ἀγαθὸν τε καὶ ὠφέλιμον;—συνεδόκει.—εἰ ἄρα, ἔφην ἐγώ, τὸ ἡδὺ ἀγαθὸν ἐστίν, οὐδεὶς οὔτε εἰδὼς οὔτε οἰόμενος ἄλλα βελτίω εἶναι ἢ

358c

“So, if it is the case,” said I, “that the pleasant is good, no one who knows or believes that other actions are better than those he is enacting, and can enact, then proceeds to enact them anyway, when he can enact what is better. Nor is yielding to oneself anything other than ignorance, nor is controlling oneself anything other than wisdom.”

358c

They all agreed.

358c

“What about this? Would you say that ignorance consists in holding a false opinion and in labouring under falsehood in relation to matters of great importance?”

358c

This too was agreed upon by everyone.

ἃ ποιεῖ, καὶ δυνατά, ἔπειτα ποιεῖ ταῦτα, ἐξὸν τὰ βελτίω· οὐδὲ τὸ ἦττω εἶναι αὐτοῦ ἄλλο τι τοῦτ' ἐστὶν ἢ ἀμαθία, οὐδὲ κρείττω ἑαυτοῦ ἄλλο τι ἢ σοφία.—συνεδόκει πᾶσιν.—τί δὲ δὴ; ἀμαθίαν ἄρα τὸ τοιόνδε λέγετε, τὸ ψευδῆ ἔχειν δόξαν καὶ ἐψεῦσθαι περὶ τῶν πραγμάτων τῶν πολλοῦ ἀξίων;—καὶ τοῦτο πᾶσι συνεδόκει.—ἄλλο τι οὖν, ἔφην ἐγώ, ἐπὶ γε τὰ κακὰ οὐδεὶς ἐκὼν ἔρχεται οὐδὲ ἐπὶ ἃ οἴεται κακὰ εἶναι, οὐδ'

358d

“Then surely no one goes willingly to what is bad, or what they regard as bad. Nor, it seems, is it in human nature to do so, to wish to go to what you regard as bad instead of what is good. And when compelled to choose one or the other of two bad things, will anyone choose the greater if he is allowed to have the lesser?”

358d

All this was agreed by all of us.

358d

“Well now,” said I, “do you use the terms dread and fear? And do you use them as I do? I am directing this question to you, Prodicus. I say that whether you call it dread or fear, it is some expectation of bad.”

ἔστι τοῦτο, ὡς ἔοικεν, ἐν ἀνθρώπου φύσει, ἐπὶ ἃ οἴεται κακὰ εἶναι ἐθέλειν ἰέναι ἀντὶ τῶν ἀγαθῶν· ὅταν τε ἀναγκασθῇ δυοῖν κακοῖν τὸ ἕτερον αἰρεῖσθαι, οὐδεὶς τὸ μείζον αἰρήσεται ἐξὸν τὸ ἔλαττον;—ἅπαντα ταῦτα συνεδόκει ἅπασιν ἡμῖν.—τί οὖν; ἔφην ἐγώ, καλεῖτέ τι δέος καὶ φόβον; καὶ ἄρα ὅπερ ἐγώ; (πρὸς σὲ λέγω, ὦ Πρόδικε). προσδοκίαν τινὰ λέγω κακοῦ τοῦτο, εἴτε φόβον εἴτε δέος καλεῖτε.—ἐδόκει Πρωταγόρα μὲν καὶ Ἰππία δέος τε καὶ φόβος εἶναι τοῦτο,

358e

Protagoras and Hippias thought that this is what they are, but Prodicus thought this was dread, but not fear.

358e

“Well, that makes no difference, Prodicus,” I said. “My point is as follows. If what has been said previously is true, will any person wish to go to whatever he dreads if he is allowed to go to what he does not dread? Or is this impossible, from what has been agreed? For we have agreed that whatever he dreads, he regards as bad, and no one willingly goes to or takes hold of what they regard as bad.”

προδίκω δὲ δέος, φόβος δ' οὐ.—ἀλλ' οὐδέν, ἔφην ἐγώ, Πρόδικε, διαφέρει· ἀλλὰ τόδε. εἰ ἀληθὴ τὰ ἔμπροσθέν ἐστιν, ἄρα τις ἀνθρώπων ἐθελήσει ἐπὶ ταῦτα ἵεναι ἃ δέδοικεν, ἐξὸν ἐπὶ ἃ μή; ἢ ἀδύνατον ἐκ τῶν ὠμολογημένων; ἃ γὰρ δέδοικεν, ὠμολόγηται ἡγεῖσθαι κακὰ εἶναι· ἃ δὲ ἡγεῖται κακὰ, οὐδένα οὔτε ἵεναι ἐπὶ ταῦτα οὔτε λαμβάνειν ἐκόντα.—ἐδόκει

359a

Everyone thought so too.

359a

“Then, Prodicus and Hippias,” said I, “based on these conclusions, Protagoras here should offer us a defence of the answer he gave at first, not the very first one though, where he said there are five parts of excellence, each dissimilar to the other one, each having its own particular power.

καὶ ταῦτα πᾶσιν. ΣΩ. οὕτω δὴ τούτων ὑποκειμένων, ἦν δ' ἐγώ, Πρόδικέ τε καὶ Ἱππία, ἀπολογείσθω ἡμῖν Πρωταγόρας ὅδε ἃ τὸ πρῶτον ἀπεκρίνατο πῶς ὀρθῶς ἔχει—μὴ ἃ τὸ πρῶτον παντάπασιν τότε μὲν γὰρ δὴ πέντε ὄντων μορίων τῆς ἀρετῆς οὐδὲν ἔφη εἶναι τὸ ἕτερον οἷον τὸ ἕτερον, ἰδίαν δὲ αὐτοῦ ἕκαστον ἔχειν δύναμιν· ἀλλ' οὐ ταῦτα λέγω, ἀλλ' ἃ τὸ ὕστερον εἶπεν. τὸ γὰρ ὕστερον ἔφη τὰ μὲν τέτταρα ἐπικεικῶς παραπλήσια ἀλλήλοις

359b

That is not the answer I mean. No, it is what he said later. For he said that four of them are fairly similar to one another, while one, courage, differs greatly from the others, and he told me I would recognise this from the following piece of evidence: ‘Indeed, Socrates, you will find people who are utterly irreverent, unjust, unrestrained and unlearned, and yet utterly courageous, and you may appreciate from this fact that courage differs considerably from the other parts of excellence’.

εἶναι, τὸ δὲ ἐν πάνυ πολὺ διαφέρειν τῶν ἄλλων, τὴν ἀνδρείαν, γνῶσεσθαι δέ μ’ ἔφη τεκμηρίῳ τῷδε· εὐρήσεις γάρ, ὦ Σώκρατες, ἀνθρώπους ἀνοσιωτάτους μὲν ὄντας καὶ ἀδικωτάτους καὶ ἀκολαστοτάτους καὶ ἀμαθεστάτους, ἀνδρειοτάτους δέ· ὃ γνῶσι ὅτι πολὺ διαφέρει ἡ ἀνδρεία τῶν ἄλλων μορίων τῆς ἀρετῆς. καὶ ἐγὼ εὐθύς τότε πάνυ ἐθαύμασα τὴν ἀπόκρισιν, καὶ ἔτι μᾶλλον ἐπειδὴ ταῦτα μεθ’ ὑμῶν διεξῆλθον. ἡρόμην δ’ οὖν τοῦτον εἰ τοὺς ἀνδρείους λέγοι θαρραλέους· ὁ δέ, καὶ

359c

“I was immediately surprised by this response at the time, and I am even more surprised now that I have gone through these issues with you. Accordingly, I asked him if he calls the courageous people daring, and he said, ‘Yes, and impulsive too’. “Do you remember giving that answer, Protagoras?” I asked.

359c

He agreed.

359c

“Come on, then,” said I, “tell us. Towards what are the courageous people impulsive? Are they the very things towards which cowards are impulsive?”

359c

“No,” he replied.

359c

“They are different then.”

359c

“Yes,” he replied.

359c

“Do the cowards go for daring exploits, while the courageous go for exploits that are dreaded?”

359c

“That is what people say, Socrates.”

ἴτας γ', ἔφη. μέμνησαι, ἦν δ' ἐγώ, ὦ Πρωταγόρα, ταῦτα ἀποκρινόμενος;—ὡμολόγει.—ἴθι δὴ, ἔφην ἐγώ, εἰπὲ ἡμῖν, ἐπὶ τί λέγεις ἴτας εἶναι τοὺς ἀνδρείους; ἢ ἐφ' ἅπερ οἱ δειλοί;—οὐκ ἔφη.—οὐκοῦν ἐφ' ἕτερα.—ναί, ἦ δ' ὅς.—πότερον οἱ μὲν δειλοί ἐπὶ τὰ θαρραλέα ἔρχονται, οἱ δὲ ἀνδρεῖοι ἐπὶ τὰ δεινά;—λέγεται δὴ, ὦ Σώκρατες, οὕτως ὑπὸ τῶν ἀνθρώπων.—ἀληθῆ, ἔφην ἐγώ, λέγεις; ἀλλ' οὐ τοῦτο

359d

“That is true,” said I, “but I am not asking you that. I am asking what you say the courageous are impulsive towards. Are they impulsive towards the dreaded exploits in the belief that they should be dreaded, or towards exploits that need not be dreaded?”

359d

“Well,” he said, “this was demonstrated to be impossible just now by the arguments you presented.”

359d

“That is also true,” said I. “And so, if this demonstration was correct, no one embarks upon what in his view should be dreaded, since yielding to oneself was found to be ignorance.”

359d

He agreed.

ἐρωτῶ, ἀλλὰ σὺ ἐπὶ τί φῆς ἴτας εἶναι τοὺς ἀνδρείους; ἄρ' ἐπὶ τὰ δεινά, ἡγουμένους δεινὰ εἶναι, ἢ ἐπὶ τὰ μή;—ἀλλὰ τοῦτό γ', ἔφη, ἐν οἷς σὺ ἔλεγες τοῖς λόγοις ἀπεδείχθη ἄρτι ὅτι ἀδύνατον.—καὶ τοῦτο, ἔφην ἐγώ, ἀληθὲς λέγεις; ὥστ' εἰ τοῦτο ὁρθῶς ἀπεδείχθη, ἐπὶ μὲν ἃ δεινὰ ἡγεῖται εἶναι οὐδεὶς ἔρχεται, ἐπειδὴ τὸ ἥττω εἶναι ἑαυτοῦ ἡνέρεθη ἀμαθία οὕσα.

—ὡμολόγει.—ἀλλὰ μὴν ἐπὶ ᾧ γε θαρροῦσι πάντες αὖ ἔρχονται, καὶ δειλοὶ καὶ ἀνδρεῖοι, καὶ ταύτη γε ἐπὶ τὰ αὐτὰ

359e

“In that case, everyone, cowards and courageous alike, embark upon daring exploits, and in that respect anyway, both cowards and courageous go for the same things.”

359e

“And yet, Socrates,” he said, “what the cowards embark upon and what the courageous embark upon are completely opposite. For instance, the courageous are willing to go to war, while cowards are not.”

359e

“And is it noble to go or is it shameful?”

359e

“It is noble,” he replied.

359e

“Therefore, since it is noble, we have agreed previously that it is good, for we agreed that all noble actions are good.”

359e

“That is true,” he said, “and I am always of that view.”

ἔρχονται οἱ δειλοὶ τε καὶ οἱ ἀνδρεῖοι.—ἀλλὰ μέντοι, ἔφη, ὦ Σώκρατες, πᾶν γε τούναντίον ἐστὶν ἐπὶ ᾧ οἱ τε δειλοὶ ἔρχονται καὶ οἱ ἀνδρεῖοι. αὐτίκα εἰς τὸν πόλεμον οἱ μὲν ἐθέλουσιν ἰέναι, οἱ δὲ οὐκ ἐθέλουσιν.—πότερον, ἔφην ἐγώ, καλὸν ὃν ἰέναι ἢ αἰσχρόν;—καλόν, ἔφη.—οὐκοῦν εἴπερ καλόν, καὶ ἀγαθὸν ὡμολογήσαμεν ἐν τοῖς ἔμπροσθεν· τὰς γὰρ καλὰς πράξεις ἀπάσας ἀγαθὰς ὡμολογήσαμεν.—ἀληθῆ λέγεις, καὶ αἰεὶ ἔμοιγε δοκεῖ οὕτως.— ΣΩ. ὁρθῶς γε, ἔφην ἐγώ.

360a

“You are right about that anyway,” said I. “But which of them are you saying is unwilling to go to war, although it is noble and good?”

360a

“The cowards,” he replied.

360a

“And since it is noble and good, isn’t it also pleasant?”

360a

“Well, that is what has been agreed,” he replied.

360a

“So, are the cowards knowingly unwilling to go to what is nobler, better and more pleasant?”

360a

“But if we agree to this as well,” he replied, “we are undermining what we agreed previously.”

360a

“And what about the courageous?” I asked. “Don’t they go to the nobler, the better and the more pleasant?”

360a

“It is necessary to agree,” he replied.

ἀλλὰ ποτέρους φῆς εἰς τὸν πόλεμον οὐκ ἐθέλγειν ἰέναι, καλὸν ὃν καὶ ἀγαθόν;—τοὺς δειλοὺς, ἧ δ’ ὅς.—οὐκοῦν, ἦν δ’ ἐγώ, εἴπερ καλὸν καὶ ἀγαθόν, καὶ ἡδύ;—ὡμολόγηται γοῦν, ἔφη.—ἄρ’ οὖν γινώσκοντες οἱ δειλοὶ οὐκ ἐθέλουσιν ἰέναι ἐπὶ τὸ κάλλιον τε καὶ ἄμεινον καὶ ἥδιον;—ἀλλὰ καὶ τοῦτο ἂν ὁμολογῶμεν, ἔφη, διαφθεροῦμεν τὰς ἔμπροσθεν ὁμολογίας.—τί δ’ ὁ ἀνδρεῖος; οὐκ ἐπὶ τὸ κάλλιον τε καὶ ἄμεινον καὶ ἥδιον ἔρχεται;—ἀνάγκη, ἔφη, ὁμολογεῖν.—οὐκοῦν ὅλως οἱ

360b

“Now, on the whole, when courageous people are afraid, their fears are not disgraceful, are they?

360b

Nor is their daring any disgrace either, is it?”

360b

“That is true,” he said.

360b

“And if they are not disgraceful, aren’t they noble?”

360b

He agreed.

360b

“And if they are noble, are they good?”

360b

“Yes.”

360b

“And the cowards, the insolent and the madmen, aren’t their fears, by contrast, disgraceful? And isn’t their daring disgraceful too?”

360b

He agreed.

360b

“And is their daring disgraceful and bad because of anything else except folly and ignorance?”

ἀνδρεῖοι οὐκ αἰσχροὺς φόβους φοβοῦνται, ὅταν φοβῶνται, οὐδὲ αἰσchrά θάρρη θαρροῦσιν;—ἀληθῆ, ἔφη.—εἰ δὲ μὴ αἰσchrά, ἄρ’ οὐ καλά;—ὡμολόγει.—εἰ δὲ καλά, καὶ ἀγαθά;—ναί.—οὐκοῦν καὶ οἱ δειλοὶ καὶ οἱ θρασεῖς καὶ οἱ μαινόμενοι τοῦναντίον αἰσchrοὺς τε φόβους φοβοῦνται καὶ αἰσchrά θάρρη θαρροῦσιν;—ὡμολόγει.—θαρροῦσιν δὲ τὰ αἰσchrά καὶ κακὰ δι’ ἄλλο τι ἢ δι’ ἄγνοιαν καὶ ἀμαθίαν;—οὕτως

360c

“That is the case,” he said.

360c

“Well then, do you refer to that because of which cowards are cowards, as cowardice or courage?”

360c

“I call it cowardice,” he replied.

360c

“And didn’t it turn out that they are cowards because of ignorance of what should be dreaded?”

360c

“Certainly,” he replied.

360c

“So, are they cowards because of this ignorance?”

360c

He agreed.

360c

“And you agree that they are cowards because of cowardice?”

360c

He concurred.

360c

“Therefore, would ignorance of what should be dreaded and not dreaded be cowardice?”

360c

He nodded his head.

ἔχει, ἔφη.—τί οὖν; τοῦτο δι’ ὃ δειλοί εἰσιν οἱ δειλοί, δειλίαν ἢ ἀνδρείαν καλεῖς;—δειλίαν ἔγωγ’, ἔφη.—δειλοὶ δὲ οὐ διὰ τὴν τῶν δεινῶν ἀμαθίαν ἐφάνησαν ὄντες;—πάνυ γ’, ἔφη.—διὰ ταύτην ἄρα τὴν ἀμαθίαν δειλοί εἰσιν;—ὠμολόγει.—δι’ ὃ δὲ δειλοί εἰσιν, δειλία ὁμολογεῖται παρὰ σοῦ;—συνέφη.—οὐκοῦν ἢ τῶν δεινῶν καὶ μὴ δεινῶν ἀμαθία δειλία ἂν εἴη;—ἐπένευσε.—ἀλλὰ μήν, ἦν δ’ ἐγώ, ἐναντίον

360d

“And yet,” said I, “courage is the opposite of cowardice.”

360d

He agreed.

360d

“Now, isn’t wisdom, in relation to what should be dreaded and not dreaded, the opposite of the ignorance thereof?”

360d

He still nodded his head at this too.

360d

“And ignorance of these is cowardice?”

360d

At this point he nodded with extreme reluctance.

360d

“So, is courage wisdom, wisdom in relation to what should be dreaded and not dreaded, since it is the opposite of the ignorance thereof?”

360d

He was no longer even prepared to nod at this stage, and he kept quiet. And I went on to say, “What is this, Protagoras? Will you not answer my question one way or the other?”

360d

“Finish it yourself,” he said.

ἀνδρεία δειλία.—ἔφη.—οὐκοῦν ἡ τῶν δεινῶν καὶ μὴ δεινῶν σοφία ἐναντία τῇ τούτων ἀμαθία ἐστίν;—καὶ ἐνταῦθα ἔτι ἐπένευσεν.—ἡ δὲ τούτων ἀμαθία δειλία;—πάνυ μόγεις ἐνταῦθα ἐπένευσεν.—ἡ σοφία ἄρα τῶν δεινῶν καὶ μὴ δεινῶν ἀνδρεία ἐστίν, ἐναντία οὖσα τῇ τούτων ἀμαθία;—οὐκέτι ἐνταῦθα οὐτ’ ἐπινεῦσαι ἠθέλησεν ἐσίγα τε.—καὶ ἐγὼ εἶπον· τί δή, ὦ Πρωταγόρα, οὔτε σὺ φῆς ἃ ἐρωτῶ οὔτε ἀπόφης;—αὐτός, ἔφη, πέραντον.—ἔν γ’, ἔφην ἐγώ, μόνον

360e

“I have only one question left to ask you. Does it still seem to you, as it did at the outset, that there are some people who are completely ignorant and yet utterly courageous?”

360e

“Socrates,” he said, “you seem to have a thirst for victory. You want me as your respondent, so, to gratify you, I say that from what has been agreed, that seems impossible to me.”

ἐρόμενος ἔτι σέ, εἴ σοι ὥσπερ τὸ πρῶτον ἔτι δοκοῦσιν εἶναί τινες ἄνθρωποι ἀμαθέστατοι μέν, ἀνδρειότατοι δέ.—φιλονικεῖν μοι, ἔφη, δοκεῖς, ὦ Σώκρατες, τὸ ἐμὲ εἶναι τὸν ἀποκρινόμενον· χαριοῦμαι οὖν σοι, καὶ λέγω ὅτι ἐκ τῶν ὠμολογημένων ἀδύνατόν μοι δοκεῖ εἶναι. οὗτοι, ἦν δ’ ἐγώ, ἄλλου ἔνεκα ἐρωτῶ πάντα ταῦτα ἢ σκέψασθαι βουλόμενος πῶς ποτ’ ἔχει τὰ περὶ τῆς ἀρετῆς καὶ τί ποτ’ ἐστὶν αὐτό, ἡ ἀρετή. ΣΩ. οἶδα γὰρ ὅτι τούτου φανεροῦ

361a

“I am not,” said I, “asking you all these questions from any other motive than a wish to investigate how exactly matters stand in relation to excellence, and what precisely this is, this excellence. For I know that once this has become obvious, the issue on which you and I have each made such long-drawn-out speeches – you claiming that excellence can be taught, me saying that it cannot – would best be clarified.

γενομένου μάλιστ' ἂν κατάδηλον γένοιτο ἐκεῖνο περὶ οὗ ἐγὼ τε καὶ σὺ μακρὸν λόγον ἐκάτερος ἀπετείναμεν, ἐγὼ μὲν λέγων ὡς οὐ διδακτὸν ἀρετῇ, σὺ δ' ὡς διδακτόν. καὶ μοι δοκεῖ ἡμῶν ἡ ἄρτι ἔξοδος τῶν λόγων ὥσπερ ἄνθρωπος κατηγορεῖν τε καὶ καταγελαῖν, καὶ εἰ φωνὴν λάβοι, εἰπεῖν ἂν ὅτι ἄτοποί γ' ἐστέ, ὧ Σώκρατες τε καὶ Πρωταγόρα· σὺ μὲν λέγων ὅτι οὐ διδακτὸν ἐστὶν ἀρετῇ ἐν τοῖς ἔμπροσθεν, νῦν σεαυτῷ τάναντία

361b

“And it seems to me as if the recent outcome of our discussions is just like a person, accusing us and mocking us, and if it were to take on a voice it would say, ‘Socrates and Protagoras, how strange you are! You, Socrates, who were saying earlier that excellence is not teachable, are now, in eager opposition to yourself, trying to demonstrate that all sorts of things are knowledge – justice, self-control, courage. But that is the best way to show that excellence can be taught. For if excellence was anything else except knowledge, as Protagoras attempted to assert, it would clearly be unteachable. But if excellence now turns out to be knowledge wholly, as you are so eager to prove, Socrates, it will be a wonder if it is not teachable. Protagoras, for his part, who was then proposing that it is teachable, now seems keen to make the opposite case, that excellence has turned out to be almost anything at all rather than knowledge. And on this view, it would hardly be teachable.’

σπεύδεις, ἐπιχειρῶν ἀποδείξαι ὡς πάντα χρήματ' ἐστὶν ἐπιστήμη, καὶ ἡ δικαιοσύνη καὶ σωφροσύνη καὶ ἡ ἀνδρεία, ὧ τρόπῳ μάλιστ' ἂν διδακτὸν φανείη ἡ ἀρετῇ. εἰ μὲν γὰρ ἄλλο τι ἦν ἢ ἐπιστήμη ἡ ἀρετῇ,

ὥσπερ Πρωταγόρας ἐπεχείρει λέγειν, σαφῶς οὐκ ἂν ἦν διδασκόν· νῦν δὲ εἰ φανήσεται ἐπιστήμη ὅλον, ὥς σὺ σπεύδεις, ὦ Σώκρατες, θαυμάσιον ἔσται μὴ διδασκόν ὄν. Πρωταγόρας δ' αὖ διδασκόν τότε ὑποθέμενος, νῦν τούναντίον ἔοικεν σπεύδοντι ὀλίγου πάντα μᾶλλον φανῆναι αὐτὸ ἢ ἐπιστήμην· καὶ οὕτως ἂν ἦκιστα εἴη διδασκόν. ἐγὼ οὖν, ὦ Πρωταγόρα, πάντα ταῦτα καθορῶν ἄνω κάτω ταραττόμενα δεινῶς, πᾶσαν προθυμίαν ἔχω καταφανῇ αὐτὰ γενέσθαι, καὶ βουλοίμην ἂν ταῦτα διεξελθόντας ἡμᾶς ἐξελεθεῖν καὶ ἐπὶ τὴν ἀρετὴν ὅτι ἔστιν, καὶ πάλιν ἐπισκέψασθαι περὶ αὐτοῦ εἴτε διδασκόν εἴτε μὴ διδασκόν, μὴ πολλακίς ἡμᾶς ὁ Ἐπιμηθεὺς ἐκεῖνος καὶ ἐν τῇ σκέψει

361d

“Now, Protagoras, when I behold all these matters in such terrible disarray, I am most eager to have them properly clarified. And once we have been through them all, I would like us also to tackle the question of what excellence is and then come back to investigate whether it is teachable or not. This is in case Epimetheus might also trip us up here, and trick us, just as he did when he overlooked humanity in the story you told us about the distribution of gifts. Now, in that story, Prometheus pleased me more than Epimetheus. So, having recourse to him, displaying forethought in relation to my entire life, I occupy myself with all of these matters. And if you are willing, as I said at the outset, I would be delighted to investigate them comprehensively along with you.”

σφήλῃ ἐξαπατήσας, ὥσπερ καὶ ἐν τῇ διανομῇ ἡμέλησεν ἡμῶν, ὥς φης σύ. ἤρεσεν οὖν μοι καὶ ἐν τῷ μύθῳ ὁ Προμηθεὺς μᾶλλον τοῦ Ἐπιμηθέως ὃ χρώμενος ἐγὼ καὶ προμηθεύμενος ὑπὲρ τοῦ βίου τοῦ ἐμαυτοῦ παντὸς πάντα ταῦτα πραγματεύομαι, καὶ εἰ σὺ ἐθέλεις, ὅπερ καὶ κατ' ἀρχὰς ἔλεγον, μετὰ σοῦ ἂν ἥδιστα ταῦτα συνδιασκοποιήν. καὶ ὁ Πρωταγόρας, ἐγὼ μὲν, ἔφη, ὦ Σώκρατες, ἐπαινώ σου τὴν προθυμίαν καὶ τὴν διέξοδον τῶν λόγων. καὶ γὰρ οὕτε

361e

And Protagoras replied, “Socrates, I can only praise your eagerness and the way you concluded the argument. In fact, I do not think I am, in

any sense, a bad person, and I am the least envious of men, since I have actually said to many people that I admire you much more than anyone else I have met, and far more than anyone else of your age. And I say that I would not be surprised if you were to join the ranks of men who are highly regarded for their wisdom. We shall go over these issues on another occasion, whenever you wish, but it is time now to turn to something else.”

τᾶλλα οἶμαι κακὸς εἶναι ἄνθρωπος, φθονερός τε ἥκιστ' ἀνθρώπων, ἐπεὶ καὶ περὶ σοῦ πρὸς πολλοὺς δὴ εἶρηκα ὅτι ὦν ἐντυγχάνω πολὺ μάλιστα ἄγαμαι σέ, τῶν μὲν τηλικούτων καὶ πάνυ· καὶ λέγω γε ὅτι οὐκ ἂν θαυμάζοιμι εἰ τῶν ἐλλογίμων γένοιο ἀνδρῶν ἐπὶ σοφίᾳ. καὶ περὶ τούτων δὲ εἰς αὐθις, ὅταν βούλῃ, διέξιμεν· νῦν δ' ὥρα ἤδη καὶ ἐπ' ἄλλο τι τρέπεσθαι.

362a

“Well,” said I, “if that is how it seems to you, that is what must be done. In fact, it was time for me to depart a while ago for that appointment I mentioned, but I stayed in order to oblige the noble Callias.”

362a

Having said all this and heard all this, we departed.

ΣΩ. ἀλλ', ἦν δ' ἐγώ, οὕτω χρή ποιεῖν, εἴ σοι δοκεῖ. καὶ γὰρ ἐμοὶ οἷπερ ἔφην ἰέναι πάλαι ὥρα, ἀλλὰ Καλλία τῷ καλῷ χαριζόμενος παρέμεινα. ταῦτ' εἰπόντες καὶ ἀκούσαντες ἀπῆμεν.

Notes

¹ Alcibiades, the son of Clinias, was a famous and notorious politician and general, and a close associate of Socrates.

² *Iliad* xxiv.348, *Odyssey* x.279.

³ Abdera was a flourishing Greek city in Thrace, on the north coast of the Aegean.

⁴ Protagoras of Abdera was an influential sophist and teacher of rhetoric.

⁵ The Hippocrates mentioned here is known only from this dialogue.

⁶ Callias was the son of the richest man in Greece, Hipponicus. He squandered the fortune he inherited, but remained active in Athenian political life.

⁷ Hippias was a diplomat, polymath and a famous and successful sophist.

⁸ Prodicus of Ceos was a contemporary of Socrates. Plato often mentions him and his insistence on the correct use of words.

⁹ The six men mentioned were prominent Athenians between the ages of 17 and 27. Paralus and Xanthippus were the sons of Pericles, Athens' leading statesman. Pericles' first wife later married Callias' father. Charmides was Plato's maternal uncle, who was eventually associated with the Thirty Tyrants. He is immortalised in Plato's eponymous dialogue. Philippides came from a wealthy family. Nothing more is known about Antimoerus.

¹⁰ Orpheus, the mythical singer, charmed not only rational beings, but also birds, fish, wild beasts, trees and rocks.

¹¹ *Odyssey* xi.601.

¹² Both Eryximachus, who was a physician, and his friend Phaedrus are speakers in Plato's *Symposium*. Phaedrus is also depicted in the dialogue that bears his name. Andron was a politician.

¹³ *Odyssey* xi.582.

¹⁴ Pausanias and Agathon, a successful tragedian, were long-term lovers who eventually left Athens to live in Macedonia. Adimantus, son of Cepis, is unknown, but assumed to be an Athenian. Adimantus, son of Leucolophides, was an Athenian general.

¹⁵ Critias was a member of the oligarchic party and leader of the Thirty Tyrants.

¹⁶ The instrument referred to here, the *aulos*, was a single-reeded instrument like a clarinet, or a double-reeded one like an oboe.

¹⁷ Aripheon is the brother of Pericles.

¹⁸ Prometheus was the champion and benefactor of mankind to whom he gave fire. His name means 'forethought'. Epimetheus is his brother, and his name means 'afterthought'.

¹⁹ The Lenaean festival of Dionysus was celebrated in Athens, with contests chiefly in comedy.

²⁰ In Attic comedy and oratory, these two figures served as paradigms of unscrupulous deceit.

²¹ Pittacus was ruler of Mytilene in Lesbos and was counted among the Seven Sages.

²² *Iliad* xxi.308-9.

²³ Hesiod, *Works and Days* 289-292.

²⁴ This is a complete list of the Seven Sages of Greece who were famous teachers, lawmakers and revered thinkers.

²⁵ *Iliad* x.224.